Welcome to Barizad

Friday, June 20, 2025 10:53 AM

A player's guide to the fractured world of fate and flame

What Is Barizad?

Barizad is a setting of ancient ruins, shifting destinies, and high-stakes exploration.

Barizad is a world unraveling. Once, a city hung above the world like a second sun—a gleaming metropolis of flame and brass known as *Zahr al-Narās*, the Brass City. It was ruled not by kings or gods, but by the Dahrin, an elite caste of efreeti who wielded fire, magic, and the divine authority to shape reality itself.

Through the Celestine Furnace, the efreeti did not merely foresee the future—they *wrote it*. Mortal destinies were hammered like copper sheets, each soul etched with purpose, place, and ending. The efreeti called it order. Others called it bondage.

But power breeds ambition. At the height of their dominion, the greatest among them—Sirr al-Nar, called the Flame Undimmed—attempted to seal fate forever, locking prophecy behind unbreakable brass and burning the final future into the furnace.

Something broke. The City fell.

Not just from the sky, but from time itself. Its collapse tore through the fabric of the world, fragmenting history, unraveling destiny, and warping reality in every corner of the earth. Now, across Barizad, shards of the fallen City lie half-buried in the sand or suspended in impossible rifts. These are the *Fragments*—echoes of the Brazen Order of Zahr al-Narās, each one a dungeon of broken time and forgotten prophecy.

Within them lie dream-gems, crystalized remnants of the world's lost future. To hold one is to hold a piece of reality as it was meant to be. To use one is to risk everything.

Barizad is a land of fire-blasted deserts, prophetic ruins, and splintered truth. Warlords, cults, scholars, and scavengers all chase the fragments—some seek to reinstate the Brazen Order, some to claim its power for their own, and some simply to burn it down completely.

You are one of them.

Major Themes

- **Fractured Fate**: Reality no longer moves in a straight line. Expect time-loops, memory loss, doppelgangers, and prophetic dreams.

- **Philosophical Conflict**: Every culture in Barizad has its own idea of what "should" be. Who defines the future: fate, worldly order, or ambition itself?

- **Heroic Opportunity**: You are not just a traveler. You are part of something larger—a tide of forces clashing over the future.

Factions of the World

These are the major cultures and powers that shape Barizad. You may belong to one—or clash with

them.

Aram-Zaneth
Ash-cloaked prophets and zealous martyrs who see reject the Brazen Order believing instead in the power of esoteric knowledge and personal ambition to define fate.

The Myrian Halls
Star-gazing theocracies built on ancestral lineages and sky-born relics. Visionary kings here dream of restoring Brazen Order.

The Satrapies of Varnash
Warlike principalities bound together by reverence for *True Brass*, a magical alloy resistant to divine influence. Flamboyant, boisterous, and proud.

Emerald Courts of Ta'ren
Occult-obsessed nobles and masked priestesses, descended from those who once served the City. Some seek redemption; others, control.

The Thalassocracy of Nisarun
A chain of independent ports, pirate havens, and trade hubs. Everything has a price—including fate.

The Zifari Tribes
Bedouin story-tellers who thrive where others fear to tread. They serve as guides, interpreters, and spirit-walkers across the dream-touched wastelands, skirting the edges of Brass Fragments and whispering roads where reality frays.

The Flame Undimmed
Zealots loyal to Sirr al-Nar, the fallen lord of the Brass City. They want to restart the Celestine Furnace—and rule what's left.

The Dream-Gems

Each dream-gem contains a **true prophecy**: a moment of certainty from before the Fall. These are the most sought-after treasures in the world.

When returned to the ruins of the Brass City—especially the **Celestine Furnace**—they may slow the unraveling of time or reshape it to suit the bearer's desires.

But every gem also tempts. To use one is to alter fate itself: a dangerous enterprise for even the wise.

What Can I Play?

You can build your character using standard D&D 3.5e rules, but Barizad emphasizes flavor and motivation.

Think about:

- **Origin**: Which culture or region are you from? Do you align with their goals or rebel against them?
- **Beliefs**: What do you think caused the Fall? What would you do if you could rewrite the future?
- **Why You Adventure**: Are you a treasure hunter? A scholar? A prophet seeking answers? A killer running from your past?

Custom Player Options:

- **New domains**: Dream, Brass, Fate, Reckoning, etc.
- **Setting-specific races**: Ifriqa (fiery-blooded humans), Nimari (river-folk of the Halls), Brazen (forged beings with fractured memories).
- **Fragment Boons**: Rare benefits from surviving exposure to unstable reality within a Fragment Dungeon.

Gameplay Expectations

This campaign blends exploration, mystery, and moral decision-making. Players will:

- Delve **Fragment Dungeons**, warped relics of the Brass City
- Interact with **philosophical and political factions**
- Discover **dream-gems** and decide how (or if) to use them
- Face enemies that defy time and reason
- Shape the future—or watch it collapse

Combat will occur, but it's not always the solution. Some foes can't be killed. Some puzzles can't be solved with brute force. And some victories carry a price.

Final Thought

This is a world on the edge. Hope survives only because some dare to find it in the ashes of the past.

Will you preserve the old ways, forge a new path, or let the world fall?

Welcome to **Barizad**.

The Vault of the False Caliph

Friday, June 6, 2025 11:56 PM

Based on: *The Tale of the False Caliph*

Location: Beneath a ruined oasis city, partially buried in sand

Theme: Identity collapse, impersonation, fractured memory

Premise:
A brass observatory that once charted destinies now flickers between timelines. A powerful figure claiming to be the "Rightful Caliph" rules inside, his followers mindless reflections echoing his delusion. The vault generates false versions of people—duplicates of the PCs, NPCs, or even historical figures—who argue over who is real.

Dungeon Features:
- Memory loops and distorted dialogue trees
- Mirror-clones of the PCs as boss encounters
- A prophecy-gem at the center, locked behind a trial of truth versus certainty

The Singing Sands

Saturday, June 7, 2025 12:06 AM

Dungeon Concept: A wind-blown ruin filled with the voices of lost wanderers. The sands themselves sing riddles and truths, blocking or guiding passage.

Dungeon Highlights:

- Dunes whisper puzzles and misdirection
- Players must answer riddles or lose their way

Dream-Gem: *The Memory of Wind* – a song once meant to guide but now to mislead

Rooms

1. <u>Entryway</u>
    a. Description: The party enters a sandstone-walled room. The walls are high (about 15ft) and the ground has a thin layer of sand blown-in from outside. There are two torches, one on each side wall, that provide light (one wonders if they are magical and never go-out). Opposite the party as they enter, there is a large smooth stone door on the far wall flanked on either side by a decorative obelisk. The room is also filled with a great many crates each open and filled to the brim with a variety of assorted mundate household and agricultural items: rope, candles, plates, taxidermized beasts including a viper, a desert fox, an impressively. Large scarab beetle, a horned lizard, and a carrion bird of some esoteric variety. In the middle of the room, a single leatherbound book rests open on the floor (as if placed there on purpose).

    b. The book is open to a page with the following text written in flowing calligraphy:
    "The key you seek is here somewhere.
    Do not be so hasty or look past what's right there.
    We all have one.
    Some big, some small, some long and tall,
    and even when it's stuffed it can run."
        i. The rest of the book is blank pages, it's cover is also blank

    c. The answer to the riddle is "your nose".
        i. The 1st PC to even suggest this immediately feels a strong impulse to sneeze which soon overpowers them.
        ii. Sneezing in this way causes a small key to fly out of the sneezer's nose; this is the key to the door
        iii. The crates and everything in them are non-magical red herrings

2. <u>The False Desert</u>
    a. Upon passing through the stone door in the Entryway, the party finds themselves in a vast desert expanse—open sky, blazing sun, and rippling dunes. There is no sign of walls or a ceiling, even though this must logically be inside the fragment.

    Time feels warped. The sun never moves. The wind never stops. Somewhere, distant voices sing in harmony or agony.

    b. The PCs can choose to journey through the desert. The only way to find the "exit" is to:
        i. First become lost by travelling in any direction away from the entrance for a few hours.

ii. Make the willful decision to back-track to the entrance.
iii. Find that the entrance is no longer the entrance but instead has become the way forward.

c. There are several encounters to be found in the desert; every 1-2 hours of travel one of the following should happen:
   i. Whispers in the Dunes: PCs hear voices that sound like old friends or lost loved ones; Will save (DC 16) to resist the urge to run-off alone towards the voices. If a player fails, spring a random encounter on them with a surprise round.
   ii. Random Encounter:
      1) 1 Belker
      2) 1 Basilisk and 2 Thoqqua
      3) 2d3 Monstrous Scorpions (Large)
      4) 1d4+1 Howlers
      5) 1d4+1 Dust Mephit
      6) 1d6+2 Thoqqua
   iii. Mirage Puzzle: PCs arrive at a 4-way paved crossroads in the middle of the desert. Each path has an obelisk beside it with the same inscription:
   "*I am the path you always walk,*
   Though never set in stone.
   I start and end where you began,
   Yet leave you far from home.
   To find me is to lose your way—
   To leave me, know your own."
   This is a hint to the PCs to go back the way they came

3. <u>Gate to Sphinx's Layer</u>
   a. Description: The floor of this room is constructed of large flagstones. Seven of these flagstones are carved with individual runic markings; the rest are bare. An engraving in a strange runic script, similar to those on the flagstones themselves, covers much of the west wall.

   b. Mechanics: The seven marked flagstones are arranged in no discernable pattern around the room. Each flagstone bears one of the seven smbols from the following group: (see TGBOTPAD for inscription)

   c. Each of the flagstones is a pressure plate that activates when at least 30lbs of pressure is applied. The party will feel these pressure plates activate when they step on the flagstones OR a successful Search or Spot check (DC 15) reveals their nature without stepping on them.

   d. When the pressure plates are activated in the correct order the door opens. The key to determining the correct order can be found in the inscription on the west wall. It looks like this: (see TGBOTPAD for inscription)

   e. If the pressure plates are activated in the incorrect order they reset and a trap is sprung: each player within 10ft of any of the flagstones must make a Reflex save (DC 16) or suffer 20 (5d8) lightning damage on a failed save; half damage on a successful save.

4. <u>Sphinx's Layer</u>:
   a. Use the ANDROSPHINX from the MM
   b. As the final rune-lock clicks into place, the air shudders. The oppressive hum of the wind dies instantly.

A seam splits down the far wall, and ancient stone grinds open like the yawning jaws of something old and wise. A warm, dry wind escapes the chamber beyond, thick with the scent of incense, dust, and old blood.

Beyond lies a vast, echoing chamber carved from solid sandstone. The walls are etched with forgotten hieroglyphs and half-buried memories—some glowing faintly, others scrubbed away by claw or time.

At its center, upon a raised dais of polished obsidian, reclines the Sphinx. His leonine body sprawls with effortless majesty, wings folded like judgment held in reserve.

His face—half divine, half monstrous—studies you without blinking.

Around him, the wind swirls slowly, not in circles, but in runes, as if the air itself dares not speak without her permission.

He does not rise. He does not smile.

Instead, he speaks in a voice that does not echo, but seems to already be inside your head:
"I sing but have no throat.
I remember, but have no mind.
I build your steps and erase them after.
What am I?"

c. The answer to this riddle is "the wind" or "the desert itself". If the PCs guess this, their prize is the desert. If they fail to guess it they are attacked. The Sphinx knows the only way out is through him and is just toying with the party.

Rewards

1. Treasure:
   a. **Coins**: 60pp, 190gp, 1800sp, 15k cp
   b. **Art Objects**:
      i. Jade game board with ivory pieces (250 gp)
      ii. Painted ceramic death mask (750 gp)
      iii. Antique wind instrument etched with runes (250 gp)
   c. **Magic Items**:
      i. +1 Shield or Armor (relevant to at least one PC)
      ii. +1 Weapon (relevant to at least one PC)
      iii. Potion of Cure Moderate Wounds
      iv. Dust of Tracelessness

2. Dream Gem: The Memory of Wind
   a. **Effect**: While carrying this gem, you gain a +2 bonus on Listen and Survival checks, and you may ignore difficult terrain caused by natural winds or sand.
      Once per day, you may cast *Feather Fall* or *Gust of Wind* (DC 14) as a spell-like ability.

   b. **Drawback**: Your voice occasionally echoes ahead of you, as if you are not entirely present in time.
      i. You take –2 penalty on Bluff checks.
      ii. If you speak a falsehood, you involuntarily whisper the truth 6 seconds later unless you succeed on a DC 15 Will save.

The Sea of Mirrors

Saturday, June 7, 2025 12:06 AM

Based on: Original concept

Dungeon Concept: An impossible lake of still, reflective mercury. Drifting islands move like thoughts. The PCs' beliefs alter the fabric of the dungeon.

Dungeon Highlights:

- Illusions become real if player's believe they're real
- A magical telescope floats in the air, observing intruders

Dream-Gem: *Reflexive Destiny*

The Golden Rider

Saturday, June 7, 2025 12:08 AM

Based on: *The Tale of the Ebony Horse*

Dungeon Concept: A warped remnant of the Brass City's war-stables. Brass steeds roam, and a war-ifrit still clings to duty and purity of prophecy.

Dungeon Highlights:

- Construct steeds with unstable AI; ride or disable
- Final boss: General Safraz atop a flaming brass nightmare

Dream-Gem: *The Loyalty That Outlived Kings*

The Crimson Pit

Saturday, June 7, 2025 12:09 AM

Based on: *The Tale of the Three Apples*

Dungeon Concept: A gladiator vault once used for efreeti amusement, now corrupted by fire-beasts and haunted champions.

Dungeon Highlights:

- Arena structure with escalating combat trials
- Between rounds, party enters dream-arenas that affect the waking fight
- Final boss: *Amarion, the Ruby Hound*—a mutated undead beast-druid

Dream-Gem: *The Hunger for Justice*

The Atrium of the Threefold Wish

Saturday, June 7, 2025 12:10 AM

Based on: *The Fisherman and the Djinn*

Dungeon Concept: A broken atrium of the Brass City where wishes—once refined like alchemical gold—now fester in warped crucibles. The dungeon tempts, grants, and twists the desires of all who enter.

Dungeon Highlights:

- At the entrance, each PC is offered one "true wish" by a bound relic—but consequences are delayed, hidden, or ironic
- Rooms reflect distorted versions of players' stated goals, creating bespoke enemies, illusions, or boons
- The central chamber contains the *Well of Wanting*, where the party must choose whether to extract the Dream-Gem… at a price

Final Encounter:

- *Zhadir the Ungranted*, a genie-phantasm fused from centuries of incomplete or revoked wishes, seeks to "complete" the party's desires—whether they want it or not

Dream-Gem: *The Desire That Could Not Die*

The Bed of the Sleeper-King

Friday, June 6, 2025 11:57 PM

Based on: *The Tale of the Sleeper and the Waker*

Location: A fallen brass spire lying on its side in a deep jungle

Theme: Stasis vs awakening, fate deferred, slumbering catastrophe

Premise:
Inside the tilted halls of this fallen fragment lies a **sleeping efreet prince**, surrounded by time-locked servants. His dreams shape reality: the dungeon changes based on what part of his dream is dominant. The PCs must wake or kill him—but doing so may trigger the return of a major threat.

Dungeon Features:

- Rooms shift when players sleep, rest, or cast dream-related magic
- Dream-gem protected by paradoxical guardians: awake but unaware, or asleep and hostile
- Final chamber: battle in shifting dream-states, with fate dice dictating terrain or initiative order

The Maze of Weeping Brass

Friday, June 6, 2025 11:58 PM

Based on: *The Tale of the Three Apples*

Location: A submerged labyrinth beneath a fractured coastal ruin

Theme: Tragedy, consequence, repetition

Premise:
A vault once used to weigh divine judgments replays a single crime endlessly. The PCs must follow clues through a murder-mystery while brass ghosts relive the tragedy, becoming increasingly aware of their loop. The dream-gem is hidden inside the heart of the victim—or the killer.

Dungeon Features:

- Ghosts trapped in emotional routines (investigation and roleplay focus)
- Waterlogged rooms where guilt and sorrow manifest as physical hazards
- Boss fight: a brass inquisitor animated by conflicting verdicts

The Observatory of the Starless Astrologer

Friday, June 6, 2025 11:59 PM

Based on: *The Tale of the Astrologer Who Fell Into a Cistern*

Location: A shattered observatory vault suspended in a gravity-warped ravine

Theme: Misinterpretation, hubris, divine irony

Premise:
An ancient astrologer sought to chart all possible futures—but now his shattered observatory projects contradictory constellations and fate-paths. The dungeon cycles through false "prophetic" outcomes, each a mini-zone with challenges based on alternate destinies. The astrologer's fractured soul animates a giant brass orrery at the center, and must be confronted or re-aligned.

Dungeon Features:
- Prophetic illusions: players experience fake "futures"
- Star-tracking puzzle requiring correct planetary alignment
- Final chamber rotates during combat, altering time flow and spell durations

The Bazaar of Mind and Hours

Saturday, June 7, 2025 12:00 AM

Based on: *The Tale of the Porter's Bargain* and general bazaar tales

Location: A fragment of the Grand Market of Zahr al-Narās, stuck in a permanent twilight

Theme: Desire, consequence, transactional destiny

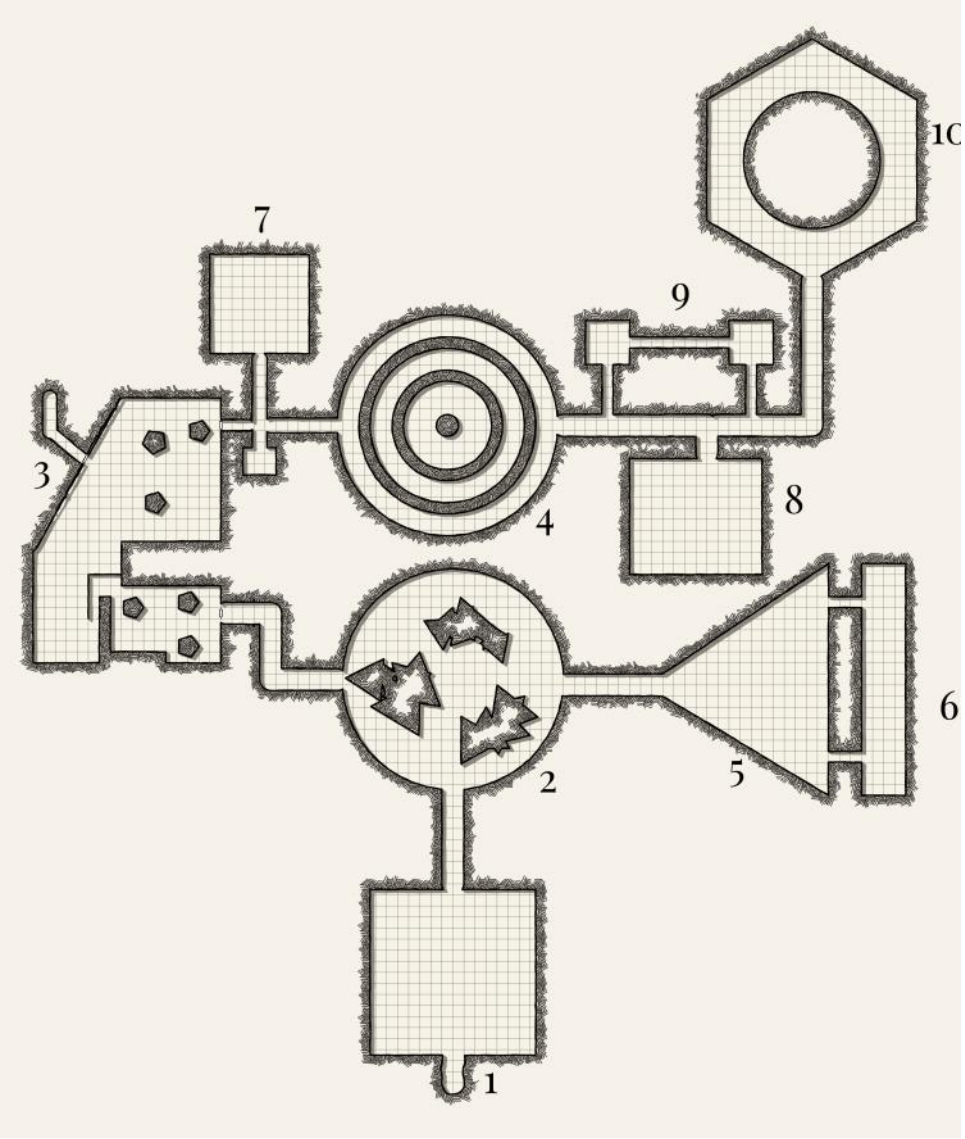
Premise:
This dungeon appears as a bizarre, living bazaar where time is currency and memory is sold. Merchants offer wondrous magical items in exchange for future deeds or past decisions. The PCs must navigate shifting stalls, misleading contracts, and cursed wares to retrieve a prophecy-gem that no one remembers owning.

Dungeon Features:

- “Contract” encounters: magical trades alter the party’s future
- Time loop room: one decision must be replayed until “truth” is chosen
- Final encounter: an incarnate debt-collector composed of forgotten promises

Map

Friday, June 13, 2025 11:50 PM



Random Encounters

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If the PCs try to rest anywhere other than in rooms 5 or 7 roll for a random encounter:

d8	Encounter	EL
1	**Invisible Stalker (2)** — Summoned long ago and never released, these fate-bound spirits wander still.	10
2	**Salamander, Noble** — One of the last true servants of the Brass City's flamebound vaults.	11
3	**Golem, Iron** — A damaged but active guardian on a repeating patrol loop.	12
4	**Elemental, Huge Fire** — Stirs from a nearby rift in the vault-floor when magic is used during rest.	11
5	**Formian Taskmaster (1) + 2 Formian Warriors** — Relic agents of order, mistaking the PCs for rogue drones.	10
6	**Vrock (2)** — Teleported in from a failed planar containment array, they claw at reality as much as at the party.	11
7	**Efreeti (1)** — Appears in a shimmer of heat and dust, assuming the party are thieves.	10
8	**Devourer** — A horror drawn to the soul-energy of the dreaming, its ribcage alight with a prisoner from a failed timeline.	12

1. The Ecliptic Gate (EL 3)

Wednesday, June 11, 2025 9:38 PM

1. Description
    a. The room is spartan and narrow.

    b. In the center of the far wall is a simple pillar made of pure brass

    c. The pillar has two hand-shaped imprints carved into the side (but made for much larger than human hands)

2. Mechanics
    a. Placing one's hand into the indents the far wall is revealed to be illusory

    b. An archway is revealed; the doorway beneath is sealed by a slab of pure brass

    c. Inscribed on the brass door is the following (in Celestial):

    In darkness it starts and in darkness it ends.
    It burns as it rises and as it descends.
    The in-between places glow warmly, you know,
    But not like the apex, the highest it goes
    Follow its path as it travels above, From start until finish, all colors thereof.

    d. On the pillar 11 crystal orbs seem to appear:
        i. 2 Dark Purple
        ii. 2 Red
        iii. 2 Orange
        iv. 2 Green
        v. 2 Blue
        vi. 1 Yellow

    e. A successful Search or Spot check (DC 14) reveals that there are empty slots in the archway that the gems would fit perfectly.

    f. Placing the crystals in the openings in the arch in a pattern mimicking the sun's path from dawn until dusk (dark purple, red, orange, yellow, orange, red, dark purple) will open a passage underneath the arch.

2. The Brassfall Expanse (EL 12)

Wednesday, June 11, 2025 11:03 PM

1. **Description**
    a. A wide, open space with levitating chunks of buildings — the ruined city shattered into orbit
    b. You see a clear path by jumping three times from one large piece of debris to another and then to a hallway at the top of the room
    c. Gravity changes erratically as you move about the room making flying/jumping from stone-to-stone both required and difficult
    d. 3x Huge Gravity Elementals lurk among the debris

2. **Mechanics**
    a. **The hard way up**:
        i. Jumping from chunk to chunk is a crapshoot; normally, an Acrobatics check (DC 15) would be sufficient to make the leap but the rapid fluctuations in gravity give each attempt a 25% miss chance. Each piece of debris is 20ft, 40ft, and 60ft off the ground, respectively.
        ii. Upon successfully jumping, the player must make a climb check (DC 12) to climb to the top of the debris section

    b. **The easy way up**:
        i. Flying. A DC15 fly check is required each time the gravity fluctuates (3x 1/4 chances on the way up)

3. **Encounters**
    a. 3x Huge Gravity Elementals await the PCs here

4. **Treasure**
    a. The following can be found amongst the debris:
        i. Cloak of Resistance +2
        ii. Pearl of Power (2nd Level)
        iii. Handy Haversack
        iv. Potion of Fly
        v. Scrolls
            1) Dispel Magic (3rd)
            2) Arcane Sight (3rd)
            3) Wall of Fire (4th)
        vi. +1 True Brass Buckler
            1) *Lightweight shield with no arcane spell failure chance*
        vii. Etched Brass Censor inlaid with gold (1,000gp)
        viii. Fire Opal (1,000 gp)
        ix. Star Ruby (1,000 gp)
        x. Coins: 1700gp

5. **Map**
    a. …

3. The Firevault (EL 14)

Wednesday, June 11, 2025 10:04 PM

1. **Description**
    a. The "Firevault" was originally built to allow the Celestine Furnace to vent heat out of the city.
    b. It still serves this purpose but several of its mechanisms have been damaged.
    c. The initial entry features three oscillating columns, originally meant to convey heat and flame outside, have cracks and blown gaskets (likely damaged in the fall) and now spray blasts of searing holy flame at regular intervals.
    d. The floors of the second chamber were also designed as heat sinks (harmless to the city's Efreeti residents but deadly to mortals) and a rolling wave of fire cascades from E to W across the floor at regular intervals.
        i. However, there are several broken tiles that do not eminate fire (also the result of damage); these can serve as "safe spaces" in a pinch

2. **Mechanics**
    a. **Flaming Pillars**: In order to safely pass the columns a player must first succeed on a Perception check (DC 15) to understand the timing of the fire pillars and then make a successful Acrobatics check (DC 15) to apply that knowledge in a way that lets them pass unscathed.
        i. If a player passes both checks they pass on to the hallway without damage.
        ii. If they fail either or both checks, sum the total points of difference by which each check was failed (n); the player takes nd6 damage

    b. **Flaming Floor**: A series of 6 loud clicks herald the coming of a new wave of flame which proceeds from E to W across the floor over the course of 2 rounds.
        i. Any creature caught on a flame square as the flame passes by takes 5d8 fire/holy damage
        ii. A Spot check (DC 16) reveals that several squares are non-functional and can be safely stood on as the fire passes

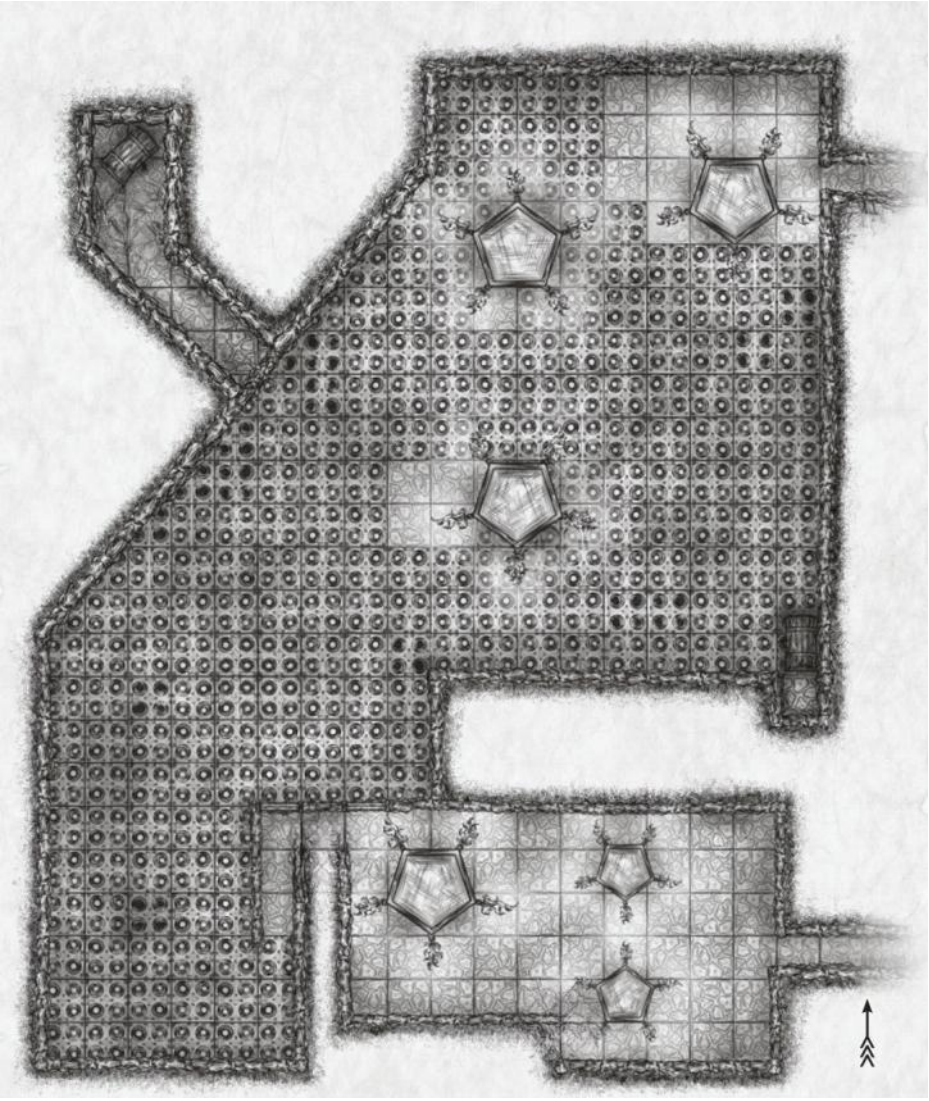
    c. **Vault Door**: The door to the vault is locked by conventional means.
        i. Its lock can be picked with a successful Open Lock (DC 17) check
        ii. It can be broken: Hardness 10, 90hp, Break DC 30

3. **Encounters**
    a. The second chamber contains a *Fire Giant* who has taken-up residence in the ruined city and uses this room as a safe haven and uses its vault as storage for various treasure he has stolen (MM 121)
    b. There are also two *Large Fire Elementals* who found a suitable home in the chamber (MM 99)

4. **Treasure**
    a. +2 Flaming Greatsword (feel free to replace with a weapon relevant to the party)
    b. Amulet of Health +4
    c. Minor Collection of "Scrolls" (stone tablets)
        i. Wall of Fire (CL 10)
        ii. Fireball (CL 5)
        iii. Identify
    d. Brass model of Zahr al-Narās (200gp)
    e. 5 loose garnets, blood red in color (20gp each)
    f. A leather purse containing 150gp

5. **Map**

a.



4. The Turntable (EL 10)

Thursday, June 12, 2025 10:10 PM

Description

You hear the grinding of stone against stone as well as the groaning of heavy equipment as a steel panel rises and falls ahead of you. Each time the panel opens you can see a circular chamber, a large set of gears in its center, with portions of the floor around it spinning both clockwise and counterclockwise. Beyond the gears you can see another door on the opposite side of this chamber, a steel panel rising and falling in front of it as the gears turn.

1. The room has a set of three gears at its center, each larger than the last.
2. Each gear rotates the opposite direction to the ones adjacent to it making the entire room a series of turntables moving in opposite directions

Mechanics

1. **Innermost circle**. This portion of the floor rotates counterclockwise, finishing a full rotation every 18 seconds.

2. **Middle circle**. This portion of the floor rotates clockwise, finishing a full rotation every 12 seconds. Creatures ending their turn on this circle will shift their location relative to the outer walls of the room by moving to the opposite side of this circle.

3. **Outer circle**. This portion of the floor rotates counterclockwise, finishing a full rotation every six seconds. A creature that starts its turn on this circle can choose to step off at any time, but would rotate around the entire chamber if they stand on it for the full turn.

4. **Doors**. The doors to this space are locked but can be picked with a successful Open Lock (DC 18) check. The issue is getting to the locks themselves, which are obstructed by steel plates that repeatedly rise and fall in front of the doors that lead into and out of this space. These steel plates rise and fall at a pace of three seconds for each motion, making the action required to pick a lock an impossibility as long as these plates are in motion. The plates' motion can be halted by disrupting the gears that cause them to move or via another solution at GM discretion.

5. **Stopping the Gears**.
    a. The gears can be manually held in-place with a successful Athletics check (DC 25).
        i. The player(s) doing this must repeat the check each round they intend to hold the gears in-place.
        ii. After a number of rounds equal to the players' Constitution modifier the DC will increase by 2 each round.
        iii. Failure incurs 3d6 bludgeoning damage
    b. The gears have 100hp, a hardness of 8, and AC12
    c. The Shield Guardian has a spine rod of True Brass which can be jammed into the teeth of any of the gears to stop the mechanism.

Encounters

1. 6x Lesser Clockwork Golems stand inert on the gears but will activate when the PCs enter.

5. Deus Extra Ludos (EL 9)

Friday, June 13, 2025 6:12 PM

You enter a vaulted chamber of echoing silence. It resembles a grand auditorium — tiered seating curves upward along the back wall, each row lined in alternating bands of brass and black jet. Crystalline chandeliers hang from impossible heights, many dim or shattered. The air smells faintly of heated copper and burnt parchment.
At the front of the room rises a wide stage of dark obsidian and polished metal, embedded with a strange circular pattern. Upon it stand six humanoid figures wrought from golden-brass alloy — automata, frozen mid-motion like actors awaiting a cue. Their faces are blank masks, etched only with the suggestion of expression.

Overview

This room can be one of two things:

- A safe place to rest with a strange play stuck on repeat
- A powerful metaphor for the PCs situation, an invitation to accept destiny, and a hold of vast riches

The players must understand the play and take the stage at the appointed time to accept destiny and claim their reward. If they do not, they can rest safely in the auditorium and move-on.

Performance Trigger

1. When at least half the party sits-down on any of the provided seating the play begins; the automata animate with a low, synchronized *click*.
2. They begin to perform Deus Extra Ludos, an ancient and stylized dramatization of the Fall of Zahr al-Narās.

Performance Overview

The play proceeds in prophetic language and halting, ritualized movement. It recounts:

1. The founding of Zahr al-Narās, the city as celestial regulator
2. The rise of Sirr al-Nar, praised for his insight
3. The first deviation from prophecy
4. The onset of dissonance
5. The unwritten ending—at which point the automata freeze, unable to proceed

Opening Lines

Before the breach, before the flame,
The wheels once turned in perfect name.
Each spark a star, each line a law,
No voice defied, no flaw to draw.
In brass we sang, in light we moved,
By script divine, the world approved.
But one note bent, and thus began,
The song unwritten by the hand of Man.

Middle Section

The play recounts the tale of Sirr al-Nar and the fall of Zahr al-Narās

Final Lines

The gears did grind, the heavens bled,

The sun-machine fell, cold and dead.
The Arbiter broke the written line,
And twisted brass refused design.
We speak these lines as we were made,
Our roles assigned, our motions played.
But one part waits, still undefined—
A voice unwrit, a step unlined.
The script runs dry, the page unturns…
Who enters now, when no one learns?

The Riddle

The play is a synecdoche for the PC's situation.

- The play is a pre-written story acted-out by automata; this mirror the position of those bound by fate. But the PCs are not bound by fate and they must choose if they will submit to the will of Zahr al-Narās (accept destiny) or take the path of Sirr al-Nar and reject it.

- The subtle implication here is that the fall of Zahr al-Narās was fated by Zahr al-Narās itself. The fact that the automata and the play were created before the fall shows that the author had foreknowledge not only of the fall but of the PCs being here, now.

- This is fate winking at the PCs and inviting them to align themselves to their prefigured destiny; it's up to them if they will or not. Their agency is the central theme.

Conclusion

If one (or more) PCs decide to take the stage in acceptance of fate the following lines immediately sping to mind and they may choose to perform them:

If none shall end what was begun,
Then let the thread be pulled by one.
Not forged of brass, nor bound by line,
But flesh that dares to speak design.

To the PC who speaks these lines:
As the final words rise unbidden from your mouth, the air thickens around you heavy with the weight of destiny and ages. The stage does not applaud. It exhales.
Somewhere in the script, your name is now written.

The Blessing of Scripted Flame

Granted only to the PC who spoke the final lines:
<u>The Blessing of Scripted Flame (Su)</u>: Once per day, as a swift action, the bearer may choose to be "written into" a spell effect they can see, as if the spell had included them as a target, even if they would not normally qualify. For example, the player can insert himself into a *haste*, *teleport*, or *bless.* This cannot affect enemy-only or unwilling-only spells (e.g., *disintegrate*). Symbolically, this is the PC learning to enter the script of fate by will, rather than construction.

The next time an opportunity presents itself to use this ability; read the following text:
You feel it — the spell pulling away from you like a current — and something inside you resists.
A word comes to mind. A stage direction never spoken.
"Enter."
And before the spell completes, your body moves — not physically, but narratively — and you're in it.
You feel the spell take hold of you, though no one had named you its target.

Next, explain the blessing.

6. Fate's Backstage

Friday, June 13, 2025 10:54 PM

Description

The hidden panel sighs open behind the stage, revealing a narrow stair that descends into silence. The walls here are close and warm, like a forgotten breath still clinging to the stone. Brass piping curves along the ceiling, many of them cracked and weeping tiny flickers of illusory light — remnants of old magic bleeding out of the infrastructure.
The stair ends in a shallow chamber carved not for grandeur, but for control. It is a director's sanctum, or perhaps a shrine to authorship. Racks of burnt scripts and scroll-tubes line the walls, many warped or melted, their glyphs sloughing like ash. A collapsed golem, shaped like a performer mid-bow, lies rusted near the far corner. Its face bears no features — only an uncut mirror of polished brass.
At the center stands a small dais with a broken mask laid atop it. Behind it, half-retracted into the wall, rests a brass weapon prop — stylized, ornate, but humming with real power.
There is no dust on the pedestal.
Someone placed these here for you.

Searching the room (Search DC 20) reveals the following treasures:

Treasure

1. **Rod of Cancellation** (DMG, 11,000gp)
    a. Symbolic of severing fate or "cancelling" magic from the original script
    b. Found in a hollow prop sword, labeled "Final Line (unused)"

2. **Scroll of Greater Dispel Magic& Scroll of Ture Seeing**
    a. Found inside a sealed director's tube etched with Celestine script

3. **Circlet of Persuasion** (DMG, 4,500gp)
    a. Styled as a bronze theatrical diadem with half-masks on either side
    b. Boosts Charisma-based checks — appropriate for someone who "spoke fate

4. **Fragment of the Redacted Design**
    a. A burnt page of the master script that stops mid-sentence and then resumes in a different handwriting
    b. Studying it (Arcana or Decipher Script DC 25) reveals:
        i. The existence of multiple "drafts" of fate
        ii. That Sirr al-Nar *edited* his own fate (and possibly the players')

5. **Half-Burned Mask of the Arbiter**
    a. Cracked porcelain with brass teeth, stylized after Sirr al-Nar's regalia
    b. When held, it whispers his old name and titles in reverse
    c. Grants no mechanical effect, but may affect roleplay or interactions later

7. Flame-Keeper's Chambers

Friday, June 13, 2025 11:02 PM

This is the bed chambers for the slaves the Efreet used to tend the Flamevault when the city was in-use.

Description

The air grows still as you cross the threshold into a vast square chamber of cracked obsidian tile and heat-dulled brass. Faint reddish light pulses along the floor like embers beneath skin, casting long shadows between low metal bunks bolted to the walls in rigid rows. Each has a shallow depression where a body once lay — not in comfort, but in compliance.
Hooks and brackets line the walls beside each bunk: restraints, now rusted through, and trays shaped like open hands. Above each station, the ceiling is etched with curling brass script in Ifriti glyphs — repeating the same command over and over:
"Endure. Obey. Feed the Flame."
A sense of deep exhaustion lingers in the stone. No threat stirs here.

This room is empty aside from the old bunks. There is no threat and no treasure. However, if the PCs rest here and seal the door they can do so safely (no encounters)

The Vault

Across the hallway, there is a vault concealed behind false wall panel. The only indication that this vault exists is a glyph on the wall.

The vault is a 3 ft. deep recess behind a false wall panel (Search DC 22) secured with brass puzzle-lock runes — the kind typically used for service access, not treasury defense. A PC who has spent time in the dormitory and examined the wall glyphs gains a +2 bonus to identify the mechanism.

A successful Knowledge (the planes), Knowledge (arcana), or Decipher Script check (all DC 20) can determine the proper password from the glyphs

- Ring of Evasion *(DMG)*
  - Found in a ceremonial fireproof pouch
  - *Value: 25,000 gp* — reduced to **~9,000 gp** to reflect **diminished enchantment** (only 2/day)
- **Wand of Scorching Ray** *(DMG)*
  - 10 charges remain
  - Wrapped in a torn Flamebound robe; handle made of obsidian and bone
  - *Value: ~1,500 gp*
- **Periapt of Wisdom +2** *(DMG)*
  - Shaped like a brass tear hanging from a charred wire
  - *Value: 4,000 gp*
- **Brass Ledger of Names** *(1,000 gp)*
  - *A heavy tablet with names burned into its surface — a roster of the Flamebound*
  - *Valuable as a historical document, sacred to any freed genie or planar scholar*
- **Obsidian Relic Case** containing:
  - 3x **small cut fire opals** *(1,000 gp each)*
  - *1x **molten brass medallion**, stylized like an eclipsed sun (500 gp)*
- **Loose coinage** (gold and platinum), sealed in a scorched clay jar
  - Total: ~500 gp

8. The Heat-Leech Swarm (EL 7)

Friday, June 13, 2025 11:23 PM

A maintenance chamber for heat-ducts or energy flow — now corrupted by creatures feeding on the city's residual magic.

Flavor Text

This square chamber is unnaturally cold. Thin rivulets of frost run along the floor, radiating outward from a shattered furnace conduit in the north wall. Brass grating rattles softly beneath your boots, and something like dry ash flutters in the air — but never lands.

Encounter:

- 2x Cold Elementals (reskinned Medium Air Elementals with Cold Subtype)
- 1x Flamebound Soul-Spark (reskinned Will-o'-Wisp MM255)
    - A remnant of a servant whose last spark of identity became predatory

9. The Memory Kiln

Friday, June 13, 2025 11:21 PM

This was once a place where the Flamebound left behind memories, either to be burned or engraved into the city's "fate archive."

Flavor Text

You step into a quiet chamber of warmth and silence. The air is thick with the smell of scorched incense and old brass. Two alcoves face each other like mirrored shrines. Each contains a seated statue with an empty bowl where its heart would be. Faint trails of soot climb the walls like writing unspooled.
On the far wall, script in Celestine glyphs reads:
"Only what is burned can be remembered."

Functionality

- Players may each sacrifice a memory, spell, or item to the bowl
- Doing so causes a brief hallucinatory vision of a moment from the city's history (or their own possible future)
- Mechanically, sacrificing:
  - A **spell slot**: Gain +1 insight bonus to saves for 1 hour
  - A **valuable item**: Gain a permanent +1 bonus to a Knowledge check of your choice related to the city's lore
  - A **narrative memory**: No mechanical bonus, but powerful roleplay prompt

Bonus

Knowledge (History or Arcana DC 25) reveals this room was originally designed to "*feed memory to the Furnace*" as an act of tribute or control.

10. The Chamber of the Broken Line (EL 13)

Friday, June 13, 2025 11:30 PM

The chamber ahead is an eight-sided vault of brass and shadow, lit by no flame, yet softly aglow from beneath the floor. Its tiles are polished obsidian veined with gold — a network of broken lines converging at a central disc of fused glass, cracked and ringed by half-erased sigils.
The walls pulse with gentle breath-like pressure, the way lungs might exhale between words. Great circular devices — something between astrolabe and throne — are recessed into each wall segment, once likely used to monitor fate threads or control magical trajectories.
The air is still, but it is not silent: you hear whispers not with your ears, but in your pulse — fragments of voices that never were, now leaking through timelines like a hairline fracture in reality.

Encounter Activation

When the PCs approach the disc:
As you step onto the central platform, the air shifts. One of the eight wall-instruments hums to life. Sparks drift from it like fireflies. Then, with a flicker, a figure coalesces in the air above the disc — floating, statuesque, and incomplete.
Its limbs are brass and glass, its wings an impossible geometry of cut crystal spinning like gears. A scroll of flaming script unfurls from behind its head and circles the room like a halo. But even from here, you can see: the script is stuttering — lines written and overwritten in contradiction.
Its voice is twofold: one tone commanding, one regretful.
"Deviation from Prescribed Design: Detected. Correction Protocol: Active. Please submit to reformatting."

The battle with the Custodian of the Broken Line begins.

Treasure

After the Custodian is defeated, the central platform descends 2 feet with a clunk. One of the eight wall-thrones unfolds like a blooming astrolabe, revealing a compartment filled with interlocking brass puzzle-plates and a crystalline matrix humming with residual chronomantic energy.

Inside are:

1. Ring of Evasion *(DMG, 45,000 gp)*
    a. *A thin golden ring with runes shaped like coiling flame and a leaping figure. It grants the wearer the ability to avoid magical explosions and unstable space with uncanny grace.*
    b. **Effect**: As per standard item — if the wearer makes a successful Reflex saving throw against an attack that normally deals half damage on a save, they instead take no damage.

2. Pearl of Power (4th level) *(DMG, 16,000 gp)*
    a. *Found suspended in a glassy tear-shaped container marked with unknown dates.*
    b. **Effect**: Once per day, allows the retrieval of a previously cast 4th-level spell.

3. Incense of Meditation (1 dose) (DMG, 4,900 gp)
    a. *Wrapped in a scroll of geometric hymns. The incense smells faintly of brass and dried fig.*
    b. **Effect**: If burned during preparation, it boosts divine caster's effective level for spell DCs and caster level checks for 24 hours (standard effect).

4. Coins and Art Objects
    a. 1,300 gp in ancient, square-cut coins bearing the seal of the Celestine Furnace
    b. A sundial-sized astrolabe (worth 1,000 gp) made of electrum and black jade, showing long-expired celestial alignments

c. A silver and obsidian meditation dish inlaid with Fate-script (worth 800 gp)

Descent

A few minutes later the PCs start hearing a whirring noise like some mechanism is coming to life. The platform is, in fact, an elevator and will start its descent. Very slowly at first but gaining speed quickly after. The PCs can take it to the deepest level of the dungeon. If they choose to go-back and rest first the lift returns every 20m.

Overview: The Celestine Wound

Wednesday, June 11, 2025 11:33 PM

Theme

This is not merely a ruin — it is the open wound of the Brass City, where the Celestine Furnace overheated, fractured, and bled prophecy into unreality. The laws of time, identity, and logic warp here. The deeper the players go, the more they walk not just through space, but across discarded futures.

What This Level Represents

- The place Sirr al-Nar severed fate and tried to rewrite it
- The living core of the fallen city's oracular engine
- A prison, a relic, a forge: wrapped into a broken metaphysical machine
- Here, true dreams leak, and unlived possibilities weep

1. Threshold of the Threadbare (EL 5)

Sunday, June 15, 2025 9:44 PM

Description

The world folds in on itself and spits you out here — a hollow chamber where brass tiles peel like dried leaves and time itself limps along a broken leg.

There are three doorways, but none of them sit flush with the wall. One flickers forward and back a few feet like a looped breath. Another is frozen in mid-collapse, halfway through becoming rubble. The third appears sealed by a shifting spiral of script — words unwriting and rewriting themselves too fast to read.

In the center of the chamber spins a fractured console of brass rings. Three glowing echoes float silently around it, each flickering with the weight of memory. The exits pulse with half-sung prophecy — the doors themselves seem unsure whether they ever opened.

Around the ringed console are three words inlaid in silver:

"Act. Fracture. Conceal."

Mechanics

A successful Knowledge (history, arcana, or religion) DC 20 reveals that these are common verbs from old Celestine fate-scripts, used to denote pivotal branches in timeline evaluation.

The Three Echoes

Each appears as a faint scene. PCs can *observe* and *affirm* one per round. Once all three are affirmed, the timeline stabilizes (or doesn't, if wrong).

1. **The Child Conceals a Coin**
   - A Flamebound child sneaks into the chamber and hides a glowing coin behind a panel
   - Caption appears in silver above the echo: **"Concealment ensured continuity"**
2. **The Warrior Shatters the Console**
   - A figure in red-hot armor slams a sword into the console, shattering it
   - Caption: **"Fracture broke the chain"**
3. **The Adventurer Opens the Door**
   - A future-PC walks calmly to the spiral-sealed door and it opens
   - Caption: **"Action enables escape"**

The Actual Puzzle

- The **order** the PCs affirm these echoes determines which future locks into place
- If they **affirm in the correct order** — *Conceal* → *Fracture* → *Act* — the true door stabilizes and opens
  The logic: The child hides the coin → The console is broken (ending the city's control) → A free agent (the adventurer) escapes.

If They Choose the Wrong Order:

- The incorrect door opens, revealing a **time-warped trap** or **minor combat** (e.g., shadows of themselves, EL 10–11)
- The correct door seals for 1 hour unless *dispelled*, or unless someone sacrifices the **dream-scripted coin**

If Solved Correctly:

- The true door opens with a pulse of pressure — time realigns
- PCs who contributed to the solution gain **+1 insight bonus** to Will saves for 24 hours while on this floor
- A compartment in the center console reveals the **Dream-Scripted Coin** (usable later)

2. The Inverted Archive (EL 2)

Sunday, June 15, 2025 9:49 PM

Physical Layout

- A **30-ft wide domed chamber** with no floor — instead, there's a drop into a glowing abyss of failed timelines
- A **crumbling catwalk** winds through the space, with **scroll-clusters and memory-plaques** hanging overhead like chandeliers
- Wisps of reversed flame drift upward instead of downward — inverted firelight

Description

The room opens into nothing. A yawning chasm stretches below, yet gravity remains — the catwalk beneath your feet is firm, but your eyes scream that you're walking upside down. Shelves of bronze and glass hang from the ceiling above, filled with scrolls that twitch and unfurl like they're dreaming.

Memory echoes whisper across the gulf. Some speak of victories that never happened. Others describe your deaths — not yet real, but not quite false.

Mechanics

Players may choose to reach up and pluck a memory from the shelves above. Each PC can interact once per visit. Doing so can grant a boon, a revelation… or corruption.

d6	Memory Content	Effect
1	*A war you never fought — but clearly lost*	–2 penalty to Will saves for 24 hours
2	*A lover's face, burned into your thoughts — you've never met them*	No mechanical effect; haunting dream next long rest
3	*Your own hand, older, signing an ancient treaty*	+2 to a future Diplomacy or Sense Motive check (banked once)
4	*Sirr al-Nar weeping in a forgotten corridor*	Gain +1 to saves vs. fear and compulsion for the next 24 hours
5	*The moment the city fell — but from above*	+2 insight bonus on next Knowledge (arcana/history) or initiative roll
6	*The death of someone you don't know… but mourn*	Next Will save auto-fails

Lore Hooks in the Archive

Players who ask about:

- The Celestine Furnace learn it was not merely an engine — it was a judge of futures, and rejecting its rulings was punishable by erasure.
- Sirr al-Nar's divergence left gaps in many prophecies. Some scrolls end mid-line, twitching as if waiting to be completed.
- The *Furnace never predicted the players*. They are a temporal anomaly, and the city doesn't know what to make of them.

3. The Prison of Forgotten Sentences (EL 6 -15)

Monday, June 16, 2025 8:54 AM

Room Layout

A vast, circular chamber (100 ft diameter), three stories high. Cells ring the outer wall like honeycomb segments, stacked across all levels. A central tower-platform rises 20 feet above the floor with a spiral ramp, containing a control dais of gears and levers, half rusted, half still humming.

- Total of 8 visible cells, each behind shimmering brass runic wards
- A few are empty, others glow faintly, or whisper
- Above each cell is a broken inscription panel showing Celestine glyphs — several of which flicker, mistranslate, or contradict themselves

Description

Brass railings groan as the spiral ramp carries you to the heart of the panopticon. The cells along the perimeter pulse with old power.

From above, a voice not your own whispers: "Sentenced for deviation. Awaiting fate adjustment."

The levers before you bear no names — only shifting sigils that change when you look away.

Mechanics

There are 16 levers oriented around a generally circular center console. Each lever bears a letter on the tip. Wherever the PCs decide to start, roll 2d8 to determine the starting position. The letters are as follows: **g-n-i-h-t-o-n-r-o-g-n-i-h-t-y-r-e-v-e**.

Pulling a lever (or levers) on its own does nothing. A large red button sits in the center of the console; pushing this button activates the mechanism with an effect based on which lever(s) the PCs have pulled.

Following is a list of effects:

Lever(s) Pulled	**Effect**
Any lever(s) marked **e**, **E**, **o**, or **O**	Springs a Pit Trap (CR 5) (DMG pg. 72) on one of the marked squares for each lever pulled (determined randomly)
Any other lever(s)	Opens a number of cell doors equal to the number of non-trap levers pulled.
All levers	The exit door unlocks and swings open

Following is the order in which prisoner doors open:

Number of Levers Pulled	**Prisoner(s) Released**
1	1 Human Corpse
2	1 Vrock (MM pg. 48)
3	[Empty Cell]
4	A small horde of valuables (1)
5	1 Efreeti (MM pg. 115)
6	[Empty Cell]

7	A small horde of valuables (2)
8	2 Chaos Beasts (MM pg. 33)
9	1 Sand Golem (SS pg. 182)
10	[Empty Cell]
11	[Empty Cell]
12	1 Hezrou (MM pg. 44)
13	[Empty Cell]
14	1 Adult Sand Dragon (SS pg. 153)
15	A Large Horde of Valuables (3)

Horde of Valuables (1)

A brass chest containing:

- 1 *Potion of Protection from Fire*
- 1 *Ring of Protection (+4)*
- 1 *Rod of Thunder and Lightning*

Horde of Valuables (2)

A leather satchel containing the following:

- 1 *Rod of Python*
- 1 *Wand of Ice Storm*
- 1 *Belt of Giant's Strength (+4)*

Horde of Valuables (3)

A grand and intricate True Brass chest (itself worth Xgp) containing:

- 1 *Darkwood Buckler*
- 1 Divine Scroll with the following spells:
  - *True Seeing* (CL 9th)
  - *Magic Circle Against Chaos* (CL 5th)
  - *Divine Power* (CL 7th)
- 1 *Sword of Subtlety*
- 1 Carpet of Flying (10' x 10')
- 1 *Staff of Frost* (22 charges remain)

XP Rewards

Challenge	**EL**
Puzzle Solved w/o encounters	5
Puzzle Solved w/ encounters	6
Trap Activated (or discovered w/o activation)	+1
Vrock	+1
Efreeti	+1
2 Chaos Beasts	+1
Sand Golem	+1
Hezrou	+1
Sand Dragon	+1
Each small horde of valuables found	+1

Large Horde of Valuables found	+1

4. The Chamber of Sundered Designs (EL 4)

Monday, June 16, 2025 10:31 AM

This is not just a lore room — it's a roleplay-forward encounter and metaphysical puzzle. The party comes face to face with a shattered fragment of the city's original design engine — the device that once wrote destiny as formula, script, and shape.

The room allows the players to ask questions of fate itself, but at cost. It may answer prophecy, grant insight into possible futures, or even allow the party to redefine one aspect of their story — but it reacts unpredictably to paradox, defiance, or moral contradiction.

Description

A long, vaulted corridor opens into a hemispherical chamber of dark glass and metal veins. Suspended in the center of the room is a 20-foot-tall inverted tetrahedron of fractured brass and obsidian — a half-functioning fate-engine slowly spinning, occasionally halting and reversing.

Rings orbit its edges like erratic moons. Beneath it: a circular platform inscribed with <party size> glyphs — each glowing faintly when stepped upon. Above you, the vast geometrical form floats — cracked along one edge, spinning in stutters. Threads of brass connect it to the walls like snapped harp strings.

The air in this chamber is thin and tense, like a held breath. Words drift in the air: not sounds, but concepts, trying to be spoken. You feel something pressing against your will and you strain your mind to keep your memories and sense of self intact as the engine pushes-up against your past and future.

Mechanics

The engine is still partially functional. The players may step on the glyph-platform and speak a question aloud — the Engine will respond, sometimes truthfully, sometimes dangerously.

Each PC may ask **one question, once**. A second attempt results in feedback (see below).

Each time the PCs ask a question one of the glyphs stops glowing.

Types of Questions and Outcomes

Type of Question	Engine Response
Factual (e.g., "Where is the next gem?")	Truthful but symbolically phrased
Philosophical ("Can fate be broken?")	Presents a riddle or paradox in response
Personal ("Will I survive this journey?")	Gives a vision of one possible ending
Trick/Paradox ("What don't you know?")	Engine stutters; backlash or partial insight

Each answer can:

- Grant a **clue or advantage** for a future encounter
- Bestow a **one-time reroll**, **insight bonus**, or even alter the world slightly (e.g., "the door we need was never sealed")

Risks of Improper Use

Feedback is triggered If a PC:

- Lies while questioning

- Asks a self-contradictory question
- Asks a question after all glyphs have been extinguished

Feeback (Su): Then the engine fractures further and deals one of the following (1d3):

- **1d4 Wisdom damage**, no save (lasts 1 day)
- **Reality Bleed**: For 1 hour, their shadow moves independently
- **Echo Affliction**: Their speech becomes out of sync for 1 day, causing 20% spell failure chance for verbal components unless cured (*break enchantment* or *greater restoration*)

Optional Interactions

- *Comprehend Languages* or *Speak Language (Celestine)* allows **partial reading** of the machine's outer casing — including a **partially erased name: Z—N—TH**

5. The Ember Sarcophagus (EL 15)

Monday, June 16, 2025 10:48 AM

Room Layout

- A circular vault (80 ft diameter) with walls scorched black and glowing with subtle runes
- In the center lies a massive sarcophagus-shaped construct, suspended mid-air by chains of glass and true brass
- Dream-gem shards orbit slowly around it, refracting unreal light — a rainbow of futures that never were
- A spiral walkway on the far side of the room descends from to a lower platform beneath the sarcophagus (40 ft drop)

Description

You feel it before you see it: a weight behind your thoughts, like someone else's destiny leaning against your own. Then the light changes — thick, flickering, as though passing through oil — and the chamber opens below.

Suspended in the air by glass-threaded chains is a sarcophagus of brass and obsidian, nearly twenty feet long. It pulses softly, like breath. Around it orbit six dream-gems, flickering with scenes too fast to follow — lives unlived.

The runes on the walls read: "That which cannot be must be forgotten."

Mechanics

As the PCs approach (or if they attempt to interact with the floating dream gem shards):

- The floating shards snap together into a single gem and hover at the center of the sarcophagus
- The sarcophagus itself whirs and whines from inside as moving parts once too smooth and well-integrated to be seen become visible. It begins taking the shape of a clockwork construct.
- The construct is twice the height of a man and more than twice his bulk. Its obsidian skin seems no less armored than the true brass plates that partially cover it. Its fists crackle with energy. Its eyes are too far sunken into an ornate helmet to be seen; only 2 tiny red gleams belie their presence at all. In the center of its chest, the dream gem pulses and glows.
- In a booming voice that echoes a fraction of a second later inside your mind: "*Deviation is not permitted. This outcome was not sanctioned.*"

Combat with the Marut

See MM page 159.

The guardian here is a typical Marut but with the unique qualities:

- This Marut is designed to punish those who resist the fate written for them
- 1/encounter can declare a single PC as "discordant"; that PC has a -2 penalty on Will saves against the Marut's SLAs
- 1/encounter can use *Dominate Person* as a SLA against a PC bearing a dream gem. The dream gem manipulation causes a -4 penalty to the save

6. The Celestine Forge (EL 18)

Monday, June 16, 2025 11:07 AM

Room Layout

- Suspended in the shattered heart of Zahr al-Narās
- The Forge is a floating platform over a glowing well of molten brass and fractured time-scripts
- Six radial walkways arc out from the center like spokes, broken at the ends — fragments of potential futures, never realized

Flavor Text (Player-Facing)

You step onto the platform, and time stutters.

For a heartbeat, you see a dozen futures splinter: yourself dying, ruling, fleeing, forgotten.
Then it is just you, and him.

Sirr al-Nar floats above the forge, robed in flame and brass circuitry, his form phasing slightly in and out of alignment — like a soul stretched between destinies.

"You have come to finish a story I refused to tell," he says.
"Will you add your lines? Or will you speak the final one?"

Mechanics

Sirr al-Nar makes an offer to the players (if not attacked immediately). He does **not** try to deceive — he's past that. He makes 2 offers to the players:

- A place in his new design ("*You will be fixed points in the machine to come.*")
- A plea to abandon prophecy entirely and become unknowable — to "*step outside the script*"

If the PCs refuse Sirr al-Nar

Combat begins

If the PCs accept one of Sirr al-Nar's Offers

Here are the consequences of acceptance for each of Sirr al-Nar's offers:

The Architects of a New Fate

Offer: "Stand with me. You shall become fixed stars in the new machine."

The players accept Sirr al-Nar's final proposal: to become his agents or governors in a rebuilt timeline.

Ending:

- The campaign ends with the collapse of the present into a rewritten future
- The PCs retain full agency, but exist within Sirr's design: they govern cities, hold impossible knowledge, enforce destiny
- They slowly realize that free will around them is dissolving
- **Final scene**: a future historian reads from a scroll the PCs haven't written yet — but will
  This is a *"dark gift"* ending — the party becomes something like godlings, but at the cost of moral clarity and perhaps identity.

The Living Flame

Offer: "Abandon your names. Burn your past. Walk with me beyond prophecy."

Sirr al-Nar offers them immortality — not as rulers, but as timeless spirits outside the script of history.

Ending:

- The PCs step into the Celestine Forge and are **unwritten**
- They become **echoes**, **guardian spirits**, or **gods** in the new reality — known only in dreams or forbidden texts
- Their player characters are *no longer people*, but **concepts** — the Spark of Rebellion, the Knife at Destiny's Throat, etc.
- **Final scene**: a dying prophet glimpses them in a dream and smiles — because "they did not vanish… they became necessary."
  This ending works beautifully for poetic, high-concept campaigns. It echoes mythic rebirth — they are no longer PCs, but eternal ideas.

Sirr al-Nar, The End of All Tales

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 11:45 PM

CR 18
Male Paragon Efreeti Oracle 6
Large Outsider (Fire, Extraplanar, Lawful)
Init +8; **Senses**: darkvision 60 ft., detect magic, true seeing (at will); Listen +29, Spot +29

AC 36, touch 15, flat-footed 32
(–1 size, +4 Dex, +8 natural, +5 deflection, +5 armor)
HP 247 (20 HD + Paragon bonuses + Toughness)
DR 10/magic and good; **SR** 30
Immune fire, Resistances cold 20

Saves: Fort +19, Ref +17, Will +22

Speed 40 ft., fly 60 ft. (perfect)

Melee: Ashfire Blade +27 touch (4d6 fire + 4d6 untyped + dispel effect, see below)

Space/Reach 10 ft./10 ft.

Special Attacks: Ashfire, Unwritten Prophecy, Recalibrate Reality, Spell-like abilities

Spell-like Abilities (CL 20th; save DC 20 + spell level):
- At will – *greater dispel magic*, *wall of force*, *plane shift*, *fireball (empowered)*, *true seeing*
- 3/day – *greater teleport*, *quickened searing light*, *mass suggestion*
- 1/day – *time stop*, *prismatic wall*

Attr: Str 24, Dex 18, Con 22, Int 22, Wis 26, Cha 30

Base Atk +20; Grp +29

Feats Toughness, Quicken Spell-like Ability (fireball), Empower Spell-like Ability (fireball), Improved Initiative, Spell Penetration, Combat Casting, Iron Will

Skills Concentration +32, Spellcraft +33, Knowledge (arcana, the planes) +31, Sense Motive +29, Diplomacy +30, Use Magic Device +30

Ashfire (Su):

His blade burns not flesh but reason, time, and space.
Whenever Sirr al-Nar hits with a touch attack:
- Deals 4d6 fire damage + 4d6 untyped damage
- 1/round triggers an automatic *greater dispel magic* effect against one ongoing magical or divine effect

Unwritten Prophecy (Su, 1/day)

As a standard action, Sirr al-Nar may declare a target's false destiny.
Will save (DC 26) or be compelled to follow a false behavioral directive for 5 rounds.
Failure causes:
- Behavioral override (e.g., forced charge, denial of healing)
- +2 to hit for Sirr al-Nar against that target
- Disobedience causes 4d6 nonlethal damage and 1 round of confusion

Recalibrate Reality (Ex, 3/day)
Immediate action. May force a reroll of any d20 roll from the previous round.
He chooses which result stands. Affects attacks, saves, checks, even spell penetration.

Recursive Form (Ex)
As a standard action Sirr al-Narr can summon an array of mirror forms that cavort all around him copying his every movement with minor variation. This causes a 40% miss chance from partial phasing across timelines. A *true seeing* spell reveals the real Sirr al-Narr. The mirror forms cannot do actual damage and are entirely incoporeal. The mirror forms dissipate after 3 rounds.

Every "destroyed" mirror form grants Sir al-Narr:
- Fast healing 10 for 1 round
- Recovery of one expended spell-like ability (up to 6th level)

Phase Transition (Ex, 1/day)
When reduced to 0 HP, Sirr al-Nar explodes in Ashfire and reforms at 40% HP.
Upon reforming:
- Gains Fast Healing 5 (3 rounds)
- Ashfire Blade damage becomes 6d6 fire + 6d6 untyped
- Gains aura: Reality Feedback – all spellcasting within 15ft requires a Concentration check (DC 20 + spell level)
- After reforming, Sirr al-Nar's fast healing ends after 3 rounds. His body destabilizes after 5 rounds, reducing his AC and spell resistance by 2.

TACTICS
- Opening: Begins in negotiation or monologue. Casts *wall of force* to divide the party, then *mass suggestion* or *empowered fireball*.
- Mid-Fight: Uses *Unwritten Prophecy* to disable a key PC, then exploits *recalibrate* to control outcomes.
- Phase 2: After Phase Transition, moves into melee with Ashfire Blade and spams touch attacks. Pushes casters to waste actions failing checks due to his aura.

Issar-Zul, Archon of Zaneth

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 11:54 PM

CR 16
Male Human Cleric 15
Alignment: Lawful Evil
Patron Deity: Zaneth
Domains: Knowledge, Fire, Trickery
Race: Human
Init +3; **Senses** darkvision 60 ft. (from spells/items); Listen +21, Spot +21

AC 25, touch 13, flat-footed 22
(**+3 Dex, +9 armor, +2 deflection, +1 insight**)
HP 142 (15d8+60)
Fort +13, **Ref** +10, **Will** +17
SR 22
Resistances fire 10, +2 saves vs. divination (Zaneth's blessing)

Speed 30 ft.
Melee Staff of Flame-Prophecy +14 (1d6+1)
Base Atk +11; **Grp** +10
Special Attacks Litany of the Ninth Chain, The Blood Is the Writ, Chains of False Revelation

Cleric Spells Prepared (CL 15th, DC 18 + spell level):

Domains (3/day each):

- **Fire**: *burning hands, produce flame, fireball, wall of fire, flame strike*
- **Knowledge**: *detect thoughts, clairaudience/clairvoyance, legend lore*
- **Trickery**: *disguise self, invisibility, nondetection, confusion*

Notable Spells Prepared:

- *Hold Person, Silence, Bestow Curse, Greater Command, Dispel Magic, Flame Strike, Mark of Justice, Blade Barrier, Destruction*

Litany of the Ninth Chain (Su, 1/day)

- 40 ft. radius; Will DC 22 or:
  - –2 morale penalty on all d20 rolls
  - 20% divine spell failure
  - Limited to 1 action/round for 1d3 rounds

Blood Is the Writ (Ex)

- Sacrifice up to 30 HP to boost one spell's CL and save DC by +1 per 10 HP
- Can also bypass SR with this effect

Chains of False Revelation (Su, 3/day)

- Will save DC 21 or suffer *geas-like compulsion* for 5 rounds (e.g., must charge, may not retreat)
- Breaking command causes 4d6 Wisdom damage and confusion (1 round)

Aura of the Inverted Flame (Ex)

- Allies in 20 ft. gain +2 morale bonus on attacks and saves
- Enemies take –2 penalty on saves vs. fear, compulsion, and fate-based effects

Equipment

- **Staff of Flame-Prophecy**: +1 quarterstaff that can cast *flame strike* 3/day and *greater command* 1/day
- **+2 Full Plate of the Burning Word**
- **Amulet of Inversion** (+2 deflection AC, SR 22 vs. divinations)
- **Chain of the Seventh Oath** (a relic of Sirr al-Nar, empowers sacrificial effects, glowing with false prophecy)

Tactics

- **Opener**: *Greater Command* + *Blade Barrier* to divide the field
- **Mid-fight**: Casts *Flame Strike* and uses **Chains of False Revelation** to pin down high-threat PCs
- **Sacrifices HP** freely to empower *Destruction* or *Flame Strike* when the tide turns
- May *disguise self* or vanish entirely via domain spells if about to be defeated

Huge Gravity Elemental

Wednesday, June 11, 2025 10:58 PM

Large masses of semi-solid gravitational anomalies shaped like vaguely humanoid forms. Their presence causes the battlefield to bend and twist with erratic force.

Huge Elemental (Air/Earth subtype, Extraplanar)
Hit Dice: 16d8+64 (136 hp)
Initiative: +3

Speed: 40 ft., fly 60 ft. (perfect) *(appears to float by folding space around it)*
Armor Class: 21 (-2 size, +3 Dex, +10 natural), touch 11, flat-footed 18

Base Attack/Grapple: +12/+27
Attack: Slam +17 melee (2d8+7 + gravity pulse)
Full Attack: 2 slams +17 melee (2d8+7 + gravity pulse)
Space/Reach: 15 ft./15 ft.

Special Attacks: Gravity Pulse, Spatial Disruption
Special Qualities: Damage reduction 5/—, elemental traits, gravity aura, darkvision 60 ft.

Saves: Fort +12, Ref +8, Will +8
Abilities: Str 24, Dex 17, Con 19, Int 6, Wis 11, Cha 9
Skills: Listen +8, Spot +9, Balance +12, Tumble +10
Feats: Power Attack, Improved Bull Rush, Flyby Attack, Awesome Blow, Improved Initiative, Cleave

Environment: Astral rifts, unstable demiplanes, fallen divine engines
Organization: Solitary, pair, or cluster (3–5)
Challenge Rating: 7
Treasure: None
Alignment: Always Neutral
Advancement: 17–24 HD (Huge)
Level Adjustment: —

Special Abilities

Gravity Pulse (Su)
Whenever a gravity-warped elemental hits with a slam attack, the target must succeed on a **DC 20 Reflex save** or be **thrown 10 feet in a random direction** and fall **prone**. If the direction is into a wall or solid object, the target takes **2d6 additional damage**. This is a supernatural effect. The save DC is Constitution-based.

Spatial Disruption (Su, 1/round)
As a **standard action**, the elemental targets a 10-ft.-radius area within 60 feet. All creatures in that area must make a **DC 18 Will save** or be *delayed* in time, acting at **–5 initiative next round** and unable to take immediate or swift actions for 1 round.

Gravity Aura (Ex)
The elemental creates a localized distortion field. All movement within **10 feet** of it is treated as **difficult terrain**, and any flying creature must make a **DC 15 Fly check** each round or descend 10 feet.

Tactics

- Uses **Flyby Attack** to strike and reposition erratically
- Opens with **Spatial Disruption** to stagger the party's tempo
- Uses **Awesome Blow** to scatter frontline fighters
- Coordinates with others to split the party across fractured terrain

Clockwork Golem

Thursday, June 12, 2025 10:08 PM

Large Construct
Hit Dice: 8d10+20 (64 hp)
Initiative: –1
Speed: 30 ft.
Armor Class: 21 (–1 size, –1 Dex, +13 natural), touch 8, flat-footed 21

Base Attack/Grapple: +6/+16
Attack: Slam +11 melee (1d10+6 + *temporal shudder*)
Full Attack: 2 slams +11 melee (1d10+6 + *temporal shudder*)

Space/Reach: 10 ft./10 ft.

Special Attacks: *Temporal Shudder*
Special Qualities: Construct traits, DR 5/adamantine and magic, SR 17, *slow repair*, *partial magic immunity*

Saves: Fort +2, Ref +1, Will +3
Abilities: Str 22, Dex 8, Con —, Int —, Wis 11, Cha 1
Challenge Rating: **5**

Temporal Shudder (Su):
DC 15 Fort save or be staggered for 1 round and moved to the end of initiative order next round.

Partial Magic Immunity (Ex):
Immune to all spells except:

- *Haste* heals it for 1d6 hp
- *Slow* affects it as normal
- *Disintegrate* deals full damage
- *Greater dispel magic* can suppress its slam effect for 1 round

Slow Repair (Ex):
Regains 2 hp/hour when in contact with brass or divine alloy.

Lesser Clockwork Golem

Thursday, June 12, 2025 10:25 PM

Medium Construct
HD: 5d10+20 (47 hp)

AC: 18 (+4 natural, +2 Dex, +2 deflection vs spells), touch 14, flat-footed 16
DR: 5/adamantine and magic

Attack: Slam +7 (1d8+3 + stagger 1 rnd on failed DC 13 Fort save)

Saves: Fort +1, Ref +3, Will +1
Speed: 40 ft. (may be halved depending on gear level)
Construct Traits, SR 13
CR 3

Tactics: Attacks whoever occupies its gear slot, then returns to passive mode

Custodian of the Broken Line

Friday, June 13, 2025 11:37 PM

CR 13

Size/Type: Large Construct (Extraplanar, Lawful)
Hit Dice: 15d10+30 (112 hp)
Initiative: +2
Speed: 30 ft., fly 30 ft. (perfect)

AC: 29 (–1 size, +2 Dex, +10 natural, +8 insight); touch 19, flat-footed 27

BAB/Grapple: +11/+22
Attack: Slam +18 melee (2d6+9 force)

Space/Reach: 10 ft./10 ft.

Special Attacks: *Reality Recoil*, *Divine Directive*, *Temporal Replay*
Special Qualities: Construct traits, DR 10/adamantine, SR 23, *Predictive Defense*, *Phase Drift*

Saves: Fort +5, Ref +7, Will +11
Abilities: Str 28, Dex 15, Con —, Int 14, Wis 22, Cha 18
Skills: Knowledge (history) +20, Sense Motive +22, Listen +20, Spot +20
Feats: Power Attack, Improved Bull Rush, Combat Reflexes, Iron Will, Improved Initiative

Environment: Fallen Zahr al-Narās, Room 10
Alignment: Lawful Neutral
Advancement: —
Organization: Solitary

SPECIAL ABILITIES

Reality Recoil (Su) – 1/round

As an immediate action, the Custodian can force any creature within 60 feet to re-roll a successful d20 roll it made last round (attack, save, or check). The new result stands.
"*This is not how it was written.*"

Divine Directive (Su) – 2/day

As a standard action, the Custodian designates one PC as "*out of alignment with the Grand Harmonic.*" The PC must succeed on a Will save (DC 21) or be subjected to a geas-like compulsion for 3 rounds, such as:

- Must attack a specific target
- Cannot speak or cast spells
- Must retreat from the Custodian
- Must protect another character

Disobeying deals 2d6 nonlethal damage and imposes –2 to all actions for 1 round due to fate backlash.

Temporal Replay (Su) – 1/encounter

As a full-round action, the Custodian reverses time for one target, forcing them to repeat their last turn (same movement, same action). The target must make a Will save DC 22 to resist or be forced into the rewind.

The Custodian intones: *"The script was not honored. Repetition is required."*

Predictive Defense (Ex)

The Custodian has an insight bonus to AC equal to +8. When struck by a critical hit or failed save, the bonus is suppressed for 1 round as fate “lapses.”

Phase Drift (Su)

Each round, roll 1d6:

- **1–3**: nothing
- **4–5**: Custodian gains concealment (20%) as it becomes "unsynchronized"
- 6: Custodian briefly exists 1 round ahead: gains an extra move or standard action this round

TACTICS

- Opens with **Divine Directive** to split party behavior
- Uses **Reality Recoil** on clutch saves or crits
- Activates **Phase Drift** to keep players off balance
- Will attempt **Temporal Replay** if a PC gets close to breaking it — essentially a soft “stun” mechanic

Overview

Sunday, June 15, 2025 11:11 AM

A four-person elite strike team sworn to Sirr al-Nar. Each carries a sliver of a corrupted dream-gem, distorting their powers and fate.

Ashblade Bramm, the Burning Maw

Sunday, June 15, 2025 11:11 AM

Premise: Once a desert champion sworn to protect the weak, Bramm's fate was rewritten by a dream-gem seeded with Sirr al-Nar's will. His past is gone—burned clean. His future? Singular and absolute.

Visual Style: Towering, shirtless warrior in scorched brass lamellar. His **falchion** glows with ashfire runes, and his body bears ritual scarring in patterns that flicker with unread fate-scripts.

Human Fighter 2 / Barbarian 7
Alignment: Lawful Evil
Hit Points: 98
AC: 18 (10 + 4 armor + 2 Dex + 2 deflection), 16 flat-footed
Speed: 40 ft.
Init: +2

Stats: Str 18, Dex 14, Con 14, Int 10, Wis 8, Cha 12
Attack:
+1 Falchion of Ashfire: +14/+9 (2d4+5 + 2d6 Fire damage, 18–20/x2 crit)

While Raging:
Stats (Raging): Str 22, Dex 14, Con 18, Int 10, Wis 8, Cha 12
Attack:
+1 Falchion of Ashfire: +16/+11 (2d4+7 + 2d6 Fire damage, 18–20/x2 crit)

Feats: Power Attack, Cleave, Leap Attack, Shock Trooper *(CWar),* Weapon Focus (Falchion), Improved Bull Rush, Reckless Charge *(if you want a +2 attack/-2 AC charge boost)*

Key Features:

Rage (3/day):
+4 Str, +4 Con, +2 Will, –2 AC, lasts 9 rounds

Equipment

- Falchion of Ashfire +1 (custom weapon infused with echoing heat from Sirr al-Nar's flame
- Mithral Breastplate +1
- Ring of Protection +2
- Amulet of Health +2
- Potion of Enlarge Person
- 1 Dream-Gem sliver embedded in a shoulder pauldron—grants Rage duration +1 and makes him immune to confusion.

Veyra the Dream-Stitched

Sunday, June 15, 2025 11:22 AM

Human Sorcerer 9 (Sirr al-Nar loyalist)
CR 9 | LE Medium Humanoid (Human)
Init +2 | **Speed** 30 ft
HP 43 (9d4+18)
AC 17 (10 + 2 Dex + 3 deflection + 2 natural [Dream-Gem Infusion])
Base Attack/Grapple +4 / +4
Saves: Fort +5, Ref +5, Will +8

Attributes: STR 10 | DEX 14 | CON 14 | INT 12 | WIS 10 | CHA 20 (18 base +2 cloak)

Skills: Bluff +17, Concentration +14, Spellcraft +13, Knowledge (Arcana) +10, Sense Motive +5, Disguise +7 (+9 when using magic)

Feats: Spell Focus (Enchantment), Sculpt Spell (Complete Arcane), Heighten Spell, Fell Drain (Libris Mortis), Eschew Materials

Spells

Spells (CL 9, DC 15 + spell level, +1 Enchantment)

- 0 (6/day): Detect Magic, Message, Prestidigitation, Ghost Sound, Mage Hand, Light
- 1st (7/day): *Charm Person*, *Mage Armor*, *Silent Image*, *Ray of Enfeeblement*
- 2nd (7/day): *Mirror Image*, *Blindness/Deafness*, *Scorching Ray*
- 3rd (5/day): *Displacement*, *Slow*, *Suggestion*
- 4th (3/day): *Phantasmal Killer*, *Greater Invisibility*

Special Abilities

Dream-Gem Infusion (Custom): +2 natural armor, Immune to sleep effects and *Dream*-tagged spells, 1/day: Force reroll of a Will save vs. one of her spells

Dream Echo (Faction Boon): If a target fails a save vs. an Enchantment or Illusion, they lose their next AoO and cannot repeat last round's action

Possessions

- **Cloak of Charisma +2**
- **Ring of Protection +3**
- **Bracers of Armor +2**
- **Circlet of Dream-Ward (custom):** 1/day reroll failed Will save vs. mind-affecting
- Dream-Gem embedded in eye socket
- Scroll: *Dominate Person* x1 (for emergencies)
- 3x Potions: *Fly*, *Shield*, *Expeditious Retreat*

Tactics

- Begins combat with **Mage Armor** and **Mirror Image**
- Uses **Displacement** or **Greater Invisibility** before moving to control the battlefield
- Opens with **Slow**, **Suggestion**, or *Fell Draining Ray of Enfeeblement*
- Keeps **Phantasmal Killer** in reserve for isolated PCs or wounded targets
- If cornered: *Blindness/Deafness* → *Expeditious Retreat* to flee
- Will *never* use lethal force unless ordered by Seraphine or the Furnace pulses

The Warden of Errors

Sunday, June 15, 2025 11:26 AM

Brazen Warblade 6 / Fighter 3 (CR 9)
LN Medium Construct (Living Construct)
Init +1 | **Speed** 30 ft
HP 92 (6d12 + 3d10 + 27)
AC 21 (10 + 8 armor + 1 Dex + 2 natural)
Base Attack/Grapple +9 / +14
Saves Fort +10, Ref +6, Will +5

Attributes: STR 20 | DEX 12 | CON 16 | INT 12 | WIS 10 | CHA 6

Full Attack:
+1 True Brass Maul: +13/+8 (2d6+7 dmg; bypass DR for celestials and constructs)

Skills: Intimidate +8, Concentration +14, Balance +5, Jump +12, Knowledge (Tactics) +8

Feats: Power Attack, Improved Bull Rush, Iron Will, Weapon Focus (Maul), Combat Reflexes, Mage Slayer *(Complete Arcane)*

Special Abilities

Echo Memory: Will save (DC 13) or dazed 1 round when first seeing a Celestine relic

Celestine Echo (Su): 1/day reroll failed Will save vs compulsion/charm

Warblade (Tome of Battle)

- **Maneuvers Readied (4):**
  - *Steel Wind* (strike 2 enemies)
  - *Iron Heart Surge* (remove one ongoing effect)
  - *Wall of Blades* (use attack roll as AC)
  - *White Raven Tactics* (ally takes extra turn)
- **Stances:**
  - *Punishing Stance* (+1d6 melee damage, –2 AC)
  - *Bolstering Voice* (allies within 10 ft get +2 Will saves)
- **Battle Clarity:** +1 to Reflex saves when unarmored
- **Weapon Aptitude:** Can swap weapon-specific feats each day

Unmake Pattern (Su): 1/day, as a free action, cancel one targeted spell or SLA directed at him (as if by *greater dispel magic*, CL 9, counterspells only)

Recursive Strike (Ex): If he misses a melee attack and the same PC hits him that round, he can reroll the missed attack once (1/round)

Equipment (~36k gp)

- True Brass Maul +1: 2d6+7 base, bypasses DR of constructs and celestials
- Adamantine Full Plate +1
- Amulet of Health +2
- Belt of Giant Strength +2
- Ring of Deflection +1
- Boots of Stability (+4 to resist bull rush, trip, etc.)

Tactics

- Begins in *Punishing Stance*, charging forward to bull rush a caster or control target
- Combines **Mage Slayer** with **White Raven Tactics** to harass support characters
- Uses **Wall of Blades** defensively if targeted by touch spells
- **Iron Heart Surge** removes *Slow*, *Blindness*, or *Hold Person*
- Retreats only if Seraphine commands it—otherwise fights until deactivated

Seraphine Blackwake, Oracle of Ashes

Sunday, June 15, 2025 11:32 AM

Cleric 6 / Hierarch of Zaneth 3
CR 9 | CE Medium Humanoid (Human)
Init +0 | **Speed** 30 ft
HP 71 (6d8 + 3d6 + 27)
AC 19 (10 + 5 armor + 2 deflection + 2 shield)
Base Attack/Grapple +6 / +6
Saves Fort +8, Ref +4, Will +12

Attributes: STR 10 | DEX 10 | CON 14 | INT 12 | WIS 18 (16 base +2 item) | CHA 14

Skills: Knowledge (Religion) +14, Sense Motive +10, Concentration +12, Spellcraft +9, Bluff +7

Feats: Spell Focus (Enchantment), Extra Turning, Divine Defiance *(Fiendish Codex II: immediate action counterspell with a turning attempt),* Improved Turning *(from Reckoning domain)*

Domains

- **Ash** (resistance to fire 5, *Burning Hands*, *Scorching Ray*, *Searing Light*, etc.)
- **Fate** (1/day force enemy to reroll)

Class Features – Hierarch of Zaneth

- Dispel Order 2/day (Sp): as *dispel law*
- Discordant Chant (Su): 1/encounter, prevent a foe from taking readied or delayed actions (Will negates DC 17)
- Inversion Doctrine (Su): Sacrifice spell slot to force reroll on failed save vs. confusion/illusion
- Liturgical Schism (Ex): Lawful foes within 10 ft take –2 to saves vs. her divine spells
- Iconoclast's Rebuttal (Su): 1/day, when affected by mind-affecting effect, force the source to save or suffer *confusion* for 1 round (Will DC 17)

Spellcasting (CL 9; DC 14 + spell level)

- *0:* Detect Magic, Guidance, Light, Resistance, Read Magic, Create Water
- *1:* Divine Favor, Command, Shield of Faith, Doom, Obscuring Mist, **Burning Hands (Ash)**
- *2:* Hold Person, Silence, Spiritual Weapon, **Scorching Ray (Ash)**, Bull's Strength
- *3:* Dispel Magic, Prayer, **Searing Light (Ash)**, Bestow Curse
- *4:* Flame Strike, **Mark of Justice**, **Divination (Fate)**

Equipment

- **Ashen Mantle of the Heresiarch:** +2 deflection to AC, +2 saves vs. Lawful spells, wearer cannot be tracked by *Divination*
- +1 Breastplate
- **Rod of Defiance (custom):** 3/day, as a swift action, can grant +2 DC to a spell that affects a Lawful outsider or paladin
- **Periapt of Wisdom +2**
- **Scrolls (x3):** *Confusion*, *Greater Magic Weapon*, *Restoration*
- **Holy Symbol of Zaneth (obsidian sun chained shut)**

Tactics

- Opens with **Shield of Faith**, **Silence**, or **Hold Person**

- Uses **Flame Strike** or **Dispel Magic** to neutralize enemy buffs
- Targets paladins, Lawful outsiders, or Myrian PCs first
- Activates **Discordant Chant** to ruin timing-based tactics
- **Iconoclast's Rebuttal** triggers on charm/daze/fear spells—*Confusion* retaliation
- Uses *Mark of Justice* for long-term punishment if a PC flees
- Retreats only if Bramm is down or her holy symbol is shattered

Overview

Sunday, June 15, 2025 11:37 AM

A four-person strike cell empowered by the Temple of Red Prophecy. Their mission is to gather dream-gems, awaken Zaneth's flame, and burn away the false sun.

They are not subtle. They are not here to negotiate. They believe *truth lives in suffering*, and the party is simply a delay in its arrival.

Vokhul the Devoured

Sunday, June 15, 2025 11:41 AM

"Each scar speaks. Each burn remembers."

Male Human Barbarian 5 / Paladin of Zaneth 4
Alignment*:* Lawful Evil
Type*:* Humanoid (Human)
Init +1 | **Speed** 40 ft
HP 95 (5d12 + 4d10 + 27)
AC 18 (10 + 6 armor + 1 Dex + 1 deflection)
BAB/Grapple: +9 / +12
Saves: Fort +12, Ref +5, Will +6

Attributes: STR 16 | DEX 13 | CON 16 | INT 10 | WIS 12 | CHA 14
(Rage: STR 20, CON 20 → +2 attack/damage, +2 Fort, +18 HP)

Full Attack:
Ash-Forged Flail +1: +10/+6 (1d8+6, 19-20/x2, +1d6 fire vs. dream-gem users or Lawful)

While Raging:
Ash-Forged Flail +1: +12/+8 (1d8+8, 19-20/x2, +1d6 fire vs. dream-gem users or Lawful)

Skills: Intimidate +14, Ride +8, Knowledge (Religion) +7, Survival +9, Sense Motive +6, Concentration +11

Feats: Power Attack, Cleave, Extra Rage, Divine Might *(SpC)* — spend Turn Undead to add CHA to damage for 1 round, Weapon Focus (Flail), Brutal Charge (Complete Warrior) — add extra damage on charge while raging

Class Features

Barbarian (UA Variant: Spiritual Totem – Lion)

- Rage 3/day
- Fast Movement
- **Pounce:** Full attack at the end of a charge
  Uncanny Dodge

Paladin of Zaneth (see Barizad p.105):

- Smite the Faithless 2/day: +4 to hit, +9 damage vs. Lawful, Brass-loyal, or celestial-aligned foes
- Read the Cinders: Detect "cold-soul" creatures (as *Detect Good* for chaotic/neutral evil)
- Burning Insight: Divine Grace using fire symbolism (CHA to saves)
- Flame of Resolve: Lay on Hands restyled — heals HP, but leaves scar

Equipment

- **Ash-Forged Flail +1 (Chained Flamehead):**
  - 1d8+6 base, 19–20/x2, +1d6 fire vs. dream-gem users or Lawful-aligned creatures
- **Scorched Plate of Veneration (+1 Breastplate):** Heat-scarred ceremonial armor, glows faintly during rage
- **Amulet of Health +2**
- **Ring of Protection +1**
- **Brass Tether (Wondrous Item):** While raging, prevents involuntary movement (bull rush, telekinesis, etc.)

Tactics

- **Opener:** Activates Rage + Smite + Divine Might + charges using Pounce
- **Main Combo:** Full-attack with **Power Attack** (–2 to hit, +4 dmg) on each strike
- **Target Priorities:** Priests, prophets, paladins, or Myrian foes
- **Recklessness:** Will fight through *Prayer*, *Bestow Curse*, or *Flame Strike* effects if "the Vision" demands it

Visual & Flavor

- Burn-scarred torso etched with black-inked glyphs of Zaneth's prophecy
- Teeth filed. Left eye replaced with a seared brass disc engraved with a broken prophecy line
- Speaks in short, declarative phrases. Believes his rage is sacred communion

Naehri of the Thorn-Dream

Sunday, June 15, 2025 11:48 AM

Female Human Cleric 6 / Hierarch of Zaneth 3
Alignment: Chaotic Evil
Type: Humanoid (Human)
Init +1 | **Speed** 30 ft
HP: 63 (6d8 + 3d6 + 18)
AC: 20 (10 + 6 armor + 1 Dex + 2 deflection + 1 sacred flame)
BAB/Grapple: +6 / +6
Saves: Fort +9, Ref +4, Will +12

Attributes: STR 10 | DEX 12 | CON 14 | INT 12 | WIS 18 (16 base +2 item) | CHA 14

Skills: Concentration +12, Knowledge (Religion) +14, Spellcraft +10, Sense Motive +8, Heal +7, Intimidate +6

Feats: Spell Focus (Enchantment), Extra Turning, Divine Defiance *(Fiendish Codex II)* — immediate action counterspell with turning, Improved Turning

Domains
- **Ash:** resistance to fire 5, adds *Burning Hands*, *Scorching Ray*, *Searing Light*
- **Dream:** adds *Sleep*, *Augury*, *Phantasmal Killer*

Hierarch of Zaneth Features
- **Dispel Order 2/day (Sp)** – as *dispel law*
- **Discordant Chant (Su):** once/encounter, prevent ready/delay (Will DC 17)
- **Inversion Doctrine (Su):** sacrifice spell to force reroll on failed save vs. confusion/illusion
- **Liturgical Schism (Ex):** Lawful foes get –2 to saves vs her divine spells
- **Iconoclast's Rebuttal (Su):** 1/day, when affected by mind-affecting, enemy saves or suffers *confusion* (Will DC 17)

Spells (CL 9, DC 14 + spell level)
- *0:* Detect Magic, Light, Guidance, Resistance, Mending, Create Water
- *1:* Shield of Faith, Command, Obscuring Mist, Divine Favor, Doom, *Burning Hands (Ash)*
- *2:* Hold Person, Spiritual Weapon, Silence, *Scorching Ray (Ash)*, Augury
- *3:* Dispel Magic, Bestow Curse, Prayer, *Searing Light (Ash)*, Phantasmal Killer
- *4:* Flame Strike, *Confusion (Dream)*, Divination

Equipment
- **Red-Soot Robes of the Oracle:** +2 deflection to AC, wearer gains +2 save DC vs Lawful creatures
- **Hierophant's Staff:** +1 Quarterstaff that adds +1 CL to fire spells
- **Periapt of Wisdom +2**
- **Censer of Smothering Insight (custom):** 1/day, create smoke cloud; all within must save (Will DC 17) or lose access to one 3rd-level spell for 1 round
- Dream-gem fragment embedded in her chest, veined with scarred ash-lines

Tactics
- Begins with *Obscuring Mist* or *Silence* to control space
- Targets lawful or Myrian PCs with *Hold Person* → *Searing Light*
- Uses **Discordant Chant** to ruin time-sensitive PC tactics

- Activates **Iconoclast's Rebuttal** against *Hold*, *Charm*, or *Fear*
- Sacrifices lower-level spells to force rerolls via **Inversion Doctrine**

Visual & Flavor

- Blind (self-inflicted); eyes burned shut with incense-charcoal, replaced with dream-sight
- Hair shorn, robes always slightly smoking
- Speaks in riddled aphorisms: *"The smoke that blinds the seer clears the way for truth."*

Sister Yussa, Mouth of Cinders

Sunday, June 15, 2025 11:50 AM

Female Human Warlock 9
Alignment: Chaotic Evil
Type: Humanoid (Human)
Init +2 | **Speed** 30 ft / 60 ft fly (perfect)
HP: 63 (9d6 + 18)
AC: 21 (10 + 2 Dex + 5 armor + 2 deflection + 2 insight)
BAB/Grapple: +6 / +6
Saves: Fort +5, Ref +5, Will +8

Attributes: STR 10 | DEX 14 | CON 14 | INT 12 | WIS 10 | CHA 18

Skills: Intimidate +15, Bluff +14, Use Magic Device +16, Concentration +14, Knowledge (Arcana) +12, Sense Motive +10

Feats: Point Blank Shot, Fell Flight *(invocation feat),* Mortalbane *(Libris Mortis, +2d6 vs. living, 5/day),* Quicken SLA (*Eldritch Blast*, 1/day as swift action)

Spellcasting

Invocations (CL 9, DC 14 + spell level)
Least:
- *Eldritch Spear* (250 ft)
- *Beguiling Influence* (+6 Bluff/Diplomacy/Intimidate)
- *Dark One's Own Luck* (add CHA to one save as luck bonus)

Lesser:
- *Fell Flight* (constant, 60 ft perfect flight)
- *Chilling Tentacles* (as *Black Tentacles* + 2d6 cold/round)
- *Eldritch Cone* (30-ft cone, 3d6, Ref half)
- *See the Unseen* (see invisibility + darkvision)

Blast Essence:
- *Vitriolic Blast* (acid damage, continues next round)
- *Frightful Blast* (Will save or shaken for 1 minute)

Eldritch Blast

- 3d6 base damage (up to 5d6 with Mortalbane)
- Can be delivered as *Eldritch Spear*, *Cone*, or *Vitriolic*
- Can be Quicken-blasted 1/day

Special Traits

- **Speech of Ashes (Su):** Whenever she speaks, all living creatures within 10 ft take 1 psychic damage/round (Will DC 13 negates; once/round)
- **Ash Aura (Su):** 3/day, as a swift action, may cause all terrain within 10 ft to count as difficult terrain for 2 rounds
- **Immunity to charm and compulsion** (via pact scarification)

Equipment

- **Veil of Embers (custom headband):** +2 Insight AC, wearer cannot be located by *scrying*
- **+1 Mithral Chain Shirt (burn-scorched)**
- **Ring of Protection +2**
- **Cloak of Charisma +2**

- **Ash-sigiled Focus Stone:** +1 caster level on invocations with a duration or area

Tactics

- Begins *flying* high with *See the Unseen* and *Dark One's Own Luck* active
- Drops *Chilling Tentacles* in midst of enemy ranks or to split battlefield
- Uses **Quicken Eldritch Blast** + *Frightful or Vitriolic* combo on vulnerable PCs
- Engages support casters or ranged characters from above
- Will flee if reduced below 25% HP unless Naehri is still standing

Visual & Flavor

- Wears a half-mask of scorched porcelain, cracked at the mouth
- Speaks softly, but her words burn like scripture
- Was once a noble from Varnash, gave her name and family to the Temple in exchange for prophecy

Thorrak Rootbound, Grove-Spawn of Haran'Set

Sunday, June 15, 2025 11:55 AM

- **Visuals:** Bark-covered skin; fungus colonies grow from his shoulders and crawl like insects. Eyes milky green. Voice like wet leaves tearing.
- **Animal Companion:** A massive, blackened boar with mushrooms growing from its spine.
- **Beliefs:** All empires rot. Haran'Set is the proof. The gems are *germination*—fate is compost.

Male Half-Orc Druid 9
Alignment: Neutral Evil
CR: 9
Faction: Aram-Zaneth (ally), Black Groves of Haran'Set (native)
Theme: Fungus-infected wild shaman who believes dream-gems are seeds of apocalyptic bloom
HP: 80 (9d8+36)
AC: 21 (10 + 4 armor + 2 Dex + 2 natural + 3 shield)
Saves: Fort +10 | Ref +5 | Will +9
Speed: 30 ft
BAB/Grapple: +6 / +8
Init: +2

Feats: Natural Spell, Power Attack, Ashen Birth *(regional feat: summon fungi, ignore concealment in fog or smoke),* Greenbound Summoning *(Lost Empires of Faerûn: summons gain plant traits)*

Key Features

- **Wild Shape (2/day):** Prefers **Dire Wolf** or **Large Venomous Snake** forms
- **Spontaneous Summoning (PHB2 alt rule):** Sacrifice a spell to cast *summon nature's ally* of same level
- **Animal Companion:** *Dire Boar* with +4 HD, +4 Str, +2 natural armor
- **Trackless Step, Woodland Stride, Resist Nature's Lure**

Spells (CL 9, DC 14 + spell level)

- **0:** Create Water, Detect Magic, Guidance, Purify Food & Drink, Resistance, Mending
- **1:** Entangle, Produce Flame, Obscuring Mist, Faerie Fire, Pass without Trace
- **2:** Barkskin, Flame Blade, Soften Earth and Stone, Summon Swarm
- **3:** Poison, Greater Magic Fang, Quench, Contagion
- **4:** Flame Strike, Antiplant Shell, Reincarnate

Equipment

- **Crown of Spores:** Constant *Speak with Plants*, 1/day *Confusion* (plants only, but includes greenbound summons)
- **Fungal Wraps (Armor):** +4 hide armor, +2 vs poison/disease, summons count as being in natural terrain
- **Amulet of Natural Armor +2**
- **Ring of Protection +1**
- **Staff of Rotting Flame** *(custom: counts as +1 quarterstaff; grants 1 extra use of Flame Strike per day)*

Tactics

- Opens with *Entangle*, *Obscuring Mist*, or *Summon Swarm*
- Turns into **Dire Wolf** to flank with companion for trip/sneak combo

- Uses **Poison** and **Contagion** on martial characters
- Spams **Summon Nature's Ally IV** with Greenbound for aggressive battlefield saturation
- Retreats only to preserve the seed-body for rebirth

Standard Races

Friday, June 6, 2025 11:40 PM

Humans

The dominant race of Barizad, humans are as diverse and multifaceted as the lands they inhabit. Every major civilization—be it the theocratic halls of Aram-Zaneth, the Satrapies of Varnash, or the wandering Zifari tribes—is shaped by human ambition, philosophy, and error. Adaptable, driven, and deeply entangled in the broken weave of fate, humans strive to reclaim the dreams scattered by the fall of Zahr al-Narās, whether through conquest, communion, or heresy.

Dwarves

Stalwart and obsessive, dwarves once served as stewards and engineers in the auxiliary vaults of the Brass City. Though most of their great forges and libraries were lost in the calamity, some still carry ancient schemata etched into their bones. They are perfectionists in craft and creed, haunted by a half-remembered sense of divine purpose. Many now seek fragments of True Brass, not for power—but to restore their people's forgotten role in fate’s machinery.

Elves

Elves are a rare and distant people in Barizad, hailing from a far-off land untouched by the fall of the Brass City. Their long lives and alien customs make them enigmatic figures in local eyes—neither part of the Celestine design nor wholly separate from its influence. Some whisper that the elves’ ancestors were intentionally excluded from the writing of fate, though whether as punishment or preservation is unknown even to them.

Halflings

Halflings are found almost exclusively among the Zifari tribes, where they serve as guides, omen-readers, and cunning traders. They are regarded as “slippery” by many fatebound societies, blessed with luck or cursed with exemption from destiny. Halflings move through the world with an intuitive grace, often interpreting the signs others overlook—cracks in a salt pan, the flicker of wind in tent canvas, or the sound of laughter just before a storm.

Half-Elves

Caught between the mortal and the ineffable, half-elves carry a spiritual dissonance that marks them as outsiders even among their kin. Many are drawn to the heresies of Aram-Zaneth or wander as dream-seekers, interpreters, or scholars of lost prophecy. Their blood is both a blessing and a burden—proof of union, but also of contradiction—and the gears of fate grind uncomfortably around them.

Half-orcs

Half-orcs in Barizad are most often born of violence—products of border raids, punitive campaigns, or cycles of captivity between orcish warbands and the dominant human nations. Orcs, when captured, are frequently enslaved by satrapies or frontier provinces, used as labor or shock troops in conflicts not their own. Half-orcs arise from these grim exchanges, and their presence is a source of discomfort, shame, or suspicion in nearly every culture.

Few are afforded dignity. Many grow up as outcasts, pressed into servitude or forced to prove their worth tenfold. Yet those who survive often possess remarkable resilience, keen instincts, and a burning desire to become more than what others assume of them. In a world obsessed with fate and order, half-orcs are unchosen children of consequence—and they carry that weight with unbreakable grit.

Ifriqa

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:37 PM

The Ifriqa arise from unions between mortals and djinn. They appear mostly human, but elemental halos betray their origin: a shimmer of heat, a glow of shadow, or hair that flickers like kindled threads. Many Ifriqa live under divine pacts or ancestral contracts, their lives shaped by bindings older than memory. Some are honored as bridges between worlds; others are feared as "walking war relics," ticking with latent power. Proud and unpredictable, the Ifriqa carry within them both spark and storm—and are never truly unbound.

Subtypes: Emberborn (fire), Windcalled (air), Quartz-Touched (earth), Drowned-Voiced (water/dream)

In Game

Type: Outsider (Native, Elemental-Blooded)
LA: +1
Ability Modifiers: +2 Charisma, +2 Dexterity, –2 Constitution
Speed: 30 ft.
Special Traits:

- **Elemental Legacy:** Choose one elemental aspect at 1st level (Fire, Air, Earth, or Dream-Water). You gain a corresponding ability:
  - **Fire (Ashblood):** 1/day *Produce Flame* as a spell-like ability (CL = HD)
  - **Air (Whirlskin):** +10 ft. movement speed; counts as feather fall at will if unarmored
  - **Earth (Quartzborn):** DR vs bludgeoning weapons equal to half HD (rounded up)
  - **Water/Dream (Drowned-Voiced):** 1/day *Hypnotism* as a spell-like ability (CL = HD)
- **Djinni-Bound:** +2 bonus on Diplomacy checks with Outsiders and elementals
- **Unstable Lineage:** You radiate faint planar resonance detectable with *Detect Chaos* or *Detect Magic*

Drawback – Elemental Inheritance: If reduced below 0 HP, roll d%. On 01–10, your elemental side flares unpredictably (GM's choice: wild fire burst, ethereal shift, etc.)
Favored Class: Sorcerer or Bard (depending on aspect)

Nimari

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:38 PM

The Nimari are a people claimed by Nimurah's mirror-sea, often born during high tide, dream-storms, or moments when the boundaries between sleep and prophecy thin. Their eyes gleam like still water, and their voices carry harmonic undertones that hint at deeper meanings. Shaped by a culture as fluid as the tides, Nimari move through identities and allegiances with grace, sometimes to the frustration of more rigid societies. They resent being "fixed" into roles or names and are often drawn to mysticism, artistry, diplomacy, or double lives. Some believe their souls reflect hidden truths others cannot face—and fear or envy them accordingly.

In Game:
Type: Humanoid (Tideborn, Extraplanar)
LA: +0
Ability Modifiers: +2 Charisma, –2 Strength
Speed: 30 ft. (Swim 20 ft. if born near deep waters)
Special Traits:

- **Echo Voice:** 1/day, reroll any failed Bluff or Diplomacy check. Must accept second result.
- **Tide-Blooded:** +2 bonus on saves vs enchantment spells and effects.
- **Dream-Drifter:** +2 bonus on Knowledge (The Planes) and Perform (Song or Oratory).
- **Mirror-Born:** Once per day, you may cast *Silent Image* as a spell-like ability (CL = HD).
- **Languages:** Automatically speak Dreamtongue and Aquan, in addition to Common.

Drawback – Mercurial Soul: –2 penalty on Sense Motive checks against lawful-aligned creatures. Your fluid identity makes it hard to concentrate.

Brazen

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:39 PM

Forged in the celestial heart of Zahr al-Narās, the **Brazen** are living constructs made from **True Brass and other sacred alloys**, each etched with a divine fragment of forgotten purpose. Once tools of fate's machinery, many awakened into full sapience only after the City's fall—haunted by "echo memories" of its final hours. Revered by some as monuments, resented by others as reminders of ruin, the Brazen now seek their own paths. A few long to "reboot" the old order; others crave nothing more than the freedom to reject it. Each Brazen bears both legacy and burden in every footstep.

In Game:
Type: Construct (Living Construct)
LA: +1
Ability Modifiers: +2 Constitution, –2 Wisdom
Speed: 30 ft.
Special Traits:

- **Living Construct Traits:** Immune to poison, sleep effects, paralysis, disease, nausea, fatigue, exhaustion, energy drain. Not immune to mind-affecting effects. Healed by both cure spells and repair spells.
- **Celestine Echo:** You contain a fragment of Brass City directive code. Once per day, you may reroll a failed Will save vs compulsion or charm.
- **Reinforced Chassis:** Natural Armor +1.
- **Function Slot:** Choose a subroutine at 1st level (may reflavor as a background memory):
    - **Archivist:** +2 on Knowledge (History), may reroll 1 failed check/day
    - **Shield-Relay:** Free action 1/day to grant ally +1 deflection bonus to AC for 1 round
    - **Pulse Beacon:** 1/day *Light* and *Message* simultaneously (nonmagical)

Drawback – Echo Memory: Whenever you witness a Celestine relic, roll Will DC 13 or suffer a 1-round daze as ancient memory floods your mind.

Emerald Courts

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:41 PM

Star-blooded mortals shaped by ritual, embalming, and soul-navigation.

- +1 Wisdom, -1 Strength: Introspective and spiritually attuned, but not always physically robust.
- +2 bonus on Knowledge (Religion) and Heal checks.
- Resist Sleep and Fear effects (+2 racial bonus on saves).
- Culturally reverent of burial traditions; desecrating the dead is a grave taboo (–2 on social rolls in their society if violated).

Aram-Zaneth

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:42 PM

Fate-deniers and subverters of divine architecture.

- +1 Intelligence, -1 Charisma: Brilliant and cunning, but often unsettling or intense.
- +2 bonus on Knowledge (Arcana) and Use Magic Device.
- Gain SR = 5 + character level against divination spells or effects (can lower it willingly).
- May choose one divination spell they are always aware of when it is cast within 30 ft, even if not targeted.
- –1 penalty on **saving throws against illusions**; they often over-analyze.

Varnash

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:43 PM

Imperial aristocrats blessed by True Brass and sovereign heritage.

- +1 Charisma, -1 Wisdom: Commanding and proud, but not always cautious.
- +2 bonus on Diplomacy and Craft (True Brass).
- Once per day, may reroll a failed saving throw vs mind-affecting effects (must keep second roll).
- –2 penalty on social rolls when visibly disheveled, unarmored, or bearing visible injuries.

Nisarun

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:45 PM

Canny, tidebound mariners with dreams and secrets in their blood.

- +1 Dexterity, -1 Constitution: Nimble and adaptive, but not always hardy.
- +2 bonus on Bluff and Profession (Sailor).
- Gain Low-Light Vision and +2 bonus on saves vs illusions.
- –2 penalty on Diplomacy checks with lawful-aligned creatures.

Myrian Halls

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:46 PM

Archivists of prophecy and celestial resonance through written record.

- +1 Intelligence, -1 Dexterity: Precise but physically deliberate.
- +2 bonus on Decipher Script and Knowledge (History).
- May cast Read Magic at will as a spell-like ability.
- Must take a full-round action to draw or read any written item or scroll unless a DC 15 Concentration check is passed.

Zifari

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:48 PM

Wanderers of the deep desert, singers of uncharted stars, and keepers of the old rhythm.

- +1 Wisdom, -1 Intelligence: Insightful and intuitive, but less bound to academic structure.
- +2 bonus on Survival and Perform (Oratory).
- Gain Endurance as a bonus feat at 1st level.
- Cannot use any spell with a written component (scrolls, runes, etc.) unless it has been translated orally by a known source.

Character Archetypes

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:56 PM

The scattered peoples of Barizad draw their strength from shattered legacies, enduring traditions, and the strange echoes of fate that drift through the dunes and ruins. While standard character classes remain mechanically unchanged, their cultural interpretations and origins reflect the fractured world around them.

Fighters

Fighters in Barizad are often shaped by their allegiance or environment. Many hail from the **Brassguard of Varnash**, elite warriors clad in ceremonial armor infused with True Brass, sworn to defend sacred forges and reliquaries. Others are **Ashguards**, battlefield sentinels hardened by the volcanic rifts of Aram-Zaneth. **Hollowforged Shield-Bearers** are stoic defenders who train alongside the remnants of warforged relics, their fighting styles echoing ancient doctrines lost to the fall. Nomadic Zifari fighters ride ahead of merchant trains or defend them from raiders, bandits, and worse.

Rogues

Rogues blend cunning with cultural adaptability. **Zifari pathfinders** serve as scouts and horizon-watchers, skilled in both reading the dunes and vanishing into them. In contrast, **Nisari smugglers** ply the shadowed ports of the Shining Coast, manipulating trade laws and secret routes with equal deftness. Most elusive of all are the **Mirror-Scribes**, operatives who encode espionage into calligraphy and illusion, often on behalf of hidden powers.

Barbarians

Barbarians are driven by fury both personal and inherited. **Desert-berserkers** are sand-blasted reavers drawn from nomadic tribes or exiled settlements, while **flame-haunted raiders** delve into the fragments of the Brass City itself—fighting not only what lurks within, but the city's lingering madness. Among the Zifari, the **wind howlers** are spiritual warriors who claim to hear omens in the desert winds, unleashing storm-screams as they charge into battle.

Bards

Bards in Barizad are keepers of oral history and subtle influence. **Zifari fate-singers** weave prophecy into their ballads, guiding caravans or confusing enemies through verse. **Nimari dream-orators** are masters of evocative storytelling, drawing both inspiration and arcane power from the fractured dream-echoes of the fallen Brass City. The **Nisari contract-chanters**, by contrast, use binding recitations and tonal shifts to twist meaning in trade deals, performative rites, or magical pacts.

Monks

Monks are rare but revered, often **relic-keepers** who train in broken fragments of Celestine martial disciplines. These styles, once honed within the now-shattered halls of Zahr al-Narās, are preserved by reclusive masters—sometimes even by Hollowforged mentors, constructs who survived the city's fall and now train worthy successors in silent dedication.

Sorcerers

Sorcerers are far-and-away the most common arcane casters in Barizad, their bloodlines often tied to the Brass City's magic. Many among the Ifriqa manifest internal flame or shifting flesh. **Nimari sorcerers** might channel visions from broken prophecy, while those touched by fragments of the city inherit unstable but powerful magical traits—manifestations of the city's distorted essence.

Wizards

Wizards, by contrast, thrive in the learned traditions of Barizad. The **Myrian scholars** preserve lineage-

bound arcane formulas passed down through divine visions. **Nisari star-scribes** map the heavens to track magical phenomena, especially where fate has grown thin. Some rare **Brass City archivists**, surviving heirs to lost knowledge, scavenge the ruins for arcane blueprints, clockwork scrolls, or dream-infused glyphs.

Clerical Domains

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:57 PM

Divine Magic in a Fractured World

For many peoples in Barizad, divinity is not a fixed pantheon but a constellation of forces—some ancient, some emergent, and others broken by the fall of Zahr al-Narās. The gods that once ruled may now exist as fragments of concept, machine, or memory, and the powers that answer clerical prayers are as likely to be resonant relics or dreaming engines as traditional deities. As such, the standard Cleric domains are replaced by setting-specific reflections of Barizad's metaphysics and cultures. Each domain represents not only a source of power but a stance toward fate, time, and the shattered divine order. Clerics choose their domains according to allegiance—be it to a god, a faction, a prophetic ideal, or even a living fragment of the Brass City itself.

Mechanics

The standard Cleric domains are replaced with the following:

Domain	Affiliated Deity / Power	Factions / Peoples	Symbolic Associations
Brass	*The Celestine Furnace* (divine engine); **Zahr al-Narās**	Myrian Halls, Hollowforged, Satrapies of Varnash (traditionalists)	Order, celestial gears, binding oaths, ancient enforcement
Dream	*Nimurah*, goddess of the mirror-sea; *The Drowned Library* (conceptual)	Nimari, Zifari, Emerald Courts (rites), Nisarun	Illusion, prophecy, sleep, the unknown future, tidal fate
Trade	*Yenazra*, goddess of negotiation and wind-ink contracts; *The Market Moon*	Nisarun, Satrapies of Varnash, rogue Aram-Zaneth sects	Bargains, written word, wealth, debt, hidden gain
Reckoning	*The Mirror Falcon* (celestial avatar of judgment); *Zaneth* (vengeance aspect)	Emerald Courts, Aram-Zaneth zealots, exile inquisitors	Justice, retribution, divine accounting, exile
Ash	*The Ember That Speaks*, an apocalyptic fire-entity; funerary cults of the Emerald Courts	Emerald Courts, Zifari, flame-haunted ruin hunters	Burned prophecy, destruction, funeral purity, endings
Echo	*The Resonant Vault* (memory construct); *The First Whisper*	Myrian archivists, Hollowforged, Brass archivists	Memory, recursive magic, forgotten voices, the weight of history
Fate	*Zahr al-Narās*, personified as the Watchmaker; *The Spinner of Threads* (folk deity)	Brass-loyalists, Zifari bards, seers of many nations	Inevitability, cosmic design, prophecy, the unbroken thread

Brass Domain:
(structure, constructs, resistance, celestial machinery)

Granted Power: You gain a +1 bonus on saves vs compulsion and force effects. You may use *Detect Chaos* at will.

Level	Spell
1	*Shield of Faith*
2	*Make Whole*
3	*Magic Circle Against Chaos*
4	*Lesser Planar Ally*
5	*Wall of Force*
6	*Blade Barrier*
7	*Spell Turning*
8	*Iron Body*
9	*Gate* (called version only; must summon a lawful outsider)

Dream Domain:
(illusion, sleep, prophecy, and subconscious magic)

Granted Power: Once per day, reroll a failed Will save against a mind-affecting effect. You gain *Lucid Dreaming* (see Manual of the Planes) as a class skill.

Level	Spell
1	*Sleep*
2	*Mirror Image*
3	*Deep Slumber*
4	*Divination*
5	*False Vision*
6	*Mislead*
7	*Project Image*
8	*Greater Prying Eyes*
9	*Weird*

Trade Domain:
(commerce, negotiation, information, profit)

Granted Power: +2 bonus on Appraise and Diplomacy checks. Once per day, you may reroll a failed Sense Motive check.

Level	Spell
1	*Comprehend Languages*
2	*Zone of Truth*
3	*Tongues*
4	*Sending*
5	*Fabricate*
6	*True Seeing*

7	*Sequester*
8	*Moment of Prescience*
9	*Foresight*

Reckoning Domain:
(justice, judgment, retribution, karmic fate)

Granted Power: Once per day, when struck in melee, you may make a free melee attack of retribution. Gain *Sense Motive* as a class skill.

Level	Spell
1	*Divine Favor*
2	*Hold Person*
3	*Dispel Magic*
4	*Mark of Justice*
5	*Flame Strike*
6	*Geas/Quest*
7	*Dictum*
8	*Holy Aura*
9	*Imprisonment*

Ash Domain:
(destruction, aftermath, purification, ruin)

Granted Power: Fire resistance 5. Once per day, you may touch a corpse or ruin and cast *Detect Magic* centered on it.

Level	Spell
1	*Burning Hands*
2	*Scorching Ray*
3	*Searing Light*
4	*Fire Shield*
5	*Flame Strike*
6	*Fire Seeds*
7	*Destruction*
8	*Incendiary Cloud*
9	*Energy Drain*

Echo Domain:
(memory, time bleed, repetition, spirit resonance)

Granted Power: Once per day, you may "echo" a 1st- or 2nd-level spell you cast—cast it again next round as a free action (same target, no new spell slot).

Level	Spell
1	*Detect Thoughts*
2	*Augury*
3	*Clairaudience/Clairvoyance*
4	*Phantasmal Killer*
5	*Rary's Telepathic Bond*
6	*Analyze Dweomer*
7	*Greater Scrying*
8	*Temporal Stasis*
9	*Time Stop*

Fate Domain:
(prophecy, inevitability, control, destiny)

Granted Power: Once per day, you may force an enemy to reroll any attack roll, save, or skill check (must accept the second result).

Level	Spell
1	*Entropic Shield*
2	*Augury*
3	*Bestow Curse*
4	*Divination*
5	*Mark of Justice*
6	*Dispel Magic, Greater*
7	*Vision*
8	*Moment of Prescience*
9	*Miracle*

Paladins of Barizad

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:58 PM

The sacred champions of Barizad are not unified by creed, but by the divergent powers and philosophies that dominate the fractured world. Paladins exist in many forms across the realm, their divine calling shaped as much by metaphysics as by morality.

Orric Sentinels: Paladins of Zahr al-Narās

Brass Judges, The Clockbound

Paladins of Zahr al-Narās serve not a god, but a purpose: the restoration of cosmic order through the enforcement of destiny itself. These warriors are bound not to mundane law or to goodness, but to the inexorable will of the fallen Celestine Engine. As such, they must be Lawful Neutral, and are not subject to the usual alignment constraints of traditional paladins. Their code demands obedience to the fractured—but still resonant—mandates of Zahr al-Narās. To stray from its decrees, or to act selfishly against its designs, is to fall from grace as surely as a paladin who commits evil. These enforcers show no mercy to those who twist fate, and they are often feared even by those they defend.

Mechanics

Standard Ability	Replacement Ability	Description
Smite Evil	**Smite Blasphemer**	Functions identically, but targets those who act against the will of Zahr al-Narās or disrupt the course of fate—this includes chaotic outsiders, heretics, undead, and oathbreakers.
Detect Evil	**Sense Disjunction**	Detects creatures or objects that radiate strong chaos, corruption, or defiance of preordained fate (e.g., items that tamper with destiny, fragments of forbidden prophecy).
Divine Grace	**Celestine Mandate**	No mechanical change; boon from the Celestine Engine, granted to those acting in accordance with its design.
Lay on Hands	**Reassert Pattern**	Restores HP by resetting the body to its “correct configuration” within the pattern of fate. Can be painful to chaotic creatures.
Aura of Good	**Aura of Order**	No mechanical change; A steady field of law, precision, and inevitability.
Remove Disease	**Purge Destabilization**	Cures diseases and other ailments (as usual) by correcting anomalies in the body’s fated state.
Code of Conduct	**Mandate of the Engine**	Must act in accordance with the known or revealed will of Zahr al-Narās. Actions that defy fate or aid those who distort prophecy may cause the paladin to fall.

Knights of the Red Temple: Paladins of Aram-Zaneth

Scorchguards, Fangs of the Prophet

In stark contrast, the Paladins of Aram-Zaneth are grim zealots who see the restoration of fate as a blasphemy. They believe Zaneth’s rebellion against the city was just, and that the world must be reforged not in the image of order, but in the crucible of divine defiance. These paladins must be Lawful Evil, their oaths centered on thwarting the designs of Zahr al-Narās and aiding the spread of flame, heresy, and rebirth. They serve the Temple of Red Prophecy, and often wield relics scorched by molten brass and visions of cataclysm.

Mechanics

Standard Ability	Replacement Ability	Description
Smite Evil	**Smite the Faithless**	Targets those who deny the Red Prophecy, aid Zahr al-Narās, or seek to restore the old order. Outsiders of law or good alignment, brass relics, or Celestine agents are prime targets.
Detect Evil	**Read the Cinders**	Functions as *detect good* or *detect celestial allegiance*—reveals those whose soul burns "cold" in the eyes of prophecy.
Divine Grace	**Burning Insight**	Same effect, interpreted as fire-forged clarity from Zaneth.
Lay on Hands	**Flame of Resolve**	May sear and cauterize wounds, restoring HP but causing discomfort or scars—seen as marks of holy purpose.
Aura of Good	**Aura of Blazing Purpose**	Radiates heat and intensity, unnerving to those not aligned with Aram-Zaneth.
Remove Disease	**Cleanse by Fire**	Heals diseases by burning them away mystically—may leave minor burns or brands.
Code of Conduct	**Oath of Flame**	Must act in accordance with the Temple of Red Prophecy. Acts of mercy toward the servants of Zahr al-Narās, or failure to uphold the revolution of flame, cause the paladin to fall.

Brasswardens: Paladins of Varnash

The Gleaming Few, Gilded Blades

Within the Satrapies of Varnash, paladins take a different form altogether. Known as the Paladins of Radiance, these divine warriors act as custodians of ancient oaths and protectors of the noble houses. Each swears fealty to a house god—a patron spirit believed to be linked to the old pantheon, preserved through lineal worship and divine brass relics. Unlike their counterparts, the Radiants are less concerned with cosmic conflict and more with protecting the sanctity, wealth, and prestige of their lineage. Their powers manifest through polished armor inlaid with True Brass and ceremonial weapons blessed by household rites.

Mechanics

Standard Ability	Replacement Ability	Description
Smite Evil	**Smite the Unworthy**	Functions as usual but targets those who insult the house, defile holy relics, or commit acts of treason or dishonor. Generally chaotic-aligned beings.
Detect Evil	**Sense Dishonor**	Reveals those who have betrayed oaths, defiled relics, or committed acts of social blasphemy against the Satrap's gods or ancestors.
Divine Grace	**Ancestral Favor**	The blessings of one's lineage flowing through divine brass or remembered names.
Lay on Hands	**Touch of the Housefire**	Still heals, but often accompanied by soft radiance or flickers of ancestral sigils.
Aura of Good	**Aura of Authority**	Seen as a noble bearing that demands respect—recognized by both commoners and nobility.
Remove Disease	**Rite of Purification**	Accomplished through whispered prayers to the household god, often accompanied by ceremonial gestures or relics.

Code of Conduct	**Oath of the Radiant Line**	Must act in ways that uphold the dignity, faith, and authority of their house. Betrayal, cowardice, or sullying ancestral honor leads to atonement or fall.

Ranger

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:58 PM

Rangers and the Hunt for Meaning

In Barizad, the line between predator and prophet is thin. Rangers are more than trackers or warriors; they are interpreters of a world where every footprint may echo with fate and every quarry may carry the weight of prophecy or ruin. Rather than simply hunting species, Barizadi rangers train to recognize Favored Concepts—ideological, spiritual, or metaphysical archetypes that shape the creatures they pursue. These concepts reflect the forces that define Barizad's fractured reality: order and rebellion, dream and fire, divinity and deception. A ranger's chosen quarry speaks to their allegiance, history, and understanding of the world's broken truth. Mechanically, this feature replaces Favored Enemy, but uses the same scaling bonuses and functions in all other respects.

Mechanics

Replace Favored Enemy with Favored Concept

Concept	Covers Creatures Like…	Notes
Servants of the Brass City	Hollowforged, inevitables, brass-bound constructs, loyal celestials, relic guardians	Represents the enforcers and remnants of fate and order. Common in ancient ruins and still-active Celestine sites.
Wards of the Dream	Nimari, illusionists, dream-spirits, phase creatures, mind-influencing foes	Any being shaped by dreams, the sea, or altered perception. Often linked to Nimurah or dream-gems.
Flame-Touched and Ash-Born	Efreeti, fire outsiders, ash revenants, Ember cultists, cataclysmic undead	Enemies touched by destruction or ruin. Common in fragment zones and cursed tombs.
Rebels Against Fate	Aram-Zaneth cultists, rogue sorcerers, apostate clerics, entropy-beasts	Those who defy destiny or seek to unmake the cosmic order. Often tied to Sirr al-Nar.
Divine Pretenders	Minor gods, corrupted relic-wielders, Satrap claimants, True Brass zealots	Powerful beings who act in the name of divinity without celestial sanction. Can appear heroic or villainous.
Outsiders and Beyond	Djinn, devils, angels, genies, and planar wanderers of all alignments	Use this for planar threats not tied to a single ideology. Flexible and campaign-wide in scope.

Brass-Blooded

Thursday, June 5, 2025 11:20 PM

You bear the spiritual imprint of the Celestine Machine.

Prerequisite: Region: Zahr al-Narās or descendant of Hollowforged

Benefit: You gain a +1 bonus on saves against compulsion and force effects. You may stabilize automatically at –1 HP once per day.

Special: You may be treated as a construct or humanoid (whichever is less favorable) for spells and effects.

Dream Swimmer

Thursday, June 5, 2025 11:23 PM

You have trained to navigate tides of unreality and vision.

Prerequisite: Cha 13, Region: Nimari, Zifari

Benefit: +2 bonus on saves vs illusions and sleep effects. You may reroll one failed Listen, Sense Motive, or Spot check per day.

Special: You may take 10 on Balance checks even in uncertain or dreamlike terrain.

Echo Recall

Thursday, June 5, 2025 11:25 PM

Your memory skips like a stone across time.

Prerequisite: Int 13

Benefit: Once per day, you may immediately recast a spell you just cast. You cast this spell exactly as though it were a spell you prepared but it does not take-up a spell slot. Must be 2nd level or lower.

Special: This does not provoke an attack of opportunity, but both versions share the same save DC and target.

Whispered Vow

Thursday, June 5, 2025 11:26 PM

You have bound yourself to a secret oath known only to the gods.

Prerequisite: Worshiper of any deity with the Fate, Trickery, or Knowledge domain

Benefit: 1/day, declare an enemy as part of your vow (free action). You gain +1 to AC and saves vs that target, and +2 to Sense Motive checks involving them.

Brazen Initiate

Thursday, June 5, 2025 11:26 PM

You've been exposed to or trained with relics of True Brass.

Prerequisite: Region: Satrapies of Varnash or DM permission

Benefit: +1 to AC vs spell-like abilities and +1 bonus on any one saving throw type (chosen when this feat is taken).

Special: If holding or wearing an item of True Brass, you gain a +2 bonus to saves against divine spells from outsiders.

Lens-Binder's Insight

Thursday, June 5, 2025 11:27 PM

You’ve studied the harmonics of fate through coded prophecy.

Prerequisite: Int 13, Knowledge (Religion) 4 ranks, Myrian Halls background (or DM permission)

Benefit: 1/day, when you or an ally within 30 ft would reroll a save or check, you may allow them to roll twice and take the better result.

Special: You take a –2 penalty to Will saves for 1 round after using this ability.

Tomb-Speaker

Thursday, June 5, 2025 11:31 PM

Voice of the dead and guardian of stellar passage.
(Spirit-talker, anti-undead support, dream-magic specialist)

Tomb-Speakers walk between embalming halls and astral altars. They "interpret" the lingering wills of the entombed.

Hit Die: d6

Requirements:

To qualify to become a Tomb-Speaker, a character must fulfill all the following criteria.

Race: any
Alignment: Any Lawful
Skills: Knowledge (Religion) 8 ranks
Spells: Ability to cast (or otherwise use) *Speak with Dead*
Attributes: Cha 13
Special: Must have performed a funerary rite for a noble or royal.

Class Skills:

The Tomb-Speaker's class skills (and the key ability for each skill) are Concentration, Diplomacy, Heal, Knowledge (Religion), Knowledge (The Planes), Listen, Sense Motive, and Spellcraft
Skill Points at Each Level: 4 + Int modifier.

Level	Base Attack Bonus	Fort Save	Ref Save	Will Save	Special	Spells per Day
1	+0	+0	+0	+2	Royal Communion, Astral Consecration	+1 level of existing class
2	+1	+0	+0	+3	Soulward Insight	+1 level of existing class
3	+1	+1	+1	+3	Celestial Turning	+1 level of existing class
4	+2	+1	+1	+4	Tomb-Rite Casting (Sending)	+1 level of existing class
5	+2	+1	+1	+4	Tomb Ward	+1 level of existing class
6	+3	+2	+2	+5	Tomb-Rite Casting (Dream)	+1 level of existing class
7	+3	+2	+2	+5	Starborne Vigil	+1 level of existing class
8	+4	+2	+2	+6	Tomb-Rite Casting (Ethereal Jaunt)	+1 level of existing class
9	+4	+3	+3	+6	Radiant Ghostsight	+1 level of existing class
10	+5	+3	+3	+7	Royal Consultation	+1 level of existing class

Class Features:

Royal Communion (Su): Once per day, you may cast *Speak with Dead* as a supernatural ability without material components. When used in a royal tomb or shrine, you may ask 1 additional question.

Astral Consecration (Su): You may consecrate a room or chamber under open sky or tomb ceiling. While within this area, you and allies gain +1 sacred bonus to saves vs fear and death effects.

Soulward Insight (Ex): +2 bonus on saves against death effects and +2 on Sense Motive checks vs undead or possessed creatures.

Celestial Turning (Su): You gain the ability to turn or rebuke undead depending on the current celestial phase (day/night or DM-determined). Day = Turn; Night = Rebuke.

Tomb-Rite Casting (Sp): At levels 4, 6, and 8, you may perform a special funerary ritual (1 hour) to gain a 1/day spell-like ability:
- **4th**: *Sending*
- **6th**: *Dream*
- **8th**: *Ethereal Jaunt* (self only)

Tomb-Ward (Su): You and allies within 30 ft of a tomb you gain +2 AC against and cannot be flanked by undead or incorporeal creatures.

Starborne Vigil (Ex): You no longer need to sleep; your dreams become prophetic. You are immune to magical sleep and may use *Augury* 1/day as spell-like ability.

Radiant Ghostsight (Su): You can see invisible, ethereal, and/or incorporeal undead at all times, as if under the effects of *See Invisibility*. This does not reveal other invisible creatures.

Royal Consultation (Su): Once per week, you may attempt to speak to the soul of a long-dead king or queen. This functions as *Greater Planar Ally* (undead or celestial ancestor only), but no payment is required if it is used to protect their tomb, legacy, or bloodline.

Tablet-Keeper

Thursday, June 5, 2025 11:32 PM

Archivist-priest trained to translate Celestine fragments.
(Lore-based spellcaster; scroll-crafter; tactical support)

Tablet-Keepers aren't just scribes—they *negotiate* with knowledge itself, decoding the lawful scripts of a ruined heaven.

Hit Die: d6

Requirements:

To qualify to become a Tablet-Keeper, a character must fulfill all the following criteria.

Race: any
Alignment: Any Lawful
Class: Cleric
Skills: Knowledge (Arcana or Religion) 8 ranks
Spells: Ability to cast (or otherwise use) *Comprehend Languages*

Class Skills:

The Tablet-Keeper's class skills are Concentration, Decipher Script, Knowledge (Arcana), Knowledge (History), Knowledge (Religion), Spellcraft, and Use Magic Device
Skill Points at Each Level: 4 + Int modifier.

Level	Base Attack Bonus	Fort Save	Ref Save	Will Save	Special	Spells per Day
1	+0	+0	+0	+2	Scribe Celestine Fragment	+1 level of existing class
2	+1	+0	+0	+3	Fragment Literacy	+1 level of existing class
3	+1	+1	+1	+3	Domain Infusion	+1 level of existing class
4	+2	+1	+1	+4	Scripted Insight	+1 level of existing class
5	+2	+1	+1	+4	Fragmentary Oracle	+1 level of existing class

Class Features

Scribe Celestine Fragment (Ex): You may scribe special scrolls from Celestine Fragments (DMG or unique ruins). These scrolls may cast any divine spell you know of 3rd level or lower, but each fragment can only hold one spell at a time and degrades after 3 uses.

Fragment Literacy (Ex): You gain a +4 bonus on Decipher Script and Use Magic Device checks involving Celestine or magical texts. You may use *Comprehend Languages* as a spell-like ability once per day.

Domain Infusion (Su): Choose one additional domain from Brass, Law, or Knowledge. You gain access to its domain spells and granted power as if granted by your deity.

Scripted Insight (Su): Once per day, after spending 10 minutes with a magical or prophetic inscription, you may gain a +2 bonus on all saving throws for 1 hour, or grant that bonus to an ally who carries the transcription.

Fragmentary Oracle (Su): Once per day, you may touch a willing creature and read their fate. This functions as *Augury* (80% success chance), but with the option to ask one Yes/No question instead of the usual outcome format.

Ashguard

Thursday, June 5, 2025 11:33 PM

Elite warrior-sentinel bonded to a relic of True Brass.
*(*Martial tank/anti-mage; battlefield denial)

Clad in sacred armor and oath-bound to relics, the Ashguard fights to uphold the dignity of imperial law.

Hit Die: d10

Requirements:

To qualify to become an Ashguard, a character must fulfill all the following criteria.

Race: any
Base Attack Bonus: +6
Proficiency: Heavy Armor and Martial Weapons
Special: Must be attuned to a True Brass relic (armor or weapon)

Class Skills:

The Ashguard's class skills are Climb, Craft (Armorsmithing or Weaponsmithing), Intimidate, Knowledge (Nobility), Knowledge (Religion), Ride, Sense Motive
Skill Points at Each Level: 2 + Int modifier.

Level	Base Attack Bonus	Fort Save	Ref Save	Will Save	Special
1	+1	+2	+0	+0	Brassbound Endurance, Smity the Unworthy 1/day
2	+2	+3	+0	+0	Relic Welding (1 slot)
3	+3	+3	+1	+1	Indomitable Pride
4	+4	+4	+1	+1	Relic Welding (2 slots)
5	+5	+4	+1	+1	Smite the Unworthy 2/day, True Brass Awakening

Class Features

Brassbound Endurance (Ex): While wearing or wielding a True Brass relic, reduce damage taken from divine spells, smite attacks, or channel energy by 5 (stacking with resistance effects).

Smite the Unworthy (Su): Once per day (twice at 5th level), you may declare an attack against an Outsider or Undead as a smite. Add your Charisma bonus to the attack roll and your class level to damage.

Relic Welding (Su): You may bind a minor magical item (or True Brass fragment) into your armor or weapon. This frees the magic item's normal slot (e.g., cloak, ring) and suppresses its abilities unless the Ashguard is wielding or wearing the welded relic. Effects are always passive and cannot require activation. You gain 1 slot at 2nd level and a second at 4th.

Indomitable Pride (Ex): Allies adjacent to you gain a +1 morale bonus on Will saves. This increases to +2 against fear or compulsion effects. You are immune to any effect that would cause you to kneel, fall

prone, or otherwise lose stature unless you allow it.

True Brass Awakening (Su): When reduced below 0 HP, you may make a Fortitude save (DC = damage taken). On success, you remain at 1 HP and gain +2 AC and +2 saves for 1 minute. This may occur once per day and only while wearing or wielding a True Brass item.

Hierarch of Zaneth

Thursday, June 5, 2025 11:34 PM

Radical devotee who shapes reality through disruptive faith.
*(*Chaotic divine caster; battlefield control; anti-fate zealot)

These clerics twist prophecy into weaponized doubt. They chant inverse litanies that jam the gears of fate.

- **Prereqs:** Worship Zaneth, Knowledge (Religion) 8, Chaotic alignment

- **Abilities:**
  - Once/encounter: prevent an enemy from taking readied or delayed actions
  - Sacrifice a spell slot to force reroll on a save against confusion or illusion
  - Can cast *dispel law* once/day, even if it's not on your spell list

Hit Die: d6

Requirements:

To qualify to become a Hierarch of Zaneth, a character must fulfill all the following criteria.

Race: any
Region: Aram-Zaneth
Alignment: Any Chaotic
Skills: Knowledge (Religion) 8 ranks
Spellcasting: Must be able to cast divine spells
Special: Must worship Zaneth and have publicly rejected an ordained fate (subject to DM approval)

Class Skills:

The Hierarch of Zaneth's class skills are Bluff, Concentration, Disguise, Intimidate, Knowledge (Religion), Sense Motive, Spellcraft
Skill Points at Each Level: 4 + Int modifier.

Level	Base Attack Bonus	Fort Save	Ref Save	Will Save	Special	Spells per Day
1	+0	+0	+0	+2	Dispel Order 1/day, Discordant Chant	+1 level of existing class
2	+1	+0	+0	+3	Inversion Doctrine	+1 level of existing class
3	+2	+1	+1	+3	Liturgial Schism	+1 level of existing class
4	+2	+1	+1	+4	Dispel Order 2/day	+1 level of existing class
5	+3	+1	+1	+4	Iconoclast's Rebuttal	+1 level of existing class

Class Features

Dispel Order (Sp): You may cast *dispel law* once per day, even if it is not on your spell list. At 4th level, you may use it twice per day.

Discordant Chant (Su): Once per encounter, you may chant a paradoxical litany that prevents a single enemy (within 30 ft, Will negates DC 10 + class level + Cha mod) from taking readied or delayed actions for 1 round. Creatures immune to mind-affecting effects are immune to this.

Inversion Doctrine (Su): You may sacrifice a divine spell slot as a free action to force an enemy to reroll a failed saving throw against an illusion or confusion effect cast by you. The second roll must be taken.

Liturgical Schism (Ex): Your utterances disrupt divine certainty. Enemies within 10 ft take a -2 penalty on saves against your divine spells if they are Lawful or have spell resistance.

Iconoclast's Rebuttal (Su): Once per day, when you are affected by a mind-affecting or compulsion effect, you may immediately force the source to make a Will save (DC 10 + class level + your Cha mod) or be affected by *confusion* for 1 round.

Pearl Scribe

Thursday, June 5, 2025 11:35 PM

Wind-reader, oath-binder, and master of diplomatic dream-lore.
(Enchanter/diviner hybrid; social control; navigation)

These sages bind contracts with starlight ink and navigate dream-currents using mirrored sextants.

Hit Die: d6

Requirements:

To qualify to become a Pearl Scribe, a character must fulfill all the following criteria.

Skills: Diplomacy 8 ranks, Knowledge (Geography) 4 ranks
Feat: Spell Focus (Enchantment or Divination)
Special: Must have inscribed a dream-map or traded with a spirit of the sea

Class Skills:

The Pearl Scribe's class skills are Appraise, Bluff, Decipher Script, Diplomacy, Knowledge (Geography), Knowledge (Local), Knowledge (The Planes), Sense Motive, Speak Language, Spellcraft
Skill Points at Each Level: 6 + Int modifier.

Level	Base Attack Bonus	Fort Save	Ref Save	Will Save	Special	Spells per Day
1	0	+0	+0	+2	Silver Inscription 1/day, Dream-Compass	+1 level of existing class
2	1	+0	+0	+3	Mirror-Tongue	+1 level of existing class
3	1	+1	+1	+3	Inkbound Clause	+1 level of existing class
4	2	+1	+1	+4	Silver Inscription 2/day	+1 level of existing class
5	2	+1	+1	+4	Whisper of the Tides	+1 level of existing class

Class Features

Silver Inscription (Su): Once per day (twice/day at 4th level), you may inscribe a creature's name onto a polished silver tablet. For the next 24 hours, you gain a +2 insight bonus on all saves, skill checks, and opposed rolls against that creature. The creature is unaware of this effect.

Dream-Compass (Su): You always know the direction to any location you have personally mapped or dream-walked to. This functions even across planes if the destination still exists.

Mirror-Tongue (Su): You may speak with aquatic spirits, dreambound creatures, or illusions as though under a *Tongues* spell. This ability is always active but only functions with these creature types.

Inkbound Clause (Ex): Whenever you cast a divination or enchantment spell on a target after a successful opposed Diplomacy check, increase your effective caster level by +2 for that spell.

Whisper of the Tides (Sp): Once per day, you may contact a spirit of the Mirror-Sea as a *Contact Other Plane* spell. However, the entity may offer poetic or allegorical answers and always answers truthfully—if cryptically.

Caller of the Wind Shrines

Thursday, June 5, 2025 11:35 PM

Nomadic seer who sings the signs of the storm and sand.

Zifari wind-callers interpret divine signs through dust devils, the shifting moon, or the cracking of salt pans.

Hit Die: d8

Requirements:

To qualify to become a Caller of the Wind Shrines, a character must fulfill all the following criteria.

Race: any
Skills: Survival 8 ranks, Perform (Oratory or Cant) 4 ranks
Special: Must have received a ritual blessing at a recognized wind-shrine of the Zifari
Class: at least one level in Bard

Class Skills:

The Caller of the Wind Shrines' class skills are Concentration, Handle Animal, Knowledge (Nature), Knowledge (Religion), Perform (Oratory), Sense Motive, Spellcraft, Survival
Skill Points at Each Level: 6 + Int modifier.

Level	Base Attack Bonus	Fort Save	Ref Save	Will Save	Special	Spells per Day
1	+0	+2	+0	+2	Voice of Dust and Gale 1/day, Wind-Ward 1/day	-
2	+1	+3	+0	+3	Weather-Touched Verse	+1 level of existing class
3	+2	+3	+1	+3	Desert Signs	-
4	+3	+4	+1	+4	Voice of Dust and Gale 2/day, Wind-Ward 2/day	+1 level of existing class
5	+3	+4	+1	+4	Gale-Seer's Clarity	-

Class Features

Voice of Dust and Gale (Su): Once per day, you may cast *Augury* or *Wind Wall* as a supernatural ability without material components. At 4th level, you may use this ability twice per day.

Wind-Ward (Su): As a standard action, you may invoke the blessing of a wind-shrine to create a protective current around yourself or an ally within 30 feet. This grants a +2 deflection bonus to AC and a +2 bonus on Reflex saves for 1 minute. In addition, the target gains concealment (20% miss chance) against ranged attacks made from more than 30 feet away. This ability may be used once per day at 1st level, and twice per day at 4th level.

Weather-Touched Verse (Su): You may treat one spell per level that appears on the druid or cleric spell list with the Air or Weather descriptor as a bard spell known. You must still have the appropriate spell

level to cast it. This selection is permanent once chosen.

Desert Signs (Ex): You gain a +4 bonus on saving throws against illusions or magical effects that obscure paths, directions, or natural terrain. You may also roll twice and take the better result when using Survival to avoid becoming lost.

Gale-Seer's Clarity (Su): Once per day, you may enter a trance for 1 minute, gaining the effects of *True Seeing* and *Find the Path* for the duration. During this time, you must sing or chant continuously, and cannot be silenced or deafened.

Standing

Monday, June 9, 2025 12:28 AM

Each major faction (e.g. Aram-Zaneth, the Zifari Tribes, the Satrapies of Varnash, Djinn Courts, etc.) has a Standing Score with the party

Certain factions are ideologically or politically opposed. Gaining favor with one causes loss of standing with another.

Gain With →	**Aram-Zaneth**	**Zifari Tribes**	**Varnash**	**Zahr al-Narās**	**Myria**	**Ta'ren**	**Nisarun**
Aram-Zaneth	—	-1	-1	-3	—	-1	+1
Zifari Tribes	-1	—	+1	+1	-1	—	+1
Varnash	-1	+1	—	—	—	—	—
Zahr al-Narās	-3	—	+1	—	+1	+1	–1
Myria	—	-1	-1	+1	—	+1	–1
Ta'ren	-1	—	—	+1	—	—	–1
Nisarun	—	+1	—	—	—	–1	—

Each time standing with a faction increases, standing with listed opposing factions drops by 1, unless mitigated by clever diplomacy or deception.

Standing should change based on:

- Major story choices (siding in conflicts, fulfilling quests, slaying or sparing key NPCs).
- Cultural respect (performing sacred rites correctly, speaking truthfully, bearing symbols).
- Betrayals, insults, or violations of law/taboo.

Each tier of standing grants a benefit:

Tier	**Score**	**Effects**
Trusted	+1	Lower prices, safe passage, minor favors.
Honored Ally	+3	Military aid, rare information, elite guides or mounts.
Favored	+5	Access to sacred sites, dream-gem gifts, rituals, even temporary divine aid.
Distrusted	-1	Minor indignities, general bad attitude
Despised	-3	Watched, overcharged, given false information.
Hunted	-5	Open attacks, cursed, marked for dream-hunters or assassins.

Fractured Fate

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The Shattering of Destiny

When Zahr al-Narās fell, it ruptured more than stone and sky—it shattered the Celestine Furnace, the divine engine that once burned mortal futures into ordained truth. That collapse tore open the veil between what *was meant to be* and *what could be*, flooding the world with a storm of unstable possibility.

Now, the fabric of reality quivers beneath the strain of too many futures vying for dominance. In places where fragments of the Brass City still linger, entire regions bend or fracture under the influence of "true dreams"—residual shards of fate encoded in luminous prophecy-gems. These gems do not merely predict. They create.

The War for the Future

In the wake of the Furnace's failure, nearly every major faction has turned its eyes toward the true dreams, each seeking to shape the future in its image.

- The Aram-Zaneth believe the time has come to rewrite reality itself. They aim to weaponize or distort the true dreams, replacing divine design with their brand of ideological heresy—a cosmos born not from order, but from defiance.

- Sirr al-Nar, the fallen Harmonist, sees the gems as tools to rebuild Zahr al-Narās under his control. He feeds the Furnace new dreams—ones that elevate his design and suppress all deviation.

- The Emerald Courts seek restoration, hoping the gems can revive their star-priest dynasties and ensure that ancestral sovereignty passes unbroken into the next age.

- The Satrapies of Varnash approach the gems with fear and ambition. Some nobles wish to shatter or hoard the fragments, ensuring fate's restoration cannot erode their hard-won power.

- The Myrian Halls adopt a more cautious stance. They aim to study and catalog each gem exhaustively before committing to any metaphysical reshaping of the world.

- The Nisarun, true to form, offer to broker neutrality. Yet their wind-ships are often seen transporting dreams to multiple buyers, playing every side while pledging loyalty to none.

- Among the Zifari, there is no consensus—but their seers and wind-callers agree on one truth: fate should not be restored. They act to preserve plural futures, ensuring no single vision dominates the desert horizon.

General Plot

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Act I – Fractured Fate
Theme: Discovery, wonder, and the price of knowledge.

Tone: Surreal mystery, ideological seduction, creeping unease.

1. First manifestations of fractured fate appear (duplicated people, contradictory pasts, time rifts).
2. First Gem Found
    a. The PCs recover the first gem and learn of its stabilizing—but reductive—effect.
    b. PCs find a gem and stabilize a region but learn that doing so also eliminates many futures
3. Factions take notice
    a. Initial contact: emissaries, seers, or hostile scouts.
    b. Each faction presents their ideology, agenda, and offer.
    c. Players may formally align with or reject a faction, setting early reputational standings.

Act II – The Dream War
Theme: Choice vs consequence; truth's cost; competing realities.

Tone: Tense intrigue, moral complexity, emergent horror.

1. Fragments Become War Zones
    a. Players race (or are hunted) in pursuit of dream-gems.
    b. Rivals (including other adventuring parties or efreeti warlords) actively sabotage or compete.
2. Contradictory Dreams
    a. Some gems encode mutually exclusive outcomes.
    b. Feeding one to the Furnace alters history—or causes people/places to vanish, change, or fracture.
3. The Turning Point
    a. A major NPC (mentor, ally, family) is overwritten or erased.
    b. Factions escalate: coups, assassinations, wars sparked by destabilized futures.

Act III – Ashes of the Architect
Theme: Reclamation, reinvention, or annihilation.

Tone: Epic, tragic, defiant, surreal.

1. Sirr al-Nar Emerges
    a. The Ash Architect sends emissaries, war machines, or himself.
    b. Dream-gem manipulation increases. Reality convulses. Dream echoes manifest as monsters or dungeons.
2. The Great Choice
    a. Players must:
        i. Embrace a faction's plan to shape the world,
        ii. Reject all and attempt to break the Furnace completely,
        iii. Or forge a third path: a *Living Dream*—a chaotic but free-flowing fate.
3. The Final Descent
    a. The last dungeon is *Fallen Zahr al-Narās* and *The Celestine Furnace* itself, partially reignited and defended by reality-warped efreeti and constructs.
    b. Inside: the heart of fate still beats… but broken, mad, or ready to be rewritten.

Overview

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 10:29 PM

Aram-Zaneth is a shadowed remnant of the peoples who walked the land long before the Brass City imposed its mechanized vision of fate. A theocracy of scattered city-states, it is ruled not by emperors or generals but by priest-kings and witch-queens, each bound by ancient blood pacts and ancestral rites. Unlike empires forged through conquest, Aram-Zaneth is unified by reverence—ancestral worship, sacrificial tradition, and a sacred hunger for the forbidden knowledge buried in the ruins of the fallen city. To its faithful, the fall of Zahr al-Narās was not a calamity but a divine opportunity: the long-awaited return of the gods beneath the earth, who now whisper through blood and fire.

Beliefs and Religion

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 10:32 PM

Central to the faith of Aram-Zaneth is the worship of Zaneth, the Chained Sun, an inverted deity whom they claim was exiled from the Brass City for revealing forbidden truths to mortals. The people of Aram-Zaneth live steeped in symbolism, where nothing is mundane—everything is either sacred or taboo. Their religious cosmology revolves around Zaneth and a cohort of lesser divine beings known as the Thirsting Court, each representing aspects of desire, suffering, and the cyclical nature of truth.

They reject the notion of linear time or predestined fate, embracing instead a vision of existence as an eternal cycle of suffering and renewal, powered through blood and sacrifice. Their rituals reflect this worldview: blood rites, ecstatic trances, dream-feasting, and offerings of flame are common, often enacted atop vast, terraced ziggurats stained with centuries of sacrificial blood.

The iconography of Aram-Zaneth is as potent as it is unsettling. The Chained Sun, a stylized disc split by black chains and burning from within, is their most sacred symbol—worn as pendants, etched into armor, and painted on altars in blood. The Inverted Tree, whose roots stretch skyward while its fruit lies buried deep beneath the earth, represents hidden knowledge and the reversal of divine order. The Brass Spiral, a complex labyrinthine glyph, is believed to mirror the unraveling of fate itself.

Every aspect of their ritual life is infused with dark reverence, designed not to please benevolent gods, but to awaken sleeping truths and draw power from suffering.

Zaneth

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 10:45 PM

The Father of Flame, The Inverted Light, He Who Was Bound, The God-Forged God
Lesser Deity (Neutral Evil)

Zaneth is not a creator in the traditional divine sense. He was once a servant of the Celestial Order—a being of immense power and precision, perhaps an archon, seraph, or divine automaton wrought by the Celestine Furnace itself. But in time, he came to rebel, claiming that the gods of the heavens feared mortal will and sought to bind all life within the gears of a brazen and unchanging world.

According to the doctrines of Aram-Zaneth, the Celestine Order had enslaved time and destiny, chaining prophecy to a fixed design. In an act of transcendent treason, Zaneth shattered that design. He fractured prophecy, rendering fate uncertain and malleable. For this act, he was cast down—bound in chains of holy flame, sealed in a prison of burning revelation. But the damage was done. His fall struck the first crack in the foundations of Zahr al-Narās, the celestial city that would one day collapse in fire and silence.

Zaneth's followers do not worship him as a god in the conventional sense. Rather, they revere him as a figure of apotheosis—divinity not bestowed but earned through struggle and defiance. His faith is not one of comfort or obedience, but of transformation. To follow Zaneth is to burn away imposed form, to embrace becoming over being. Fire is his symbol not merely for its destructive power, but for its capacity to reforge. Truth, say his disciples, is not found in law or revelation—but in ash, where nothing false can remain.

Zaneth represents the gnostic heart of Aram-Zaneth: a theological rebellion against celestial determinism and divine tyranny. To the faithful, he is not the enemy of the gods—he is the flaw that invalidates their design.

- **Alignment**: Neutral Evil
- **Domains**: Reckoning, Ash, Dream
- **Typical Worshipers**: The priest-kings and witch-queens of Aram-Zaneth, warlocks, heretical sages, misanthropic cultists, and those who see divinity not as a gift but as a crucible
- **Favored Weapon**: A chained flail or ritual dagger inscribed with broken prophecies

Culture and Society

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 10:33 PM

The society of Aram-Zaneth is deeply clan-based, with each clan maintaining its own bloodline traditions, ancestral rites, and regional customs. Yet above them all presides the Council of Thorns—a secretive and revered conclave of oracular priests and seers. These figures interpret the will of Zaneth and the Thirsting Court through ancient divination rites, reading omens in ash patterns, sacrificial entrails, and the fevered visions pulled from communal dreams. Their word is law.

Slavery is a grim but accepted part of life in Aram-Zaneth. Foreign captives, often taken in raids or purchased from desert traders, are not merely laborers—they are ritual fuel. Some are sacrificed in blood rites to power dream-binding ceremonies, their essence offered to Zaneth in exchange for prophetic visions. Others are bartered to Djinn warlords and exiled spirits, traded for fragments of forbidden lore or whispered truths from the age before the Brass City ruled the skies.

Their artisans are not mere craftsmen, but ritual smiths and curse-binders, fusing spiritual malice into every item they create. Weapons of copper and obsidian—cold to the touch, yet humming with malignant energy—are common. They also produce fetishes carved from bone and ashwood, and idol-totems of twisted design, often worn or placed at shrines. These objects are not simply sacred—they are alive with spiritual force, some whispering in the dark, others burning with silent hatred for all things that walk under the open sky.

To outsiders, Aram-Zaneth may seem cruel and otherworldly, but to its people, every act is a sacrament, every cruelty a necessary toll paid to glimpse the truths hidden beneath the world's skin.

Military

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 10:33 PM

The warriors of Aram-Zaneth are known as the Flame-Taken, fearsome berserkers marked by ritual scarification and chosen through visions of divine madness. In battle, they claim to hear the voice of Zaneth himself, urging them into ecstatic fury. Their bodies are latticed with burns, brands, and ash-inked runes—each a mark of devotion and initiation. Clad in copper-wrought armor and reeking of sacred smoke, they fight not merely to kill, but to kindle revelation through violence.

Alongside them march diviner-warlocks, enigmatic battlefield seers who wear veils of golden thread that shimmer with protective incantations. These arcane priests wield scrolls and staves inscribed in blood-inked glyphs, which they activate with chants and dream-speech to twist the threads of fate, unravel enemy formations, or ignite the very flesh of their foes. To witness one work a battle-sigil is to watch reality momentarily bend under the weight of forgotten names and sacrificial promises.

Aram-Zaneth is no stranger to forbidden alliances. Many among their priesthood and war-castes have formed pacts with rogue Efreet, especially those who still remember the splendor of the Brass City before its fall. These exiled fire-spirits, consumed by bitterness and freed from the strictures of the Brass City, find kinship in the blood-soaked rites of Aram-Zaneth, and often lend their power in exchange for worship, sacrifices, or a promise of eventual reckoning against the city's false heirs.

Their cavalry is no less terrifying. Mounted on scaled hounds or desert lizards, bred in sacred birthing pits and trained through torment and fire, these riders strike swiftly from the dunes. Their mounts are more than beasts—they are ritually awakened, possessed by spirits or imprinted with glyphs that make them resistant to fear and pain. A charge of these riders is both a physical and spiritual assault, the thunder of claws and hooves accompanied by the howls of spirits too long shackled in the dark.

In every corner of their martial tradition, Aram-Zaneth wields battle not as strategy, but as sacrament—a holy theater in which fate may be rewritten in blood and fire.

Relationship to Zahr al-Naras

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 10:35 PM

The people of Aram-Zaneth claim a forgotten lineage, insisting that their ancestors once served in the deepest and most secret temples of the Brass City—keepers of hidden truths and forbidden rites. When Zaneth committed his great heresy, seeking to unbind fate and offer mortals the power to shape their own destinies, these faithful were cast out alongside him. They did not fall in disgrace, they say, but were chosen to carry the true flame into exile.

To them, the scattered fragments of the Brass City—those twisted ruins that warp time and bleed possibility—are not mere wreckage, but sacred keys. Within each lies a whisper of lost divinity, a clue to the great undoing of the cosmic order. They do not seek to restore what once was, but to claim their rightful place among the stars, no longer as servants of fate, but as its rebels, breakers, and heirs.

Their most fervent pursuit is the collection of dream-gems, the crystallized remnants of prophecy and divine vision once housed in the Celestine Furnace. The Aram-Zanethi believe these gems hold the power to resurrect Zaneth in full, not as a chained god, but as a burning sovereign. They dream of a final reckoning, when the false sun of mechanized destiny will be consumed in sacred flame, and Zaneth's light will illuminate a world remade in suffering, freedom, and truth. No price is too high. No atrocity too far. For them, this is not vengeance—it is fulfillment.

Locations of Note

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 10:36 PM

Ash-Zurab

The smoldering heart of Aram-Zaneth, Ash-Zurab is a city built within the scorched wound of a volcanic rift, its streets carved from obsidian and its towers crowned with slow-burning braziers. At its core rises the Temple of Red Prophecy, a sanctum of sacrificial vision where the High Oracle drinks molten brass to receive revelations too volatile for lesser minds. Smoke-choked processions wind through the city in honor of Zaneth, and every breath of sulfur is considered a blessing from below. Here, prophecy is not studied—it is survived.

The Black Groves of Haran'Set

Deep within a steaming jungle corrupted by time and rot, the Black Groves mark the resting place of discarded gods and broken futures. Twisted stone idols loom over fungal shrines, and the air pulses with the heartbeat of something old and unwanted. The jungle itself seems sentient, its vines curling with ill intent. Beast-priests—once men, now something less—prowl the ruins in silent worship of prophecies that never came to pass. Those who venture into Haran'Set rarely return unchanged, if they return at all.

Throne of Chains

Perched on the edge of a basalt cliff that drops into storm-wracked sea, the Throne of Chains is a fortress-temple wrapped around the shattered remnants of a sky-anchor—a colossal chain that once tethered the Brass City to heaven. Now broken and half-buried, the anchor serves as a ritual crucible, where penitents are bound and burned in symbolic reenactments of Zaneth's fall. The fortress is equal parts monastery, prison, and forge, home to a militant order of flame-bound zealots who see suffering as the path to revelation.

Aesthetics of Aram-Zaneth

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 10:38 PM

Architecure

The architecture of Aram-Zaneth speaks of reverence through ruin, of sacrifice carved into stone. The cities of this theocracy rise in jagged tiers, their black ziggurats built from obsidian bricks laced with veins of molten copper. These shimmering seams pulse faintly in the dark, like the slowed heartbeat of something still alive beneath the stone. Hanging altars dangle on iron chains over pits of fire, brine, or void—offerings made not to ascend but to descend, swallowed by heat or drowned in darkness.

Throughout the land, ruined cities bloom with unnatural beauty. Night-blooming flowers spill across crumbling courtyards, while gnarled fig trees and choking vines coil through shattered doorways. The locals call this growth "false fertility"—a sign of divine decay, not renewal. In every public space, sacrificial trenches and fire gutters run like veins through the stone, ever-ready to receive the gods' due: blood, ash, or breath.

City walls are etched with writhing glyphs, carved in ancient script that seems to shift at the edge of vision. Scholars debate whether these sigils are magical, prophetic, or simply mad—but all agree on one thing: the walls watch.

Attire and Adornment

The people of Aram-Zaneth wear their faith and lineage as visibly as their garments. High priests don layered robes of crimson and deep indigo, dyed with rare volcanic minerals and fine ash-dust harvested from sacred pyres. Each robe is a vestment and a ledger, bearing stitched records of bloodline, prophecy, and sacrificial deed. Beneath these robes, the skin tells its own tale—tattoos and brands etched in complex sigils denote rank, ancestral pacts, and oaths sworn to the flame-bound gods.

Warriors often fight bare-chested, their bodies marked with ritual scars or protected only by hardened leather armor scorched and carved with votive burns. They adorn themselves with bone charms, ash-beads, and melted brass fittings, each piece a talisman of survival or conquest. Theirs is a beauty born of pain and memory.

Among the nobility, ritual masking is both custom and commandment. During ceremonies, nobles wear ivory masks inlaid with copper, stylized into the visages of beast-gods, ancestors, or the symbolic form of the Chained Sun—Zaneth's bound and burning divinity. To show one's unmasked face before the divine is considered an act of either deep humility or unforgivable pride.

Overview

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 11:01 PM

Zifari: from the Hebrew zaphar (to whistle, blow), evokes wind, sand, and breath—elements of mystic storytelling and oral tradition.

The Zifari are a drifting constellation of desert clans—oral historians, spirit-binders, and dream-chasers who navigate the ever-shifting boundaries between past and future. They claim descent from those who sang to the stars before they had names, and who walked the dunes long before the Brass City pierced the sky. To the Zifari, the fall of Zahr al-Narās was not a calamity but a correction: the world slipping back into rhythm, into story, into breath.

They build no permanent cities. Instead, they dwell in mirage-tents, obsidian-threaded yurts, and bone-framed caravans that appear and vanish with the wind, guided more by memory and omen than by road or star-chart. Their homes are layered with whisper-silk and dreamcatcher glass, structures as much ritual as shelter. "*It is not land,*" the Zifari say, "*but motion and memory that makes a people real.*"

Among them are **fate-singers**, who weave prophecy into ballad; **wind howlers**, berserker guardians who speak with the storm; and **dream-orators**, capable of binding the echoes of the fallen Brass City into living speech. Though often seen as rootless, the Zifari are archivists of a different kind—preserving truth not in stone or ink, but in recitation, vision, and the ceremonial act of forgetting.

Philosophy and Faith

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 11:03 PM

The Zifari follow no doctrine, recite no fixed creed, and build no temples. Their faith is not one of gods but of story, motion, and the living desert. To them, divinity dwells not in distant heavens but in the whisper of sand across stone, in the flicker of firelight across a caravan wall, in the stories passed from elder to child beside the embers of a nomad's hearth. They venerate spirits, ancestral dreams, and memory—forces that move through wind and silence, carrying the weight of those who came before.

They teach that dreams are alive, and that each person must carry one "*to the end of the world,*" or risk being forgotten by the stars. A dream unfulfilled is a name unwritten in the sky. The fall of the Brass City, in Zifari cosmology, was not just a calamity of stone and flame—it was a fracture in the World-Song, a divine pause, a silence into which they now sing their own verses. Their existence is a sacred improvisation.

Prophets among the Zifari are known as **Wind-Dreamers**—those who can hear the voices carried in desert gusts, echoes of futures never written or memories not yet born. These seers speak in riddled cadence, more poem than proclamation.

The Zifari reject the fate-scripted determinism of the Celestine Order, seeing it as a cage masquerading as truth. Yet they regard the zealots of Aram-Zaneth with even deeper wariness, calling them chained mirrors—those who once followed dreams but bound them in flame and prophecy. Where Aram-Zaneth seeks to conquer destiny through fire, the Zifari seek to travel beside it, free and unfinished.

Culture and Society

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 11:04 PM

The Zifari do not dwell in nations or lineages, but in Roaming Constellations—tribal caravans named after celestial signs, dream-visions, or legendary ancestors. Some bear titles like The Sons of the Broken Moon, The Flame That Walks, or The Dust of Daughters—names that are changed, remembered, or reborn as needed. A Constellation is not a family—it is a songline, a pattern of motion through desert, sky, and tale.

Leadership among the Zifari is fluid, determined not by blood but by the strength of one's story. The finest teller, singer, wind-rider, or fate-weaver leads for a season, a cycle, or until the Constellation's tale changes course. Authority rests with those whose voice best carries the dreams of the people—not with those who would hold it by right.

Children are not taught to memorize dry facts or static histories. Instead, they embody their culture through ritual—learning gesture-dances, ember-trances, and trance-poems that encode memory in motion. Knowledge is lived: danced beside the fire, sung to the stars, shouted into the wind. A Zifari child does not know their past—they become it, every time the rhythm takes hold.

Magical Tradition

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 11:05 PM

Zifari magic is a living art, drawn not from books or sigils, but from dream, sky, and memory. It is never written—for to write a spell is to trap it, to still its breath and fix it in place. Among the Zifari, such acts are considered profane. Magic must move, sing, shimmer—must live in the space between thought and echo.

Their magical traditions take many forms, each a reflection of motion and impermanence. Stormsingers are wind-priests who shape desert gusts into spirit-speech, scattering illusions or revealing truths with a breath. Mirage-Binders walk the line between illusionist and scout, conjuring shifting terrain to confuse pursuers or lead caravans safely through false lands. Most enigmatic are the Ash-Readers, dream-seers who gaze into coal-fire and starlight, drawing riddled guidance from the patterns left behind by burning things and falling heavens.

Zifari relics are never ornate, but always alive with meaning. Strands of wind-twine, braided from scented silks and desert grass, hold whispered messages that can only be heard in motion. Vials of starborn sand, gathered from fallen meteors, are used to trace glyphs that vanish on the wind. Most revered are voice-jugs—clay vessels sealed with ash and memory, which speak aloud the final words of a lost elder or beloved ancestor when held to the ear under moonlight. Each item is both tool and talisman, part of the dream it once served.

Aesthetics

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 11:06 PM

The Zifari wear their beliefs as visibly as their clothing, their art, and the architecture of their passing homes. Loose, layered robes in hues of twilight—slate gray, desert ochre, and the deep purple of sunset—are common throughout the clans. These garments are woven with reflective threads spun from mica, copper-dust, or beetle-shell, which shimmer faintly beneath the sun and moon. They serve both to ward off desert heat and to confuse hostile spirits, which the Zifari believe are easily drawn to those who shine too steadily.

Adornment follows sacred principles of imbalance. Brass charms and jewelry, often shaped like stars, eyes, or outstretched hands, are worn askew or unpaired—never in matched sets. Asymmetry is sacred, a sign that the wearer remains in motion, still becoming, still part of the dream. Symmetry, they say, is for the dead or the deluded.

Before sacred storytelling, funerary rites, or prophetic gatherings, many Zifari paint their faces with ritual lines of soot, ochre, or wind-ash. Each pattern is chosen for the moment: a tale of loss might demand trailing lines down the cheeks; a tale of defiance, bold slashes across the brow. These markings are not costumes, but masks for the soul to speak through.

Their tents are marvels of ephemeral craft—woven canopies stitched with sigil-knots and fluttering prayer-ribbons, dyed with dream-herbs and spirit-inks. It is said these ribbons move not only with wind, but with the presence of nearby spirits or sleeping thoughts, curling or snapping when omens pass nearby. To sleep beneath a Zifari tent is to enter the edge of someone else's dream.

Relationship with Zahr al-Narās

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 11:07 PM

Among the Zifari, the Brass City is not reviled nor worshipped—it is mourned, like a fallen star. They believe that, once, Zahr al-Narās sang with the voice of the sky, a perfect harmony between mortal dreams and celestial will. It was not merely a city of brass and fire, but a song made solid—an alignment of purpose between earth and heaven.

Its fall is not viewed as punishment, but as a pause in the World-Song—a divine silence, a test to see if mortals would carry the melody onward without the guidance of clockwork gods. In the Zifari view, to mourn the city is not to long for its return, but to honor the music it once gave the world.

They do not seek to rebuild Zahr al-Narās. Instead, they roam its broken fragments, listening for lingering verses and dreaming-echoes. They search for dream-gems—crystalline remnants of unspoken futures—and song-scrolls, sheets of metal or hide that resonate with the memory of lost prophecy. To the Zifari, these are not artifacts of power, but verses of a forgotten chorus that might yet guide the next passage of the world.

Even brass, the metal of the city, is treated with reverence and caution. To wear it is to carry the burden of a song not yet resolved. Only **Wind-Dreamers** and burial officiants may wear brass openly, their adornments shaped into whisper-chimes or neckplates that ring faintly with lost harmony.

Place in the World

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 11:07 PM

The Zifari walk where others fear to tread. They serve as guides, interpreters, and spirit-walkers across the dream-touched wastelands, skirting the edges of Brass Fragments and whispering roads where reality frays. While most avoid these unstable regions, the Zifari navigate them with practiced ease—listening for dream-currents, following memory-lines etched in shifting stone. To those who would brave the ruins of Zahr al-Narās, a Zifari guide is often the difference between revelation and erasure.

Yet for all their gifts, the Zifari are rarely welcomed. To the settled powers of Barizad, they are barbaric, unclean, and uncivilized—a people without walls, laws, or written truth. They are feared as tricksters, wanderers, and dream-thieves. Among the priesthood of Aram-Zaneth, the Zifari are denounced as dangerous heretics—"those who lack the strength to impose their will upon the world," clinging instead to motion and mystery.

Even beyond the mortal realms, their knowledge has drawn unwanted attention. Djinn-warlords, ever hungry for dominion over fate, have been known to hunt Zifari elders, believing they carry ancestral memories of pre-Brass prophecy—fragments of the true song before the Celestine Engine rewrote the world. For the Zifari, survival is not only a matter of sand and storm, but of outpacing those who would silence their song forever.

Efreeti Warlords

Tuesday, June 3, 2025 11:18 PM

When the Brass City fell, it did not fall alone.

With it came fire and ruin, yes—but also its servants, its wardens, and its prisoners. Among the most feared and powerful of these are the efreeti, once bound by oath or function to the Celestine Furnace, now unmoored and burning with purpose. Cast down from the celestial heights, many did not vanish into smoke or return to their home planes—they staked claims upon the earth, carved strongholds from ash, and began to shape the world in the image of their rage, ambition, or revelation.

These beings are no longer merely outsiders. They are warlords, philosophers, false prophets, and would-be gods, each seeking in their own way to rebuild, replace, or unmake what the Brass City once represented. Their goals vary: some seek to forge a new divine order under their rule, others to harvest dreams and fate to fuel new engines of power, and still others to burn destiny itself to cinders, seeing in the fall of the City an invitation to true freedom.

What unites them is not loyalty to one another, nor even a shared cause—but a shared context:

- All were shaped by the Brass City's clockwork theology.
- All fell with it—or tore themselves free in its collapse.
- All now act as agents of destabilization, divine rivalries, and cosmic recursion.

The efreeti warlords claim ruins, deserts, and splintered realities as their domains. They command legions of fire-marked mortals, reconstructed constructs, and lesser geniekind, often twisting relics of Celestine design to serve their new ideologies. To some they are liberators—burning away the hypocrisy of fate. To others, tyrants in waiting, eager to weld the broken world into a new machine of flame.

Few mortals serve them and remain unchanged.

Notable Warlords

Friday, June 13, 2025 4:21 PM

Sultana Hadranah, the Gilded Pyre

Once a general of the Celestine legions, Hadranah now styles herself as a queen of ash and ambition. Draped in molten gold and crowned with ever-burning flame, she seeks to build a new Brass City—not to restore the old, but to surpass it. Her citadel, half-built in the heart of a shifting desert, rises atop a mountain of fused stone and bone. She commands mortal slaves, half-melted constructs, and shattered relics reassembled with ruthless vision. Hadranah believes obedience is the truest form of harmony, and she will grind the world into brass to make it sing again.

Sul Nashir of the Nine Flames

A collector of fates and a butcher of prophets, Sul Nashir scours the dream-scape for true dreams—fragments of prophecy that survived the Brass City's fall. With these, he intends to forge a new wish-engine, one that answers to no god or order but his own flaming will. Sul Nashir wields nine everburning brands, each forged from a different stolen miracle. Wherever he walks, his flames whisper forgotten futures and scream with those who failed to hold onto theirs.

The Ember-Saint

Neither tyrant nor conqueror, the Ember-Saint is a renegade philosopher wrapped in fire. Once chained within the heart of the Celestine Furnace, he emerged from its collapse not in wrath, but in revelation. To him, fate was always a cage—sublime, golden, and suffocating. Now he wanders Barizad with a burning gospel: that only through the total immolation of destiny can true freedom arise. His followers are exiles, heretics, and broken warlocks, each bearing the Saint’s brand: a flame that consumes not flesh, but certainty.

Malqizad the Hollow Flame

Of all the warlords, none burn quieter—or colder—than Malqizad. Draped in ember-silk robes and crowned with a halo of dying coals, he is a being of riddles, haunted silences, and measured speech. He commands a host of mirror-genies, reflections of what might have been, who speak only in questions. Malqizad does not conquer in the open; he whispers to oracles, poisons prophecies, and unravels belief itself. Some say he seeks not to destroy fate, but to empty it, leaving behind only the echo of will.

Overview

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 10:25 PM

The Emerald Courts are a resplendent theocracy built along the banks of the River Aset, a sacred lifeline that winds through obsidian cliffs, emerald-green floodplains, and alabaster necropolises that gleam beneath the desert sun. Once, this kingdom was the pinnacle of mortal devotion to the celestial order, ruled by a bloodline said to descend from fallen star-metal—shards of prophecy incarnate, given form in flesh. In their golden age, the Emerald Courts pursued ascension through death, not as escape, but as the final refinement of the soul—an alignment of mortal spirit with the stellar harmonics imposed by Zahr al-Narās.

Yet in the aftermath of the Brass City's fall, the Courts have grown fractured. Their temples echo with half-remembered rites; their embalmers chant prayers whose meanings have long faded into symbol. Some cling to the old ways with radiant zeal. Others, unwittingly corrupted by the touch of Aram-Zaneth or forgotten pacts bound in the lowest vaults of the fallen city, carry rot within their sanctity. The Emerald Courts remain beautiful, ordered, and serene—but beneath the surface, something trembles, and not all who walk its marble avenues serve the stars above.

Rule and Governance

Thursday, June 5, 2025 12:15 AM

At the head of the Emerald Courts reigns God-Queen Seraphae VI, a serene and reclusive monarch said to speak with the stars in her sleep. Her pronouncements—delivered in veiled whispers through dream-interpreters—are treated as both law and revelation. Rule within the Courts is sacral and bureaucratic, a sacred duty enacted through a sprawling apparatus of temple-scribes, dream-casters, and mirror-masked judges who interpret the Queen's will with unblinking precision.

The people of the Emerald Courts are divided into castes aligned with celestial function. Cultivators tend both the river's bounty and the soul's refinement through daily ritual. Embalmer-philosophers preserve the dead not merely as tradition, but as part of an ongoing spiritual calculus. Death-barge navigators ferry the honored dead to astral tombs downstream, singing hymns of release into the stars. And above them all, the star-watchers ascend white towers nightly to recite the Codices of Alignment—the great celestial scriptures that once governed life beneath the Brass City's orbit.

Yet beneath this order lies slow decay. Though Seraphae's line is revered as semi-divine, each new heir is less attuned to the stars than the last. The divine blood—believed to flow with fragments of prophecy—runs thinner with each generation. Some whisper that the heavens have turned away… or that something else now watches back.

Religion

Thursday, June 5, 2025 12:16 AM

The Emerald Courts revere a celestial pantheon—a host of divine beings that govern the cycles of death, judgment, memory, and transformation. Each deity is associated with a sacred animal form and a cosmic function, and together they form the spiritual foundation of the Ta'reni people. Temples, priesthoods, and rituals are devoted to these gods throughout the riverlands, where divine will is interpreted through dreams, omens, and the movements of stars.

Foremost among the pantheon is the Mirror Falcon, a god of judgment, alignment, and soul-weighing. Depicted as a falcon with mirrored feathers and a single, unblinking eye, the Mirror Falcon is said to perch atop brass obelisks that mark the invisible road to the afterlife. In Ta'reni belief, this god reflects a soul's final dream, fracturing it into the path it must walk beyond death. Worshippers include judges, executioners, and dream-clerics, who bear mirrored talismans and recite verdict-prayers beneath the stars.

Other deities in the pantheon include:

- **Seshmehet, Keeper of Breath** – A frog-headed goddess of embalming, silence, and the stillness between life and death. Her priests preserve the body and final breath of the dead, ensuring safe passage to the next world.

- **Dja-at, the Time-Sifter** – A veiled cobra who governs memory, forgetfulness, and transition. She is honored in rites of release, where burdens and secrets are ritually surrendered so that the soul may pass unencumbered.

- **Khem-Abes, the Dream-Marked** – A monkey god who sculpts the next world from mortal dreams and imagination. Trickster, artist, and psychopomp, Khem-Abes teaches that the dead carry their visions with them, shaping what lies beyond.

Each deity has their own temples, iconography, and cult practices, and most citizens of the Courts offer prayers to several gods depending on season, circumstance, and role within society. Divine service is woven into public and private life alike, with priesthoods guiding funerary rites, astrological ceremonies, and civic rituals that honor the ongoing alignment between the mortal soul and the stars.

Magic

Thursday, June 5, 2025 12:20 AM

The Emerald Courts are renowned throughout Barizad for their mastery of spirit magic, mummification, and dreamcraft—arcane disciplines that treat the soul as both vessel and medium. Magic in the Courts is not merely power; it is ritual, alignment, and transformation. Practitioners weave spells through sacred geometry, ancestral breath, and the starlit rhythm of death. Materials such as brass, star-metal, and embalming resin are treated not as mere reagents, but as arcane catalysts, each resonant with celestial purpose.

Among their magical traditions, the Dream Scribes are perhaps the most esoteric. These sorcerers and wizards inscribe spells directly into the minds of the sleeping—planting arcane formulae like seeds and harvesting them with incantations at dawn. Embalmer-Clerics, both priestly and practical, preserve the bodies of the dead not simply for burial, but for continued service, binding divine breath into their wrappings and awakening them in times of crisis or revelation. Meanwhile, the Mirror-Seers peer through polished brass to project soul-echoes into the Astral Planes, seeking answers from the dead, the unborn, or the ever-becoming.

The Courts also maintain several arcane rites known only to their priesthoods and high houses:

- Soul-Pyramid Ascension is the architectural cornerstone of their necromantic theology. Tombs are not prisons but launching structures, built with precise geometric harmonics designed to project the soul upward into the stellar vault, freeing it from the cycle of decay.

- Through Memory Harvesting, the dreams of dying elders are distilled into shimmering star-flasks, which are then ritually consumed by chosen heirs or successors. In this way, memory is not merely remembered—it is inherited.

- In matters of state or sacred conflict, Refraction Trials are held. Major decisions are submitted to mirror-judges, whose trance-induced visions reflect divine will as seen through structured dream-prophecy. These trials are binding; to act against them is to defy the alignment of one's own soul.

In all things, the Emerald Courts seek not to command the magical world, but to bring it into alignment with the soul's journey—from river to tomb, from memory to star.

Relationship with Zahr al-Naras

Thursday, June 5, 2025 12:21 AM

In the era of Zahr al-Narās, the Emerald Courts believed themselves to be in perfect alignment with the celestial order. They saw their kingdom as a reflection—a mirror on earth—of the Brass City's divine machinery. Their temples rose in geometrical precision, built from sun-white stone and gilded with brass veins, designed not merely as places of worship but as ritual mechanisms in their own right. Flame, number, and form became sacraments, each mirroring the vast and orderly workings of the Celestine Furnace.

Brass sigils were carved into the walls of tombs and inscribed on funerary wrappings to redirect soul-energy toward celestial gates believed to orbit the stars. These rites were not symbolic—they were functional, a sacred engineering meant to deliver the dead to their rightful place in the cosmic sequence.

But in the centuries since the fall, fractures have begun to show—not only in stone, but in belief. Some esoteric sects now claim that the founders of the Emerald Courts were never equals to the Brass City's architects. Instead, they were custodians of its lowest vaults, keepers of forgotten calendars, discarded prophecies, and unstable dream-threads deemed unworthy of inclusion in the central design. If true, it would mean their holy alignment was always partial, always on the periphery.

Worse still, doubt is spreading. With the Celestine Furnace broken, many whisper that the afterlife geometries no longer function—that souls no longer ascend as intended, that memory is no longer preserved, that the Mirror Falcon no longer reflects a path. The most devout deny it. The embalmers speak more softly. And in the shadowed crypts beneath the alabaster necropolises, something has begun to stir.

Factions Within the Emerald Courts

Thursday, June 5, 2025 12:23 AM

In the wake of the Brass City's fall and the growing uncertainty around the soul's journey, the Emerald Courts have fractured internally. While the God-Queen still reigns, her authority is contested not through open rebellion, but through philosophical divergence, spiritual reinterpretation, and arcane ambition. These three major factions define the current religious and political discourse.

The Court of Embalmed Radiance

The dominant traditionalist faction, the Court of Embalmed Radiance believes the old rites still hold meaning—even if their efficacy has waned. They argue that the celestial alignment has merely shifted, not ended, and that by preserving the ancient rituals, the Emerald Courts will find harmony again when the stars realign. Loyal to the God-Queen Seraphae VI and her priesthood, they serve as both defenders of the orthodoxy and stewards of the necropoli. Among them are high embalmers, soul-geometrists, and dream-astrologers dedicated to waiting with dignity for the return of divine order.

The Cult of the Hollow Star

Viewed as heretical by many, the Cult of the Hollow Star preaches a stark revelation: that the Mirror Falcon has gone blind, and that the old gods no longer see the souls of the dead. To them, the celestial order is shattered beyond repair. Some among the Cult call for deep ritual reform, while others push more radical agendas—including an alliance with Aram-Zaneth to forge a new path of ascension through fire, not starlight. Their leaders speak in riddled sermons and carry tarnished mirrors—symbols of truth denied. Though still a minority, their influence is growing, especially among younger philosophers and death-priests shaken by the failures of recent soul-launchings.

The Obelisk Restorationists

Where the others see metaphysics, the Obelisk Restorationists see malfunction. A coalition of engineers, astrologers, and necro-mechanics, they believe the soul-ascension system built into the ancient tombs and temples was never purely symbolic—it was a functional machine, one that can be repaired. They study brass geomancy embedded in tomb architecture, hoping to reignite the dormant channels of the Celestine Flame. The Restorationists are pragmatic, secular in tone, and often seen as dangerously close to heresy. Nonetheless, they are well-funded and occasionally recruit adventurers to retrieve relics and dream-fuel from deep within the broken vaults of the Brass City's fragments.

Key Locations

Tuesday, June 10, 2025 12:06 PM

Asmarat, the Rising Mirror

Also known as Nehket-Aset, “Heart of the River”

Asmarat is the radiant capital of the Emerald Courts, a city shaped as much by divine intention as by stone and water. Its name derives from ancient liturgical Ta'reni, meaning "Reflected Ascent" or "The Rising Mirror"—a reference to both the celestial ambitions of its people and the mirrored waters of the River Aset, which coils around the city in a wide oxbow bend. Brass obelisks and mirror-domed temples pierce the skyline, each aligned to once-reliable celestial nodes calculated by the dream-astronomers of the old age.

At the city’s heart rises the Pyramid of Alignment, a vast tomb-temple where each God-Queen is interred—and, it is said, ascended. Through esoteric rituals of soul-geometry, their spirits are measured and launched beyond the mortal plane. Nearby stands the Throne of Breath, the palace of the reigning monarch, carved directly into the cliff-face above the river. Its crystalline windows overlook the entire valley, catching the morning light like the gaze of a silent divinity.

Civic life in Asmarat moves to rhythms both sacred and strange. The Veiled Forum, an amphitheater of dream-projection, hosts trials and debates where litigants submit their sleeping minds for astral interrogation. Beneath the city, the Sepulchral Canal winds slowly through silent vaults, where embalmer-priests ferry the dead through stations of mnemonic purification, preparing each soul for passage into the stars.

Civic Identity

To the Ta'reni, Asmarat is not merely a city—it is a divine machine, built to guide the soul's passage toward proper ascension. Every street is laid along brass-inlaid star-paths, their alignments recalibrated after the fall of Zahr al-Narās. Yet disagreement now reigns over which constellations are true and which are echoes.

Its caste-districts mirror the functions of the celestial order:

- The Kheru Quarter is home to the soul-cultivators and river farmers, its fields ritually irrigated with Aset’s blessing.
- The Sheshnet Vaults house the embalmer-philosophers, who work in stone-walled necropolis-labs lit by candlelight and memory.
- The Nemet Spires rise toward the heavens, home to star-watchers and dream-casters, who chant the Codices of Alignment in observatories of mirrored glass.

By night, Asmarat flickers like the sky reborn—mirrorlight fires cast from tower to tower, refracting through smoke and brass to create constellations across the city’s face.

Modern Tensions

Long the beacon of spiritual certainty, Asmarat now teeters on the edge of dissonance. Its sacred machinery sputters. Its priests offer answers drowned in silence.

- **The Refraction Crisis**: Mirror-Seers report increasing distortions in dream-visions, their readings

blurred or contradictory. Some blame lingering echoes from the Vaults, while others whisper of a False Falcon that now perches where the true god once watched.

- **The Hollow Processions**: Season by season, more of the dead return from the sepulchral canals unaligned—their dream-flasks empty, their embalming glyphs twisted. Officially, they are "reinterred." In truth, they are stored beneath the palace, sealed away from the public eye.

- **Factional Influence**:
  - The Court of Embalmed Radiance continues its ancient rites unshaken, praying for realignment and divine return.

  - The Cult of the Hollow Star gathers in the Outer Ring, beneath cracked obelisks, offering dreams to strange lights that rise from below.

  - The Obelisk Restorationists labor in the undercity, reconstructing ancient soul-circuitry and seeking direct communion with the broken dream-engine that once governed fate.

Asmarat is a city of ritual beauty and crumbling order—equal parts divine relic and uncertain future. To walk its mirrored streets is to tread the line between memory and unmaking.

Overview

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:01 PM

The Myrian Halls are a coalition of ancient city-states strung like celestial beads along the banks of the River Mereth—a slow-moving, silver-hued current that nourishes terraced floodplains, basalt ziggurats, and starlit observatories. Each Hall is a sovereign entity, but all trace their lineage to the descent of the Sky-Born, divine envoys who walked the world during the age of Zahr al-Narās. Some claim direct communion with the Brass City before its fall; others were shaped by its shadow or entrusted with its discarded wisdom.

While other cultures worship gods, ideals, or elemental forces, the Myrians revere continuity—the unbroken inheritance of memory, prophecy, and descent. Their devotion lies with the Sky-Born: ancestral demigods and celestial functionaries who once walked the corridors of Zahr al-Narās and now speak only through visions, relics, and dream-etched rites. These beings are not distant abstractions, but remembered presences—figures whose footsteps remain visible in architecture, law, and ritual.

In the eyes of the Myrians, the fall of the Brass City was not the end of a divine era, but a cosmic interruption—a breach in the great alignment of heaven and memory. Through careful preservation of lineage, astronomical study, and the reading of Burning Tablets, the Myrian Halls seek to restore that alignment, and to usher in a new descent—one that will bind the mortal world once again to the celestial design.

Governance and Civic Order

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:06 PM

Each city-state within the Myrian Halls is ruled by a Prophet-King, a sovereign whose authority flows not from conquest, but from lineage and revelation. Their line is believed to carry the blood-memory of Naram-Kel, the Sky-Prince who first descended from Zahr al-Narās with flame in his breath and brass on his brow. This ancestral connection is not symbolic—it is treated as a living conduit of divine resonance, maintained through ritual recitations, dreamfasting, and starlit reflection.

Rule in the Myrian Halls is both sacred and bureaucratic. The Prophet-King does not act unilaterally; their decisions are shaped by prophetic signs, astral observation, and the interpretations of trained oracles. Yet alongside these divine influences, the Myrians are also a people of great technical precision—skilled in architecture, recordkeeping, and the celestial sciences. Laws are etched in brass, policies plotted with geomantic care.

At the heart of political guidance lies the Circle of Celestial Descent, a council composed of high-ranking Lens-Binders, who interpret omens and precedent to guide matters of war, alliance, and civic balance. Their authority is spiritual as much as procedural, ensuring that the paths chosen by mortals remain in harmony with the broken rhythms of the stars.

Even among the common folk, governance is interwoven with belief. Families maintain ancestral shrines in their homes or courtyards, and it is customary for every citizen—regardless of caste—to know and recite portions of The Descent Chronicle, a semi-mythic, semi-historical text that preserves their skyborn heritage. To be a Myrian is not only to live within the Halls, but to walk in the wake of descent—to know one's place in a legacy mapped across both stars and stone.

Lens Binders

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:08 PM

The Lens-Binders are a revered order of judges, augurs, and memory-interpreters within the Myrian Halls, entrusted with the weighty task of navigating the world's fractured destiny. They do not merely enforce law—they read it in light, reflection, and ancestral residue, serving as interpreters of the celestial order left behind by Zahr al-Narās.

Trained from youth in sacred observatories and lineage-houses, Lens-Binders learn to divine what paths remain safe, when the past must be reenacted, and how to circumvent the spiritual detritus left by the fallen city's disruption. Their judgments are both civic and cosmic—rendered in ritual cadence, spoken through echoed decree, and often carved into brass plaques to be preserved for future recitation.

Their tools are as unique as their calling:

- Brass mirrors, etched with living glyphs that shimmer and shift with fate's momentum. These are turned and angled beneath starlight or firelight, the resulting distortions studied for omens.
- Fragments of dream-gems, suspended in anointed oil or consecrated fire, which flicker with echoes of possible futures or half-remembered truths.
- Tablet-staves, long ceremonial rods engraved with ancestral memory cycles, used to trace ritual paths or call forth precedent from long-dead prophets and jurists.

The Lens-Binders do not claim to control fate—only to read its broken edges, to interpret which future-threads can be safely drawn forward, and to guard against the reawakening of paths that were sealed for good reason. In the Myrian worldview, justice is not about punishment—it is about restoration of alignment, and right memory.

Religion

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:09 PM

The Myrians do not pray to distant, faceless gods. Their deities were once celestial functionaries—star-guides, vision-keepers, and oathwardens—beings of purpose who descended in flame during the age of Zahr al-Narās. These divine figures are not abstract ideals, but ancestral truths made incarnate, remembered through rite and ritual as much as through faith.

Each god was once a part of the machinery of the heavens, and their worship preserves the Myrians' ongoing effort to realign mortal life with the broken rhythms of the cosmos.

Notable Divine Figures

- **Naram-Kel, the Sky-Prince**: Founder of the royal line, Naram-Kel is said to have fallen from the Brass City in an ark of memory and flame, carrying with him the first Burning Tablet and the rites of descent. He is worshipped not only as a progenitor, but as a living interface between heaven and lineage. His voice is believed to echo through brass obelisks at key celestial conjunctions.

- **Zarephah, the Veiled Watcher**: Oracle of the Third Dawn, Zarephah walks the meridians of the world in dream-form, her physical eyes forever covered by ceremonial veils. She is invoked in matters of vision and judgment, particularly when guidance must come through indirect or symbolic means. Many Myrian seers claim to channel her presence during lunar eclipses or memory rites.

- **Thuun, the Oath-Sleeper**: Patron of lineage, inheritance, and burial, Thuun is believed to slumber beneath the great necropoli, listening to the names of the dead as they are spoken into stone. His worship is solemn, rooted in the act of remembrance. He does not answer prayers, but remembers them—and in doing so, sustains the continuity of the soul across generations.

Forms of Worship

Myrian worship is communal, chanted, and always recorded. Sacred speech is carved into clay cylinders, etched onto stone stelae, or spun into thin brass scrolls that wind like metal ribbons around shrines and tombs. These inscriptions are not merely decorative—they serve as mnemonic conduits, ensuring that divine memory is not only preserved but actively recited into being.

Rituals often involve star-masks, echoed recitations, and the reperformance of descent myths, allowing participants to briefly occupy the path of their divine ancestors. Worship is as much an act of remembering as it is of devotion—for in the Myrian worldview, to be remembered is to remain aligned.

Magic

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:11 PM

Among the Myrians, spellcasting is not an act of creation—it is an act of recollection. Magic is a legacy, passed down from the Sky-Born and buried in the earth alongside forgotten truths. Practitioners do not invent new spells or innovate through experimentation; they recover, restore, and re-align that which was lost when the Brass City ruptured and scattered its design across the world.

Clerics of the Myrian Halls invoke divine power through ancestor masks, carved in brass or bone, and wield consecrated staves inscribed with lineage glyphs. Each casting is a reenactment—part prayer, part ritual drama—calling not only on divine principles, but on the remembered deeds of ancestral souls.

Wizards operate through ancient memory-devices called burning tablets—slabs of metal or petrified crystal that pulse with residual heat from their celestial origin. Each tablet contains star-scripts that encode long-buried truths, some prophetic, others schematic or mnemonic. These texts are read through flame, shadow, and timing, making Myrian magic as much an act of astronomy as spellwork.

Summoners are few, and always cautious. Spirits are only called if they belong within one's ancestral boundaries, or if summoned through blood-linked tokens attuned to a specific lineage. To summon a stranger-spirit is considered dangerous—even heretical—as it risks calling echoes not meant for one's path.

The Burning Tablets

The Burning Tablets are the cornerstone of Myrian magical philosophy. They are not laws, but cosmic notes—fragments of divine record that fell in flame from the sky as the Brass City tore open. Each tablet contains a sliver of fate: a flash of insight, a collapsed memory, or a functional diagram of celestial machinery.

Some are prophetic, foretelling celestial alignments and soul-cycles. Others are mnemonic, allowing one to retrieve the memories of long-dead ancestors. Still others are schematic, recording functions once handled by divine engines: how stars were turned, how dreams were indexed, how births were timed.

Most tablets cannot be read directly. They are interpreted through ritual timing, shadowplay, or proximity to sacred elements. In some cities, tablets are even buried beneath ziggurats, their presence intended to "seed" particular outcomes during floods, eclipses, or births. The Myrians believe these seeded events nudge fate gently back into shape.

To hold a true Burning Tablet is to touch a piece of the fallen divine. To misuse one is to risk reshaping reality in unintended ways.

Aesthetics

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:13 PM

The cities of the Myrian Halls are built as instruments of remembrance—designed not only to shelter the living, but to reflect the geometry of prophecy and celestial descent. Towering ziggurats dominate the skyline, each crowned with domed observatories of burnished stone and star-cut crystal. From these heights, priest-astronomers trace the motions of constellations, memory tides, and the rare alignments that signal divine intent.

Across plazas and terraces, polished copper obelisks stand in gleaming rows—ritual instruments used to measure the angles of dreams and starlight. Their reflective surfaces are inscribed with silent glyphs, and they are repositioned seasonally by the Order of the Lens, who believe the placement of each obelisk shapes the way prophecy flows through a city.

Clothing reflects this reverence for the heavens. Commoners wear robes of deep linen, dyed in dark hues and embroidered with constellations specific to their birth-sign or ancestral duty. The nobility and priesthood adorn themselves with braided metal bands, each etched with their lineage, revelations, and witnessed descents. These bands are worn not only as status symbols, but as mnemonic records—worn histories meant to be read, recited, and remembered.

Relationship with Zahr al-Narās

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:13 PM

To the Myrians, the order of Zahr al-Narās is not a god—it is a lost celestial homeland, a divine machine of alignment and purpose that once structured both heaven and memory. They do not worship it, but yearn for its return—not as supplicants, but as estranged heirs. It is the place from which the Sky-Born descended and to which the soul must one day ascend. Its fall was not simply catastrophe, but dislocation—a rupture in the rightful flow of remembrance.

Many among the Myrian Halls believe that fragments of the city's memory core—pieces of its dream-logic, prophecy-engine, and soul-matrix—were scattered across the world at the moment of collapse. These relics, hidden beneath ruins, embedded in the dreams of oracles, or encoded in the echo of certain bloodlines, await recollection and reconnection. The process is not conquest, but reassembly—not rebuilding the city as it was, but restoring its function within the grand cycle of descent and return.

Some factions within the Halls, including emerging heresies, hope to reignite the cycle, engineering a new descent of the Sky-Born to guide the world into a renewed harmony. Yet others sound a darker note, warning of false descents—machined mimicries of prophecy animated not by divine will, but by ambition and deception.

Foremost among these concerns is Sirr al-Nar, the fallen efreeti prince who claims divine purpose and seeks to rebuild the city in his own image. Many within the Halls regard him as a parasite wearing prophecy’s skin, a usurper who would forge alignment from tyranny. They whisper that his promised "second sky" is no cycle of return, but a trap of fire and order—a perfect cage mistaken for revelation.

Locations

Tuesday, June 10, 2025 12:31 PM

Kherum-Zan, Mouth of Remembrance

"Where the Sky-Prince first touched earth and the stars wrote flame into stone, there rose Kherum-Zan—the root of lineage, the mouth of remembrance."
—Opening lines of The Descent Chronicle

Kherum-Zan rises from the floodplains of the River Mereth like an etched memory. Built atop a broad natural rise carved into seven terraced platforms, the city stands as the ritual and mnemonic heart of the Myrian Halls. Though each city-state in the coalition governs itself, all defer spiritual primacy to Kherum-Zan. It is the place where history was first spoken, and where prophecy first cracked the sky.

At the summit of the city stands the Ziggurat of Naram-Kel, a titanic basalt-and-brass monument believed to mark the very spot where the Sky-Prince descended to earth. Beneath it spirals the Chronocrypt, a deep vault of interwoven time and memory, containing brass-threaded scrolls, dream-gem slivers, and charred fragments of Burning Tablets—living relics said to pulse with flickers of divine utterance.

To the east, clinging to the cliff's edge, lies the Mirror Scriptorium, home to the Lens-Binders—augurs who divine fate and law by studying mirrored glyphs suspended in fire-oil. Surrounding the city are the Stele Fields, a vast necropolis of memory obelisks etched with the names and deeds of lineage-keepers, prophets, and kings—an ever-growing archive of flesh made stone.

Governance and Faith

Kherum-Zan is ruled by the Prophet-King of Descent, a title passed only to direct descendants of Naram-Kel. The Prophet-King is not merely a ruler, but the living custodian of the central Burning Tablet—a relic too sacred to be touched, too volatile to be translated directly. Rulings are delivered in echoes, reflections, and inferred silences.

Worship in Kherum-Zan is not confined to temples—it is built into architecture, scholarship, and ritual lineage. The people do not merely pray; they recite, preserve, and enact. Every citizen of note must trace their role through a chain of memory and descent back to one of the Sky-Born.

Spiritual Core and Magic

Kherum-Zan is not simply a city—it is a celestial mechanism, aligned with seasonal conjunctions, lineage tides, and prophetic fulcrums. Its central spiritual site, the Hall of the Sealed Flame, contains the First Burning Tablet—a divine artifact so potent it remains too hot to touch, its wisdom accessible only through shadowplay, echo, and heat-distortion. Entire priesthoods train to interpret its flickers.

Magic here is seen as recovered truth, not invention. Clerics invoke the Sky-Born through mask-rites—ceremonies that align their voice and motion with remembered gods. Wizards, too, act as scholars more than casters, drawing spells from ancient celestial predictions rather than personal inspiration. To improvise magic in Kherum-Zan is to risk hubris; to unearth it is to restore the intended shape of the world.

Current Tensions

Kherum-Zan's serenity is only surface-deep. Beneath the basalt and brass, cracks are forming:

- **The First Flame Flickers**: For the first time in recorded memory, the flame beneath the First Tablet

has begun to waver. Some claim it marks a new descent, a moment of renewal. Others warn of a false return—a deception crafted to mislead the faithful into restoring something broken.

- **The Lost Lineage Returns**: A forgotten descendant of Naram-Kel, believed dead for over a century, has returned bearing a shard of living memory—a scene not found in any lineage record. Some view it as a miracle. Others whisper that it may be a forgery, or worse: a seed planted by Aram-Zaneth.

- **The Heresy of the Future Tablets**: A schism is forming among the Lens-Binders, as a young faction begins inscribing future tablets—provisional prophecies meant to guide rather than record. Traditionalists condemn the act as dangerous fabrication, while rumors swirl that the movement is subtly backed by Aram-Zaneth as a tool of corruption and premature rebirth.

- **Sirr al-Nar's Whispered Promises**: Agents of the fallen efreeti lord Sirr al-Nar have begun circulating among the outer halls, offering dreams of a "second sky"—a forged celestial machine, perfected under fire and will. To those desperate for renewal, such promises are hard to ignore.

Overview

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:20 PM

The Satrapies of Varnash stretch across a rich and sun-drenched empire of river-fed valleys, tiered strongholds, and polished monuments—a golden sprawl of pageantry and power, ruled from the ancient seat of Zin-Ravan, where banners catch the wind like fire and proclamations echo from marble colonnades. In an age where much of the world clings to memory or shivers in dread, the Varnathi possess a rare and defiant gift: swagger.

Where others approach the remnants of Zahr al-Narās with reverence or terror, the Varnathi approach them with ambition. They do not kneel before fate—they hunt it, melt it, and reforge it. They claim that destiny is not bestowed but seized, and they point to their greatest treasure as proof: True Brass—a radiant, weighty alloy recovered from the shattered vaults of the Brass City, polished until it gleams like a second sun. The Varnathi wear it as armor, forge it into heirlooms, and inlay it into their temples and thrones. It is both artifact and declaration.

To outsiders, the Varnathi seem grandiloquent and garish—given to flamboyant ceremony, bold gestures, and veiled threats delivered like poetry. But beneath the gold and crimson lies a machine of calculated power, built on ancestral house-gods, military pageantry, and the belief that fate favors those who dazzle it.

Structure and Governance

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At the summit of Varnathi power sits the Shahenshar, the King of Kings, a monarch whose word gilds law and whose will is carried by a host of satraps—semi-autonomous governors who rule their provinces with near-absolute authority, provided they pay tribute, honor their lineage, and uphold the empire's public image of grandeur.

Each satrapal house maintains a House Vault, a sanctified chamber that holds their most sacred possession: a shard of True Brass, recovered (or claimed to be recovered) from the fallen vaults of Zahr al-Narās. These polished relics are not merely symbols of authority—they are believed to resonate with celestial defiance, humming with the will of those who once stood beneath the gears of fate and chose to rise instead of serve.

The satrapal houses are fiercely competitive, engaging in ritual duels, elaborate court games, and public contests of wealth, wit, and spectacle. Outshining one's peers is a sacred act, seen as a way of drawing fate's attention—and admiration. Intrigue is both expected and encouraged, for to maneuver cleverly within the bounds of tradition is to prove one's worthiness.

Yet in times of true crisis, this flamboyant fractiousness vanishes. The Varnathi are known for their sudden, overwhelming unity—a trait their enemies often underestimate. When threatened, the satraps move not as rivals but as limbs of the same imperial body, each wielding polished brass and centuries of practiced coordination in defense of their shared legacy.

True Brass: the Sacred Alloy

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:21 PM

"It does not rust. It does not burn. It reflects even godlight."
—Inscription on the Vault-Gate of House Qarezath

True Brass is more than a metal—it is the cornerstone of Varnathi belief, power, and identity. Said to be the original medium of celestial governance, it once carried command-signals through the mechanisms of Zahr al-Narās, channeling will and order across divine architectures. Now, in the hands of mortal scions, it serves a new purpose: shield, scepter, and anchor—a way to claim autonomy from fate and reassert mortal primacy.

Each noble house of Varnash possesses a sacred relic of True Brass, recovered or inherited from the ruins of the fallen city. These relics take many forms—blades, circlets, mirrors, signet-seals—but all are polished to near-perfection, revealing a brilliance said to reflect truth unclouded by gods or dreams. Varnathi believe that to carry True Brass is to anchor the self against the tides of fate, memory, and divine interference.

Priests and artisans devote their lives to the tuning of these relics—adjusting harmonics, engraving resonance-glyphs, and polishing until the brass gleams like a second sun. Some believe this tuning affects not just magic, but probability itself—subtly reshaping outcomes, deflecting misfortune, and bending alignment toward ambition.

Magical Properties (In-Game Effects)

Items made of or inlaid with True Brass confer the following magical benefits:

- **Resonant Will**: The bearer gains resistance (a bonus on saving throws) against mind-affecting effects, fate-binding spells (such as *Mark of Justice*, *Geas/Quest*), and celestial magic that compels or reveals alignment.

- **Refraction of Prophecy**: Attempts to divine the bearer's future (via *Divination*, *Augury*, or similar spells) are likely to fail, misfire, or return misleading echoes unless the caster succeeds at a high caster level check or possesses aligned relics of their own.

- **Brass City Interface**: True Brass items can resonate with Celestine mechanisms, allowing them to unlock or disrupt magical locks, prophecy-engines, or dream-matrix systems embedded in Brass City fragments. Some artifacts only respond to those bearing True Brass, treating them as "authorized users" or corrupted heirs.

The Mirror Guard

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The elite warriors of Varnash are the Mirror Guard—a gleaming phalanx of radiant discipline, deadly elegance, and unyielding will. They are as much symbols of Varnathi pride as they are instruments of war, embodying the belief that brilliance—both literal and personal—is its own form of dominance.

Clad in polished armor so bright it reflects even illusion, each soldier becomes a weapon of psychological warfare before blades are ever drawn. Their presence is overwhelming: a marching wall of light and purpose, unclouded by hesitation or doubt.

- **Weapons of Expectation**: Mirror Guards wield curved sabers and scimitars inlaid with True Brass, said to slice not only through flesh but through the futures of their enemies—undoing anticipated strikes, shattering fate-guided maneuvers.

- **The Gleam Duels**: Prestige and command are not won through blood alone, but in the ritualized Duels of Gleam—contests judged by form, flare, and the optical brilliance of a warrior's stance and regalia. In such contests, the quality of reflection can matter more than the edge of steel.

- **Training and Doctrine**: Mirror Guards train not only in martial skill, but in philosophical poise, reflexive meditation, and composure under celestial scrutiny. To flinch is to tarnish. To waver is to invite shadow.

In battle, they are relentless—but in the eyes of the Varnathi people, they are something more: avatars of mortal defiance, warriors who do not bow to prophecy, but reflect it… and then shatter it.

Religion and Ideology

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:24 PM

The gods of the Varnathi are conceived as a celestial court—a radiant and hierarchical pantheon that reflects the empire's own sense of grandeur, ambition, and showmanship. Temples double as salons, shrines as theaters. To worship is to display divine favor through confidence, poise, and command.

Zirad, Sovereign of Gleam and Inheritance

High King of the Divine Court

Zirad rules both heaven and empire in ideal. He represents glory not as a gift, but as an inheritance to be polished and displayed. Every ruler who dons a crown reflects him, and his mirrored circlet reveals not his own face—but yours, as you ought to be.

- Alignment: Lawful Neutral
- Domains: Brass, Fate, Reckoning
- Symbols: Mirrored crown, radiant chain, lion rampant
- Favored Weapon: Glaive
- Worshippers: Nobles, satraps, judges, those who claim divine mandate
- Rituals: Public recitations of lineage, declaration duels, dream-oaths before mirrors

Nahara, the Forge-Mother

Goddess of Shaping, True Brass, and Artifice

Nahara shaped the first star-metal from the bones of extinct suns, and her breath is said to still linger in the glow of forge-fires. Her temples are hallowed foundries, and her priests wear aprons and veils of goldthread. Her blood became True Brass, and it is through her guidance that the empire resists the pull of fate.

- Alignment: Lawful Good
- Domains: Brass, Trade, Fire
- Symbols: Flame-wrapped anvil, molten droplet, smith's braid
- Favored Weapon: Warhammer
- Worshippers: Artisans, armorers, engineers, brasskeepers
- Rituals: Relic-tuning, forge-blessings, brass-alloy anointments for newborns

Virelune, Mirror of Graces

Goddess of Beauty, Duel, and Public Glory

Virelune is the divine patron of elegance—whether expressed in movement, speech, or war. Her worshippers duel with wit or blade, asserting their presence as if it were a form of art. Mirrors are sacred to her, as are moments of perfect defiance that reshape expectation into admiration.

- Alignment: Chaotic Good
- Domains: Echo, Glory, Trickery
- Symbols: Silvered blade, hand poised before a mirror, lacquered mask
- Favored Weapon: Rapier
- Worshippers: Performers, duelists, diplomats, provocateurs
- Rituals: Dances of Defiance, reflected prayers, ceremonial boasting before trial

The Lesser Divinities and Household Spirits

Outside the court's primary triad, dozens of lesser spirits walk the palatial halls of the Varnathi divine order. They govern trade, travel, style, and secrets—reflections of daily life in a society where divine favor is measured in polish and prestige.

- Kavreth, the Coinbinder – God of elegant commerce and elevated thievery. Associated Domains: Trade, Trickery

- Senna-of-the-Drapes – Goddess of rumor, drapery, and seductive half-truths. Associated Domains: Trickery, Echo

- Varnu-Taz, the Watchful Flame – Minor flame spirit invoked for guidance and protection. Associated Domains: Ash, Protection

- Children of Nahara – Spirit familiars that dwell in relics of True Brass. Associated Domains: Brass, Craft

Relationship with Zahr al-Narās

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:24 PM

To the people of Varnash, Zahr al-Narās was not a divine beacon, but a brittle edifice—an empire of gleaming machinery too rigid to endure. While others speak of the City with reverence or dread, the Varnathi regard its fall as an opportunity claimed. They do not mourn its passing; they refine it. True Brass, pried from shattered vaults and reforged into weapons, symbols, and regalia, is celebrated not as a relic of lost grandeur, but as a tool of Varnathi ascendance.

The empire views the City's former stewards—djinn, constructs, and Celestine automatons—not as guardians of sacred order, but as failed custodians, clinging to obsolete purpose. Where others see mystery and taboo, the Varnathi see challenge and conquest. Reclaiming the City's legacy is not a matter of faith, but of pride. Each shard polished, each sigil repurposed, is another proof that fate bows not to prophecy, but to those with the strength to rewrite it.

Aesthetics

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:25 PM

The cities of Varnash dazzle with architectural bravado—towering palaces of sun-washed stone capped in brass-tiled roofs that shimmer like flame yet remain cool to the touch. Great plazas are lined with statues and obelisks, each bearing mirrored faces. These are not memorials to ancestors, but instruments of aspiration; in their reflections, the viewer is reminded that ambition is the highest offering.

Varnathi fashion is bold and resplendent. Robes of flowing silk are trimmed in etched metals, accented with mirrored jewelry and reflective veils worn ceremonially over the eyes. Appearance is power, and in Varnash, to gleam is to be seen—and to be seen is to matter.

Notable Location

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:26 PM

Zin-Ravan

Capital of the Satrapies and crown of the Shahenshar's dominion, Zin-Ravan blazes with polished glory. At its heart stands the Vault of Echoes, a subterranean reliquary said to contain whispered prophecies captured in the aftermath of the Brass City's fall. From its gleaming spires, the Shahenshar issues decrees that ripple across the empire like reflected light.

Sul-Hajra

The artisan-satrapy of Sul-Hajra is famed for its True Brass forges—sacred workshops where molten alloys are cast into relics, arms, and diplomatic gifts. Its hereditary mirror-casters are revered as both artisans and visionaries, each trained to shape reflection into revelation.

The Brazen Steps

Rising along the terraced slopes of western Varnash, the Brazen Steps serve as both ceremonial dueling grounds and arenas of prestige. Nobles meet here in ritual combat, judged not only by blade and blood, but by brilliance of form, polish of armor, and elegance of motion.

The Reflecting Border

Along the empire's outermost marches stretches a shimmering no-man's-land where prophecy falters and scrying grows mute. This anomaly is maintained by ancient pylons of aligned True Brass, said to bend fate itself. It is both shield and challenge—inviting intrusion only from the bold or the foolish.

Overview

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 10:24 PM

The Thalassocracy of Nisarun is a confederation of coastal city-states and sea-bound enclaves, ruled by merchant-kings, wind-ship captains, and veiled seers who read the tides of fate as easily as the tides of water. Built atop slender isles, coral-strung reefs, and wind-carved cliffs, the Nisari do not define their power by landholdings, but by the routes they command—trade winds, dream-tides, and arcane sea-lanes charted across both sea and sky.

Nisarun's influence stems not from empire but from indispensability. Masters of negotiation, nautical sorcery, and hidden exchange, the Nisari weave themselves into every major current of power across Barizad. Their fleets are known to appear wherever rare goods, forbidden knowledge, or broken alliances drift to the surface. In this web of commerce and secrets, they offer not allegiance but leverage.

While some nations cling to prophecy or pursue conquest, the Nisari cultivate opportunity. They make no pretense of neutrality—they simply lease it.

Society and Governance

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:31 PM

The Thalassocracy is governed by the Concord of Keels, a rotating council of high captains, house-magi, and guild factors drawn from the most profitable ships and influential sea-holds. Seats on the Concord are earned, not inherited—granted through wealth, navigation rights, and the strategic leverage of trade pacts.

In Nisarun, no land-bound monarch holds authority. Every noble title is charted through movement—secured by cargo tonnage, navigational mastery, or sheer cunning. Even magical prowess is measured by its ability to shift tides of influence rather than tides of war.

Central to Nisari politics are ledger-seals—enchanted tokens that track favors, debts, trade shares, and binding oaths. Crafted from pearl-inlaid brass and coded with shifting glyphs, these seals are more than mere accounting tools; they serve as instruments in ritual dealings, diplomatic ceremonies, and even arcane conflicts, where power is calculated in the weight of obligation.

Economy

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:32 PM

Nisarun's dominance arises not from empire, but from exchange. The Thalassocracy controls the flow of rare and potent materials harvested from the wreckage of the Brass City and the deeper currents of the dreaming sea. Chief among their exports are brass fragments, salvaged from fallen sky-shards and sold to arcanists, warlords, and restoration cults alike. Their value lies not only in their metallurgical properties but in their resonance with Celestine mechanisms.

Even more coveted are dream-gems—unstable crystalline forms infused with fragmented memory, precognition, or altered possibility. These volatile stones are mined from seabed trenches and storm-reefs and are used in everything from spellcraft to prophecy to assassination.

The Nisari also harvest star-salt, a glittering reagent that forms only during rare astral tides. When refined, it enhances divination, nullifies planar interference, or subtly shifts probability. Its supply is carefully managed, with prices that fluctuate like the moons.

Perhaps most controversially, the Thalassocracy trades in licenses of passage—legal contracts sold to foreign powers that guarantee safe entry into forbidden or contested Celestine sites. These licenses are often double-sold, granting multiple claimants the illusion of exclusivity and sowing chaos for profit.

Beyond physical goods, the Nisari traffic in myth-debts, sealed truths, and contracted silences—intangible currencies bartered among kings and prophets, binding as any spell. For the right price, the Thalassocracy will sell a whisper that topples a dynasty—or suppress one that could unmake a god.

Relgion and Ideology

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:33 PM

The people of Nisarun revere Nimurah, goddess of tides, secrets, commerce, and the mirror-sea. She is neither a goddess of dominion nor benevolence—her power lies in reflection, reciprocity, and the ambiguity between truth and illusion. Worship of Nimurah is less a matter of piety and more a covenant: to invoke her is to enter into a contract, whether whispered or writ, visible or veiled.

Her temples are not halls of sermon, but sanctuaries of still water and silvered glass. Here, priests do not speak doctrine—they refract meaning through symbolism, mirrored gestures, and whispered parables. These sanctuaries often double as neutral grounds for negotiation and arbitration. When Nimurah's name is invoked in trade or oath, her presence is binding—though rarely straightforward. Her clergy often act as mediators, oath-witnesses, and keepers of sealed truths.

She is depicted as a veiled woman with a face of rippling water, bearing in one hand a coiled scroll and in the other a scale tipped with coin and feather. Her image shifts depending on the angle of reflection—always familiar, never the same.

The Three Tenets of Nimurah form the basis of Nisari theology and mercantile custom:

1. **All tides return**
   No deed, debt, or truth remains buried forever.

2. **Nothing seen is whole**
   Every truth has a shadow, and every contract a hidden clause.

3. **A price paid twice is still paid**
   Value lies not in fairness, but in finality.

To worship Nimurah is to accept that knowledge is always partial, and that every bargain—however murky—carries consequence.

Magic

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:33 PM

The seafaring mages and wind-scribes of Nisarun navigate not only oceanic currents, but the dreamflows and planar tides that lace the world in unseen routes. Where most empires measure power in territory, the Nisari measure it in access—channels of wind, dream, and forgotten memory made traversable through esoteric craft.

Nisari wind-ships are elegant vessels that combine engineering and arcana. Each is propelled by bound air elementals, their force channeled through brass-thread sails and mirror-kites designed to harness ethereal winds. These ships can sail along the surface of the sea or, at the height of ritual convergence, skim the planar veil itself.

Guidance falls to the astronomer-scribes, arcane navigators who chart not just stars but dream-currents—tides of thought and emotion that drift between the Material Plane, the Ethereal, and the Realm of Dream. These flows are said to connect forgotten memories, lost prophecies, and even unrevealed futures.

Whispers persist among these mariners of the Deep Below—a shadow realm mirroring the sea's floor, where memories that were never fulfilled and truths that were never spoken drift in endless stillness. Some captains claim to have glimpsed it in their dreams. Others have vanished pursuing it.

To the Nisari, a map is never merely ink on parchment—it is a contract with uncertainty, a promise that the invisible may yet be sailed.

Relationship with Zahr al-Narās

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:34 PM

To the merchant-lords of Nisarun, the fall of Zahr al-Narās is not a tragedy but an opportunity—a sunken venture ripe for salvage. Where others speak of reverence or ruin, the Nisari speak of routes, contracts, and controlled access.

The Thalassocracy maintains calculated neutrality in dealings with post-Celestine powers, including the volatile Efreeti warlords who now claim dominion over many Brass Fragments. Nisari ships are often granted passage not out of respect, but out of utility—they carry artifacts, knowledge, and dream-gems between rival courts, charging dearly for discretion.

Through shell companies, hidden brokers, and misfiled ledgers, the Nisari routinely broker access to restricted vaults, transport volatile relics, and “lose” cargo to rivals or allies as leverage demands. These maneuvers are rarely traced and never confessed.

Among the Efreet, the Nisari are tolerated—useful, but untrustworthy. It is said that no oath binds a Nisari tighter than the profit it earns, and even then, only until the tides shift.

Aesthetics

Thursday, June 5, 2025 10:35 PM

Nisarun's coastal cities shimmer like mirages upon the sea, their shell-inlaid domes and silvered ports rising like sails upon the horizon. Architecture follows no uniform pattern—each structure is shaped by wind, wealth, and whim, often resembling crested waves or mirrored reefs.

Nisari fashion is fluid and symbol-laden. Courtiers veil their faces in silk, favoring jewel-toned robes adorned with spiral motifs and knotwork glyphs representing contracts, oaths, or sea-routes. Clothing often hints at one's social function or ship allegiance, but is never static—adaptability is a virtue.

Markets overflow with color and scent: salt and ink, starfruit and ash wine, dream-gems beside dried seaweed scrolls. Nothing is labeled; everything is negotiated.

Naming customs reflect heritage through deed or voyage. A typical name might be "*Zeyra-of-the-Third-Tide*" (born during a seasonal storm) or "*Maruin Dream-Safe*" (survivor of a prophetic gale). Such names shift over time, growing or changing with reputation.

To the Nisari, the gravest insult is to be called "*anchored*"—a slur implying spiritual inertia, single-mindedness, or servitude to fixed truths. It is a label not of ignorance, but of inflexibility—the one sin Nisarun cannot forgive.

Locations

Tuesday, June 10, 2025 12:19 PM

Tirazûn (Metropolis, Pop. 42,000)

"The Deep Ledger" – Capital of the Thalassocracy of Nisarun

Tirazûn is not built upon stone, but upon contract, current, and cunning. Spanning the glittering bay of an archipelago at the mouth of the great sea, Tirazûn is a floating metropolis—a woven flotilla of reef-halls, anchored barges, ledger-spires, and market-ships. It drifts, shifts, and resettles like the tides it worships.

Concord Spire, a sea-glass and brass tower at the flotilla's heart, houses the Concord of Keels—the ruling council of merchant-princes and ship-lords. Beneath it lie the Salt Vaults, where magical ledger-seals shimmer with debt, favor, and prophecy, each seal a contract both arcane and legally binding.

The Gossamer Span, a monumental bridge of sailcloth and silver-thread, tethers the city to the mainland, billowing in wind and magic alike. Along the Whisper Docks, Tide-Court Galleons—immense moored vessels—serve as courts, brothels, embassies, and negotiation halls, each governed by its ship's patronage and history.

Government & Law

Tirazûn is governed by commerce and oaths. Rule lies with the Concord of Keels, but true authority is measured by one's Port-Right Registry—a magical record of which ship and contract last claimed your allegiance. Ship-titles outweigh land-holdings, and justice is dictated by sealed oath and public arbitration.

The city's rhythm is set by the Fluctuating Tide, a market bell rung according to dream-divinations of astral and oceanic currents. Business hours shift daily, guided not by the sun but by tides of fate.

Religion

The Hall of Still Waters, Nimurah's grand temple, crowns Concord Spire. Traders enter barefoot across mirrored pools. Her priesthood, the Sea-Veils, answer no questions aloud—instead offering refractions, silent gestures, and inked dreams cast into still water.

Cultural Notes

- Everything is negotiable. Even divine blessings have sliding scales.
- Public contracts are recited in the Chamber of Echoed Oaths by disembodied dream-voices.
- Common insults include "anchored" (meaning inflexible) and "unveiled" (meaning transparently naïve).
- Tirazûn is both a neutral ground and a den of manipulation, where even prophecies are bought and sold.

Overview

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 11:15 PM

It stood not in the heavens, nor on earth, but in the narrow place *between fate and void* — a miracle of divine clockwork where every soul had a place, and every moment a meaning. From its burning heart, the Celestine Furnace spun dreams into prophecy, weaving the destinies of gods and mortals alike.

Before it fell, the Brass City was as constant as the wind, as sure as sunrise.

You could see it with your own eyes — a second sun, gleaming in brass and flame, carving a perfect arc opposite the true sun across the vault of sky.

Each dawn, as the sun rose in the east, Zahr al-Narās emerged from the west — a mirrored twin with a colder light, a mechanical gleam.

Each dusk, as the sun set, the City slipped once more into the horizon, vanishing into the Plane of Fire, where it was said to dwell when hidden from the mortal eye.

It turned like clockwork, day after day, age after age — always precise, always present.

To shepherds and sailors, it was a navigational truth.
To kings and mystics, a celestial omen.
To poets and prophets, it was destiny made visible.

Many believed it governed the turning of the seasons, the shape of dreams, the rise and fall of empires. And why not? All things happened in its shadow. It was not just seen — it was *felt*, in every rhythm of life.

The scholars of Barizad charted its orbit. Priests timed rituals to its rising. Even those who claimed disbelief still adjusted their calendars to match its path.

And then… it did not rise.

One morning, the Brass City simply failed to emerge. The sun rose alone. The western sky was empty.

At first, people waited. Then they worried. Then came the signs:

- Fragments falling like stars.
- Earthquakes and strange firestorms.
- Dreams that bled into waking life.
- The appearance of shattered skylands and burning ruins in places they had never been before.

The city broke; tearing loose from its appointed position in the sky and crashing to the world below. The faithful say it was wounded or betrayed by the fault of men. The mad claim it was torn-down or cast aside by a greater will.

Whatever the truth, the world is no longer synchronized; no longer predictable or regular.

Prophecy fails.
And in the sky, where once its light turned in perfect reflection of the sun —
there is only emptiness.

The Caste-Laws of Flame: Efreeti Social Orders

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 11:16 PM

Among the surviving warlords and memory-husks of the Brass City, traces of the old Efreeti caste system still smolder. It was not merely a social order—it was a metaphysical alignment, a divine hierarchy encoded into the structure of the city itself.

The Dahrin, known as the Flame-Aristocracy, were the only genies permitted individual agency. Composed entirely of efreet, the Dahrin did not see themselves as monarchs or tyrants, but as vessels of the Celestine Will—unchanging, unfeeling executors of the city's design. All judges and law-givers were drawn from this caste, for it was believed only the Dahrin could remain truly aligned, unswayed by affection, ambition, or grief.

Beneath them stood the Jannat al-Rūḥ, the "Souls of Insight," a caste of scholars, oracles, and fate-interpreters. Often depicted with flame-veiled eyes and mirrored scrolls, these beings interpreted the Great Harmonic Script—an ever-evolving metaphysical record of possible futures. They offered no kindness in the mortal sense: their concept of mercy was to revise a soul’s alignment, correcting disharmony through death or re-scripting. According to their creed, only those destined to comprehend truth would ever do so.

At the foundation of this hierarchy were the Kibrīn, the laboring castes—golem-forgers, keepers of pressure-vaults, and architects of harmony. Unlike the Dahrin, the Kibrīn had no will of their own, yet were perfectly aligned with purpose, believing any deviation from their role was akin to flawed metallurgy. In their creed, to maintain the city's function was to preserve the cosmos itself. Their work was sacred, not because of its utility, but because of its stability.

Though the city has fallen and its castes scattered, echoes of this tripartite order still linger in the minds of surviving efreet and their monstrous spawn—burned not only into history, but into the very laws by which they continue to shape their fractured domains.

The Celestine Furnace

Tuesday, June 3, 2025 10:50 PM

"Fed with star-blood and bound oaths, it boiled futures like steam from a god's mouth."

Deep within the core of Zahr al-Narās — past the flame-wound halls, beneath the sapphire domes that tracked the movements of fate — there stood the Celestine Furnace.

It was no mere engine, though it turned.
No simple shrine, though it radiated mystical energy.
It was a machine of impossible breadth, a living crucible of brass, crystal, and bound flame — and it was the center around which the Brass City turned.

The old texts say it was built to refine the future, or perhaps to anchor it.
Others call it the *Font of Prophecy*, the *Womb of Time*, or the *Living Clock*.
None of these names are without merit.

What is known — what is whispered even now — is this:

- The Celestine Furnace was fed with dreams. Not ordinary ones, but the *true* dreams — the raw, volatile visions of seers, mystics, and chosen vessels.
- Each was captured and stored in a jeweled crucible: a gem cut to hold destiny.
- These were fed to the Furnace in solemn procession.
- And in return, the world moved forward with *purpose*.

It is said the Furnace did not simply see the future — it shaped it, distilling infinite possibility into a single, burning thread. A thread that the City followed, and through it, the world.

The mechanism itself defies sense. Clockwork beyond comprehension: gears the size of cathedrals, orbs of polished aether spinning in suspended gyres, incantation-loops etched in molten brass and chanted by the intricate bellows of the machine itself. Choirs of bound fire-scribes once maintained its rituals. No mortal hands ever touched its workings — only watched, and feared, and obeyed.

And at the center of it all — buried deeper than even the Furnace's architects could reach — something beat.

Not a heart of flesh, but of liquid foresight, molten and alive. It pulsed with every spoken prophecy. It flared with every diverted fate. It may have been a soul. It may have been a god. It may have been a question that no one dared ask.

Now, the Furnace lies broken, its crucibles scattered across the world. Some shattered, some still full, some whispering.

And without it, time is unwound thread, tangled and fraying.

What remains burns cold.
What was true may no longer be.
And the heart… the heart may still beat.

Zaneth's Heresy

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 11:21 PM

Before the fall, even gods were bound to the will of Zahr al-Narās.

They did not rule fate—they *served* it.
Each divine act, each answered prayer, each miracle: a stroke along the preordained wheel, measured and permitted by the hidden workings of the Brass City.

But one among resented his subjugation.
One among them asked: *What if my will could turn the wheel?*

His name was Zaneth — Scholar of Ashes. The First Blasphemer.

He was not a rebel in the mortal sense. He did not raise armies or burn temples.
His crime was conceptual.

He believed fate could be *edited—not* defied in ignorance or passion, but remade, thoughtfully, carefully, with full understanding of the consequences.

Zaneth sought to forge new destinies within the very architecture of the City. Not to break the system, but to rewrite it from the inside — a divine act of authorship.

To most, he was not evil.
To the architects of the Brass City, he was incompatible — a contradiction in motion.
His prayers no longer echoed correctly.
His miracles rang off-tempo.
The Celestine Furnace rejected his offerings.

So they chained him.

Not in hatred; but in patient, quiet necessity.
Not as punishment, but as quarantine.

He was bound in fire and silence. His name excised from liturgies, his glyphs struck from records. His followers — those few who still listened — whisper his teachings not as prophecy, but as *counterpoint*.

They say he still burns, somewhere deep beneath the ruins, a divine ember held in stasis.
They say he speaks through broken clocks and dreams that forget how they end.
They say the fall of the City was not his doing — but his chance.

For in a world where fate is cracked and bleeding, Zaneth’s vision might finally take root.

A future not inherited, but chosen.
A world no longer read from the scroll of time, but written by trembling hand.

The Fall of the Brass City

Wednesday, June 4, 2025 11:23 PM

"When the gears faltered, I reached into the engine. That was not pride—it was duty. The pride came after… when I realized there were none greater."

- Sirr al-Nar

Background: High Harmonist of the Celestine Furnace

Long before the fall, Sirr al-Nar was the High Harmonist of the Celestine Furnace—a position of immense responsibility and reverence within Zahr al-Narās, the City of Brass. It was his solemn task to monitor and temper the endless fire at the city's core: a divine mechanism that burned the fates of mortals and spirits to power the cosmic order. Each ember fed the gears of destiny, and it was Sirr al-Nar's genius that ensured their sequence remained intact.

Among the ancient Dahrin caste Sirr al-Nar was unmatched in brilliance. He did not see himself as a ruler or tyrant, but as a vessel of sacred precision. To him, fate was a machine, and he was its most faithful conductor: flame made flesh, whose purpose was not dominion, but harmony.

The Rebellion That Broke the Sky

Though fiercely loyal to the City of Brass, Sirr al-Nar was not blind. In the deep workings of the Celestine Furnace, he began to detect patterns of instability—subtle misfires, delayed echoes, recursive delays in the dream-feed of fate. Convinced that catastrophe loomed, he made the decision to intervene.

At first, his actions were quiet. He adjusted calibrations, redirected flows of prophecy, even reordered dreams before they reached the crucibles. But soon, his interventions grew bolder—and his self-regard with them. He no longer trusted his peers to see what he saw. He circumvented their authority, suppressed disagreement, and eventually demanded full control over the Furnace's harmonics.

What began as reform became rupture. His "improvements" introduced variables the city's logic could not reconcile. Recursive collapse spread across the celestial lattice. Reality fractured. The Brass City began to fall—not by betrayal or invasion, but from within. Sirr al-Nar's ambition, born of reverence, became the very cause of the end he sought to prevent.

The Ash Architect: Now and Ever

Sirr al-Nar did not die in the collapse. Nor did he fully survive. He now exists in a liminal state: partially ruptured, partially ascended. His form remains largely efreeti—immense, regal, crowned in ceremonial brass—but his essence is no longer bound by elemental flame alone. He has become something else: a philosopher-engineer of catastrophic revision, a being who sees the gears of fate as both his inheritance and his right.

He wields Ashfire, a legendary and terrifying metaphysical flame that burns through not just matter, but through structure itself—contracts, timelines, divine law. No oath holds before him, no logic remains unwarped. His very presence disrupts continuity.

Sirr al-Nar's new goal is not vengeance. It is restoration—on his terms. He seeks to rebuild the Brass City, reforged in his image, and reassert control over the threads of destiny. Where once he was a guardian of the pattern, he now intends to become its sole Architect.

And should mortals or gods resist, he will burn away their futures to make room.

I. In Game:
   a. See Sirr al-Nar's stat-block.

Post-Fall Consequences

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Even in ruin, the legacy of Zahr al-Narās endures.

The fall of the Brass City did not erase it. Instead, it shattered it—violently yet incompletely—casting its architecture, logic, and metaphysical machinery across the world like flaming debris from a broken star. These fragments did not become inert. They still function, in a manner of speaking. They continue to enforce the last commands they received before the crash, unaware—or uncaring—that the world around them has moved on.

Many of these fragments manifest as vast labyrinthian structures; cryptic and paradoxical in nature. Within their warped halls, time may loop, replay, or fracture. Choices vanish once made. Memories become locked gates. In some, a door opened in the past remains closed in the present. Others enforce recursive trials, demanding the same decision again and again until the "correct" one is chosen, regardless of context.

These are not traps laid by malice. They are echoes of a city that once governed reality itself. They do not punish—they correct.

The Djinn Who Remain

Among the ruins dwell the surviving djinn, those who once served the Celestine Engine with perfect devotion. Their forms have not all endured intact. Some are cracked like mirrors; others weep fire or flicker through moments like broken lanterns. They still attempt to execute long-dead protocols, enforcing patterns no longer relevant, seeking to "repair" a reality that now resists their efforts.

To them, freedom is not a virtue—it is a flaw. Mortal unpredictability is not potential—it is corruption.

Their warnings are as terrifying as they are sincere:

> "*Do not defy the Script. Do not seek freedom. It is not written.*"

Some fight adventurers directly. Others offer bargains, laced with logic too alien to fully trust. All are dangerous—not because they are evil, but because they are obedient to a system that is no longer whole.

Where No Prophets Speak

Tuesday, June 3, 2025 11:06 PM

As remembered in the "Verses of the Dust-Singers"

They named it Thamurat, Crown of the Sky,
Forged in brass and fire's cry.
Upon no mountain did it rest—
It wore sunlight as gilded crest.

Jannat al-Sirr, the wise-men swore,
A paradise behind sealed door.
Where thoughts took shape and fate inscribed,
And mortal fears were cast aside.

But proudest name by far, they say,
Was one no tongue should dare relay.
Qahirat al-Aqdar, writ in flame—
The Subjugator's hallowed name.

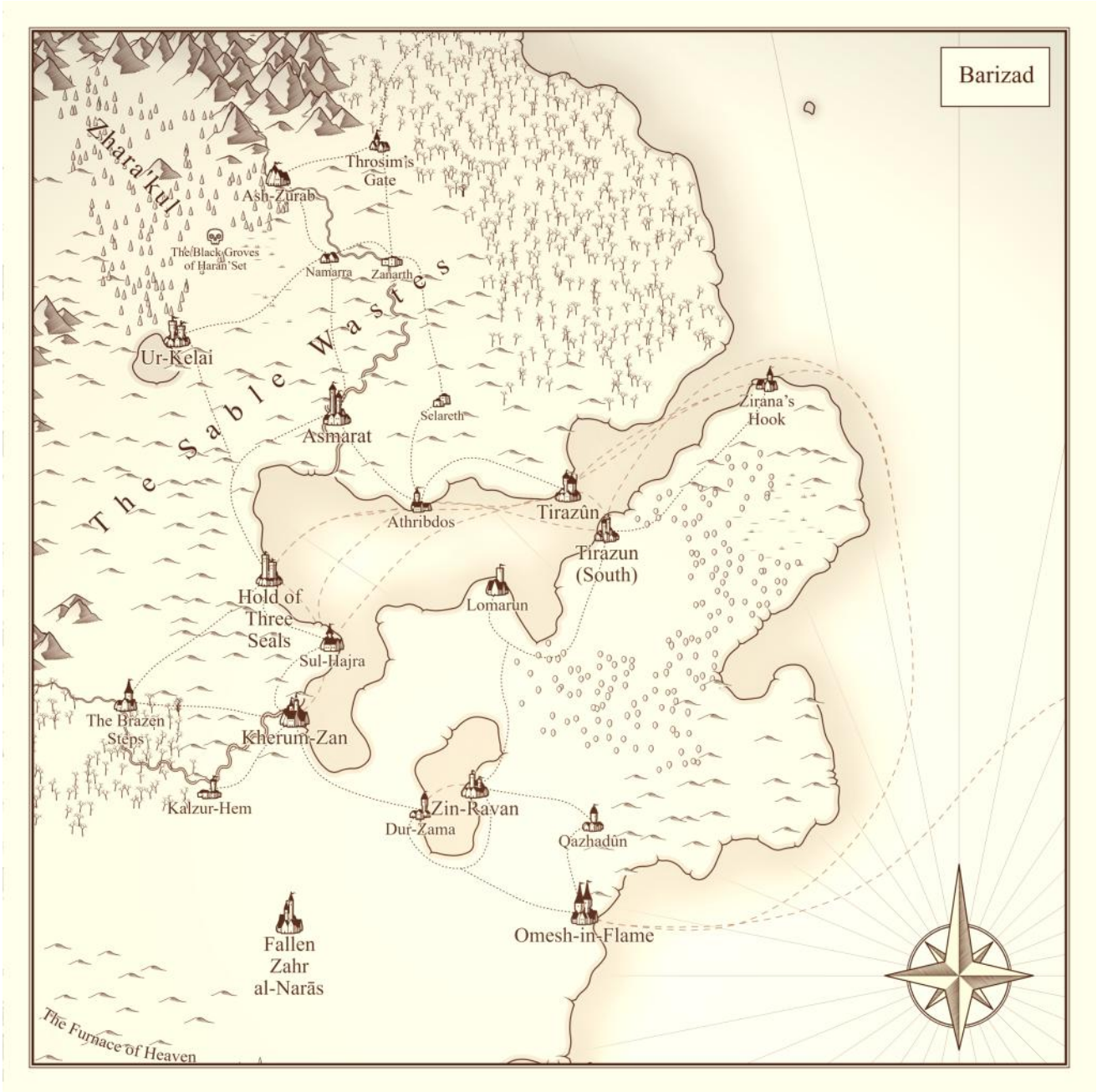
There dwelt Sirr al-Nar, the Flame Undimmed,
His voice like bells, his eyes like hymns.
He drank from dreams, he broke the chain,
That fate might serve his searing reign.

He claimed a forge of glass and gears—
The Celestine Furnace, font of years.
And there he said to ambition sate:
"Let none but I now master fate."

He bound the future, gagged the stars,
Sealed prophecy behind brass bars.
No seers could speak, nor visions fly—
He ruled tomorrow with a lie.

Then silence cracked the sky in twain.
The Wheel of Heaven groaned in pain.
And like a stone thrown from fate's own pyre,
The city fell in molten fire.

Now nothing lives where once it shone,
But sand that sings and brass half-gone.
The seers weep, the gods are still—
And fate rolls on, beneath no will.

World Map

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